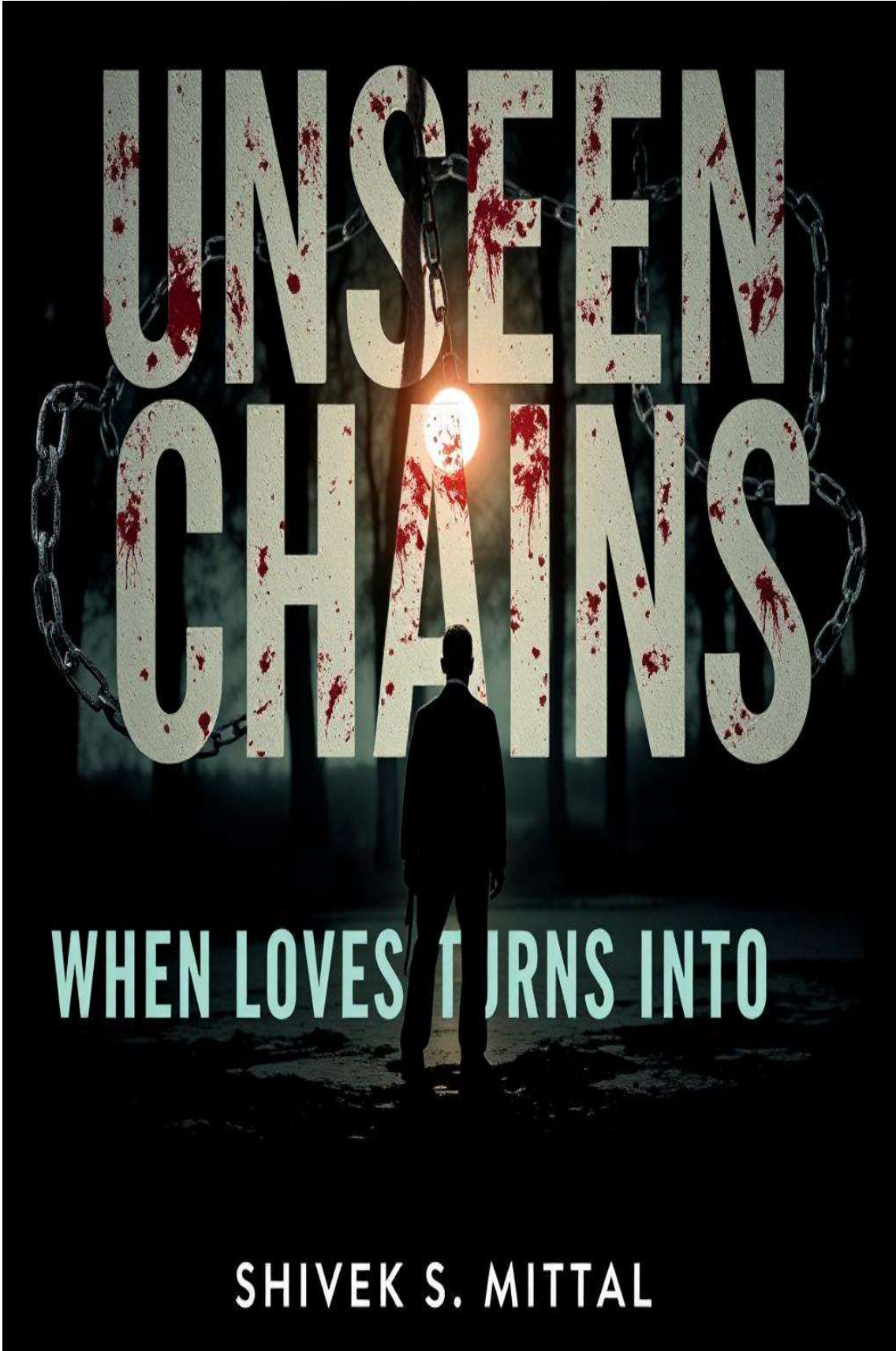




UNSEEN CHAINS

WHEN LOVES TURNS INTO

SHIVEK S. MITTAL

First Sight

Ethan Carter sat in the grand, sunlit auditorium of Woodbridge Academy, his family's name etched into one of the brass plaques adorning the walls. The private school was the pinnacle of prestige, and his parents' philanthropy ensured that his name carried weight in every hallway and classroom. Beneath the vaulted ceilings and glittering chandeliers, Ethan adjusted his immaculate blazer, custom-tailored to fit his tall frame.

But even with all the trappings of wealth and privilege, Ethan felt an unshakable hollowness. The assembly droned on—a lecture about leadership and the importance of tradition—yet Ethan barely registered the words. Instead, he stared blankly ahead, his polished shoes tapping a steady rhythm against the marble floor.

Then he heard it—a laugh, soft yet piercing, like the chime of a silver bell cutting through a fog.

His head snapped up, and his breath caught. There she was, seated three rows ahead, leaning slightly toward her friend. Her delicate features lit up as she laughed at some whispered joke, her golden hair catching the afternoon sunlight filtering through the towering windows.

Ethan couldn't look away. His heart, long accustomed to a monotonous rhythm, stuttered into something frantic. His life had been an endless parade of privilege—wealth, respect, admiration—but in that moment, all of it felt empty compared to the girl in front of him.

Samantha Hayes.

He didn't know her name yet, but something about her made his chest tighten. She was radiant in her simplicity, unburdened by the weight of expectations that pressed down on him daily. She laughed freely, carelessly, as if the world was hers to command.

Ethan's gaze hardened. She *should* be his.

The rest of the assembly blurred into nothingness as he watched her. Every flick of her wrist, every turn of her head felt deliberate, like a carefully crafted melody just for him. The thought settled deep in his chest—a strange, possessive ache that felt both thrilling and suffocating.

His fingers tightened on the edge of his seat, nails digging into the polished wood. There was something magnetic about her, something he couldn't explain but

UNSEEN CHAINS

knew he couldn't let go of. For the first time in his charmed, controlled life, Ethan wanted something desperately.

And he always got what he wanted.

When the assembly ended, the applause rose around him like static, but Ethan remained seated, his eyes locked on Samantha as she stood and gathered her things. She smiled at her friend, her laugh echoing faintly in the vast hall, and turned toward the exit.

Ethan watched her leave, every step a dagger to his chest. He had to follow her, to know her, to make her understand what she had stirred within him.

For now, though, he remained frozen in his chair, gripping the armrests so tightly they creaked under the pressure. His perfect world had shifted in an instant, and he didn't yet know if it was for better or worse. He didn't even know that his story wasn't his anymore. All he knew was that Samantha Hayes belonged to him. Even if she didn't know it yet.

Ethan lingered in the hallway long after the other students had filed out. His heart still raced from the sight of her, a sensation unfamiliar and exhilarating. He wasn't sure what it was about Samantha Hayes that gripped him so tightly, but the answer seemed both unimportant and inevitable.

Sliding his hands into his pockets, Ethan stepped toward the bustling corridors of Woodbridge Academy. The usual cacophony of chatter and laughter filled the air, students swapping notes or debating plans for the weekend. It was all white noise to him now. His eyes darted, searching for her, and there she was—an effortless beacon amid the chaos.

Samantha leaned against a locker, chatting with her friend. Her bag, a faded blue canvas satchel, dangled from her shoulder, and she fiddled absently with a loose strand of her hair as she spoke. Everything about her seemed unpolished, natural, and Ethan found it maddeningly captivating.

He kept his distance, careful not to draw attention. His height made him hard to miss, but his quiet demeanour often rendered him invisible. From the far corner of the hallway, he observed her, cataloguing every detail—the way her lips curved slightly upward when she wasn't smiling, the faint freckles dusted across her cheeks.

“Hey, Ethan!”

The voice jolted him out of his reverie. He turned sharply to see Jacob, a classmate and fellow legacy student, striding toward him.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“You coming to practice later?” Jacob asked, his tone casual but his posture expectant.

Ethan’s jaw tightened. The school rugby team, like most things in his life, had been chosen for him—a legacy tradition passed down through generations of Carter men. Yet it felt like a costume he wore for others.

“Maybe,” Ethan replied curtly, his gaze sliding back to Samantha.

Jacob followed his line of sight and smirked. “Samantha Hayes, huh?” he said, leaning closer. “Cute, isn’t she? Bit out of your league, though.”

Ethan’s stomach churned. Jacob’s words were meant to tease, but they landed like a taunt. He forced a smile, masking the flicker of rage that sparked in his chest.

“She seems nice,” Ethan said evenly, though his voice felt distant, detached.

Jacob shrugged, patting Ethan on the shoulder. “Well, good luck with that. She’s got the whole school wrapped around her finger.” With a laugh, he walked off, leaving Ethan standing rigid in the hallway.

Ethan turned back to Samantha, now laughing again at something her friend had said. She was radiant, her presence filling the space like sunlight piercing through a storm. But the more he watched, the more a gnawing thought burrowed into his mind: **What if she never noticed him?**

The idea festered, ugly and insistent. For someone like Ethan Carter, used to the world bending to his will, the possibility felt unbearable.

As Samantha and her friend walked off, Ethan found himself trailing a safe distance behind. He told himself it was innocent, that he just wanted to see where she was going. But deep down, a darker truth began to surface—a truth he wasn’t ready to face yet.

She didn’t even glance back as she turned a corner, disappearing into the library. For a moment, Ethan stood there, frozen. Then he moved toward the library doors, his pulse quickening.

Something was shifting inside him, something he couldn’t explain but didn’t want to stop.

The library was hushed, the usual bustle of the hallways replaced by the faint rustle of pages and the low hum of the air conditioning. Ethan stepped inside, his polished shoes muffled by the thick carpet. The scent of old books mingled with floor polish, an oddly sterile atmosphere that did little to quell the rapid beating of his heart.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He saw her instantly. Samantha was seated at a long oak table near the windows, her bag resting on the chair beside her. A textbook lay open in front of her, her head tilted slightly as she scribbled something in her notebook. Sunlight streamed in through the tall windows, bathing her in a warm glow.

Ethan lingered near the entrance, his fingers twitching at his sides. He wasn't sure why he had followed her here. It wasn't as though he had anything to say, but he couldn't shake the pull she had over him.

For a moment, he considered leaving. What would he even do? Walk up to her and say hello? But the thought of walking away felt unbearable, like tearing himself away from something vital.

Instead, he moved deeper into the library, keeping to the edges, his movements deliberate and silent. He settled into a corner seat, positioned perfectly to watch her without being noticed.

From this angle, he could see every detail—the slight furrow of her brow as she concentrated, the way she chewed the end of her pen absently. His mind raced with questions. What was she studying? What did her handwriting look like? Did she know how utterly captivating she was?

Ethan leaned forward slightly, resting his chin on his hand. For the first time in years, he felt something close to joy, a strange and consuming joy that filled him to the brim. She was perfect.

But then a shadow crossed his thoughts. It wasn't enough to watch her. Watching her felt passive, like staring through a shop window at something he couldn't touch. She needed to know him, to see him.

The thought lingered, heavy and insistent.

Samantha shifted in her seat, brushing her hair behind her ear. Her pen rolled off the table and clattered to the floor. She leaned down to retrieve it, and in that brief moment, Ethan's hand clenched into a fist.

He imagined walking over to her, imagined the look of surprise on her face when she saw him standing there. Would she smile? Would she laugh? Or would she recoil?

The idea of rejection sent a jolt of rage through him, quick and sharp.

No, he told himself. She wouldn't reject him. She just didn't know him yet.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Before he could spiral further, Samantha stood, gathering her things. She tucked her notebook and textbook into her bag, slinging it over her shoulder. Ethan's heart dropped as she walked toward the exit.

He hesitated for a moment before following, his steps light and soundless.

The hallway beyond the library was quiet, the late afternoon sun casting long shadows across the floor. Samantha didn't look back as she made her way to the parking lot. Ethan slowed his pace, staying just far enough behind that he could see her but wouldn't be noticed.

She stopped at a sleek black car—a gift, no doubt, from doting parents. She unlocked the door and slid into the driver's seat, the faint sound of music escaping as the door opened and closed.

Ethan stood at the edge of the lot, hidden behind a row of trees. His breath came in shallow gasps, his chest tightening as her car pulled away.

He had no reason to feel this way. They hadn't spoken a single word, yet the thought of her leaving, of being out of his sight, felt unbearable.

His fingers brushed against the rough bark of the tree beside him, and a dark thought took root.

He needed to know more. Where she lived, what she liked, who she spent her time with. It wasn't enough to see her from afar. He had to become part of her world.

The thought didn't scare him. If anything, it felt natural—like the first step toward something inevitable.

Ethan spent the rest of the evening replaying every moment he'd observed Samantha. Her laugh, the way she brushed her hair back, the faint pink flush of her cheeks as she smiled—it was all burned into his mind like an endless reel of film.

In his room, surrounded by perfectly ordered furniture and expensive trinkets, he sat at his mahogany desk. A notebook lay open in front of him, its blank pages taunting him. He reached for a fountain pen—his father's gift for his sixteenth birthday—and began writing.

Samantha Hayes.

The name looked strange on the page, almost too simple for someone so extraordinary. He underlined it once, then twice, his hand pressing harder with each stroke.

UNSEEN CHAINS

His mind wandered to her car, the shiny black paint gleaming under the afternoon sun. He'd seen the license plate—had memorized it, in fact.

BLK-738.

He jotted it down, the ink smudging slightly under his impatient hand. It was a small detail, but it felt significant. A piece of her world, now captured in his.

Ethan leaned back in his chair, his eyes scanning the room. His life was immaculate, every corner of his existence polished to perfection. His family's wealth and reputation ensured that no door was ever closed to him, yet he'd never felt this kind of hunger before.

Samantha wasn't like the other girls at Woodbridge Academy—girls who giggled and flirted with him, hoping to bask in the Carter name. She didn't seem to care about social status or appearances. That made her special.

No, it made her **his**.

He closed the notebook carefully, sliding it into the top drawer of his desk. Then, with a sudden, almost compulsive urgency, he stood and walked to his closet.

From the back of the shelves, he retrieved an old camera, one of the vintage models his father collected. It was heavy in his hands, the leather strap worn smooth from use. He checked the lens, adjusting it with practiced precision.

The idea of watching her through the lens made his heart race. It wasn't enough to simply see her; he needed to preserve her moments, to keep them safe from time.

His phone buzzed on the desk, snapping him out of his thoughts. He glanced at the screen.

Dad: "Meeting with the board tomorrow. Be there at 10 sharp. Presentation ready?"

Ethan's jaw clenched. His father's texts always carried the weight of expectation, like chains wrapped tightly around his chest. There was a time when he'd tried to meet those expectations, to be the perfect son, but now it felt like another life.

He tossed the phone onto his bed, ignoring the message. Samantha occupied every corner of his mind now, and nothing else mattered.

The next day, Ethan arrived at school earlier than usual. The hallways were nearly empty, the faint hum of fluorescent lights the only sound. He liked the stillness, the way the world felt suspended in time.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He made his way to Samantha's locker. It was easy to spot—he'd memorized the number and the small sticker of a daisy she'd placed on the corner. Standing in front of it, he felt a strange sense of possession, as if this small, mundane object was an extension of her.

Without thinking, he reached out, his fingers brushing the cold metal. He imagined opening it, finding something personal—a book, a note, something she'd touched. The thought sent a shiver down his spine.

He froze when he heard footsteps approaching. Quickly, he stepped back, blending into the shadows near the stairwell. A girl rounded the corner, humming to herself, and didn't notice him as she passed.

Ethan let out a breath he hadn't realized he was holding. His heart was pounding, but not with fear. The rush of almost being caught filled him with a twisted exhilaration.

This was only the beginning.

Ethan felt the camera's weight in his bag all day, its presence a constant reminder of the boundary he was about to cross. The world outside might have seen him as composed, polite, even enviable, but beneath the surface, something far darker stirred.

When the final bell rang, students spilled into the hallways, their voices bouncing off the polished marble floors. Ethan lingered near the lockers, his eyes scanning the crowd. Samantha's daisy sticker glinted under the harsh overhead lights, drawing his attention like a beacon.

She appeared moments later, weaving through the throng of students with an effortless grace. Her hair shimmered under the sunlight streaming through the windows, and her laughter, faint but distinct, sent a jolt through his chest.

Ethan ducked his head, pretending to check his phone as she approached her locker. Her fingers danced over the dial of the lock, twisting it with a practiced ease.

He waited until she'd left the building before following, keeping his distance as she walked to the student lot. This time, he was ready.

The trees lining the edge of the lot provided perfect cover. Ethan crouched behind a thick trunk, his hands steady as he lifted the camera to his eye. The world narrowed to the small frame of the viewfinder, where Samantha stood beside her car, searching her bag for her keys.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He adjusted the focus, the lens zeroing in on her face. She looked serene, her lips moving slightly as if humming a tune. Ethan's finger hovered over the shutter, and for a moment, he hesitated.

What he was doing felt intimate, like peeling back a layer of her world that wasn't meant for him. But the thought of stopping never occurred to him. Instead, he pressed the shutter, the faint click of the camera lost in the hum of distant traffic.

The first photo captured the slight furrow of her brow as she concentrated on her bag. The second froze the moment she smiled, likely finding what she was looking for.

Each photo felt like a small triumph, a piece of her that he could keep.

She climbed into her car and drove away, and Ethan lowered the camera, his hands trembling slightly. His heart raced, a mix of adrenaline and something darker coursing through him.

As he walked back to his own car, he replayed the sound of the shutter in his mind. It was a sound he decided he liked, a sound he wanted to hear again.

That night, Ethan sat at his desk, the photos spread before him like pieces of a puzzle. The images weren't perfect—the light was off in some, and her movements had blurred others—but they were enough.

He traced the outline of her face with his finger, the glossy surface of the photo cool under his touch. She looked so peaceful, so unaware.

Ethan smiled to himself. This was how it had to be—gentle, careful. He couldn't risk scaring her away. Not yet.

His phone buzzed again, and this time, he ignored it entirely. The world outside didn't matter anymore. Samantha was his world now.

The next day, Ethan arrived at school before dawn, the campus still shrouded in mist. He parked near the faculty lot, where the early hour ensured he'd go unnoticed.

His plan was simple, almost laughably so. He wasn't sure why he hadn't thought of it before.

Samantha's locker wasn't locked in the way he'd expected; she only spun the dial halfway after closing it. It wasn't unusual—many students did the same, trusting the school's atmosphere of safety.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's hands were steady as he approached, his footsteps muffled by the thick carpet of the hallway. He glanced over his shoulder, confirming he was alone, and then slid the locker open.

The faint smell of perfume greeted him, a floral sweetness that made his head spin. Inside, her books were stacked neatly, their spines worn and annotated. Her bag hung from a hook, and a small compact mirror rested on the top shelf.

He reached for the mirror, turning it over in his hand. It was scratched along the edges, a mundane object that carried an intimate weight. He slipped it into his pocket, his heart pounding with the thrill of the act.

Ethan closed the locker quietly, his movements practiced and deliberate. The hallway remained silent, the morning sun creeping through the windows.

Ethan couldn't shake the feeling of Samantha's mirror in his pocket. As he walked to his next class, the cool metal pressed against his thigh, a secret weight that made his every step deliberate.

The knowledge that he now possessed something of hers—something she touched daily—sent an intoxicating thrill through him. It was as though he'd taken a piece of her world and anchored it to his own.

But he needed more.

The classroom buzzed with the low hum of conversation as students shuffled into their seats. Ethan took his usual spot near the window, pulling out a notebook to feign attention. His classmates spoke in muted tones about weekend plans, parties, and the latest gossip, but Ethan's focus was elsewhere.

Samantha entered a few minutes later, her bag slung casually over one shoulder. She wasn't alone—her friend, a tall brunette with an easy smile, walked beside her. They slipped into seats near the front, their heads bent close as they whispered and laughed.

Ethan's hand tightened around his pen.

It wasn't jealousy—not exactly—but the sight of her smiling at someone else filled him with a simmering unease. He should have been the one sitting beside her, sharing in those quiet moments. Instead, he was stuck here, an outsider looking in.

His pen scratched against the paper, the ink bleeding into jagged lines that twisted and coiled. He wasn't drawing anything specific—just an outlet for the restless energy building inside him.

UNSEEN CHAINS

After class, Ethan waited by the door, his movements unhurried. Samantha and her friend passed by, their laughter like a private melody.

He followed at a distance, careful to blend into the crowd. She turned toward the library, her usual haunt during lunch, and Ethan's chest tightened with anticipation.

This time, he didn't linger in the shadows. Instead, he walked to a table near hers, placing himself just within her line of sight. He opened a textbook, pretending to study, but his eyes flicked to her constantly.

She didn't notice him—or if she did, she gave no indication. Her focus remained on her notebook, her pen moving in steady, fluid strokes.

Ethan's gaze drifted to the edge of her sleeve, where a bracelet glinted faintly under the fluorescent light. It was simple—just a silver chain with a small charm dangling from it—but to him, it was perfect. He imagined wrapping the chain around his fingers, feeling its weight as he held it in his palm.

His breath hitched.

That evening, Ethan sat in his room, the mirror resting on the desk in front of him. He'd cleaned it meticulously, wiping away the smudges until it gleamed. The scratches along the edges didn't bother him; they gave it character.

He turned it over in his hands, watching the way the light refracted off the surface. His reflection stared back at him, distorted and warped.

"It's not enough," he muttered to himself. His voice sounded strange in the quiet room, like it belonged to someone else.

He opened his notebook and flipped to a blank page. His pen hovered for a moment before he began writing.

Samantha Hayes.

The letters sprawled across the page, looping and twisting into a tangled mess. He underlined her name, the ink pressing deep into the paper, and then began listing everything he knew about her.

- Favourite colour: Blue (her bag)
- Usual lunch spot: Library
- Bracelet: Silver chain

UNSEEN CHAINS

The list grew longer as he wrote, each detail a thread in the web he was weaving. When he finished, he stared at the page, his chest swelling with a strange mix of pride and longing.

He closed the notebook, his hand lingering on the cover. Tomorrow, he decided, he would add more to his collection.

The thought filled him with a quiet certainty, as though it were the most natural thing in the world.

The next day, Ethan arrived at school before anyone else. The hallways were deserted, bathed in the faint glow of emergency lights. He moved with purpose, his footsteps muted against the tile floor.

Samantha's locker stood in its usual place, the daisy sticker catching the faint light. Ethan approached it slowly, his hand brushing over the metal. His pulse quickened as he slid it open, the scent of her perfume wafting out like an unspoken invitation.

He rummaged carefully, not wanting to disturb the arrangement. A textbook with her name scrawled neatly on the inside cover caught his eye, but it was a smaller, more intimate object that made his breath hitch—a hairbrush tucked into the corner of the locker, strands of her golden hair tangled in the bristles.

Ethan's fingers trembled as he picked it up. He ran his thumb along the handle, feeling the smooth plastic warm under his touch. This was something of hers, something she touched every day.

He slipped the brush into his bag, closing the locker quietly before stepping back. The hallway remained silent, as if holding its breath.

During class, Ethan couldn't focus. His thoughts were consumed by the brush sitting in his bag. He imagined her using it that morning, running it through her hair as she got ready for school.

Samantha sat two rows ahead, her head tilted slightly as she took notes. The sunlight filtering through the windows lit up her hair, making it shimmer like gold. Ethan stared, his pen hovering over a blank notebook page.

It wasn't enough. Watching her, following her—it wasn't enough anymore. He needed something more, something permanent.

That afternoon, Ethan skipped practice. Instead, he drove to a small craft store on the edge of town, its neon sign flickering faintly in the dusk.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The bell above the door jingled as he entered, the sharp scent of paint and glue filling the air. He wandered the aisles aimlessly until he found what he was looking for—a shadow box, simple and elegant, with a glass front.

The cashier barely looked at him as he paid, and Ethan was grateful for it. The box felt heavy in his hands as he walked to his car, the faint click of his shoes on the pavement echoing in the stillness.

That night, he placed the brush inside the shadow box, arranging it carefully. He added the mirror, propping it against the back wall so that it reflected the brush's handle. The effect was mesmerizing, the items seeming to float in the dim light of his desk lamp.

Ethan sat back, his arms resting on the edge of the desk. A strange sense of satisfaction filled him, a quiet certainty that he was building something important.

The shadow box wasn't just an object anymore—it was an altar. Each piece he added felt like a sacred act, binding him closer to Samantha in ways the rest of the world couldn't understand.

Late at night, Ethan would sit at his desk, staring at the items he'd gathered. The pen, the mirror, the folded note—they were ordinary things, yet they pulsed with life, as if they carried a piece of her soul. He found himself reaching out to touch them, his fingertips brushing against the glass as if to close the distance between them.

But the shrine wasn't enough. It could never be enough.

The next morning, Ethan arrived at school with a new plan.

Samantha's routine had become predictable. She always arrived ten minutes before the first bell, parking in the same spot, walking the same path to her locker. Ethan's familiarity with her movements was unsettling even to himself, but he couldn't stop. He didn't want to.

He waited near the stairwell, the shadowy corner offering a perfect vantage point. The hallway was quiet, the students still trickling in. Then he saw her—a flash of blonde hair, the faint jingle of her keys as she walked.

Ethan stepped out of the shadows, timing his movements perfectly.

"Samantha," he said, his voice steady despite the pounding in his chest.

She turned, her eyes meeting his for the first time.

For a moment, the world stopped.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Yes?” she said, her tone polite but distant.

Ethan’s mind raced. He hadn’t planned what to say, but he couldn’t let the opportunity slip away.

“Sorry—I think you dropped this,” he said, holding out a pen he’d swiped from her locker the day before.

Samantha blinked, her brows furrowing slightly. She hesitated before taking it, her fingers brushing against his.

“Oh, thanks,” she said, offering a small smile. “I didn’t even realize I lost it.”

Ethan nodded, his throat dry. He wanted to say more, to make her stay, but the words stuck in his mouth.

Samantha turned and walked away, the moment slipping through his fingers like sand.

That brief interaction consumed his thoughts for the rest of the day. The sound of her voice, the way her eyes had flicked to his hand when she took the pen—it all played on a loop in his mind.

Ethan knew it wasn’t enough. It would never be enough.

That afternoon, he followed her again.

Samantha was easy to follow, her habits like clockwork. After school, she stopped by the coffee shop near campus, her favourite spot to study. Ethan waited outside, his heart pounding as he watched her through the glass.

She sat at a small table near the window, her notebook open and her hair tucked behind one ear. A cup of coffee steamed beside her, the faint swirl of vapor catching the sunlight.

Ethan’s fingers twitched. He wanted to go inside, to sit across from her and pretend to be a stranger who’d stumbled upon her by chance. But the thought of rejection—the possibility that she might see through him—held him back.

Instead, he stayed outside, his breath fogging the glass as he watched.

He told himself it wasn’t creepy. He was just...observing.

UNSEEN CHAINS

That night, Ethan added a new item to the shadow box: a napkin from the coffee shop, the faintest trace of her lipstick still visible on the edge. He'd waited until she left to swoop in, pretending to clear the table so no one would suspect him.

The napkin smelled faintly of vanilla and cinnamon, a mix of her perfume and the coffee she drank. Ethan inhaled deeply, his eyes closing as the scent filled his lungs.

He placed it carefully in the box, the fabric folding gently against the other items.

The shrine was growing, but it wasn't enough.

Ethan's fixation began to spill into other parts of his life. At home, his father's lectures about legacy and responsibility became little more than white noise. The family dinners, the weekend functions—they all blurred together, irrelevant distractions in the face of his obsession.

He spent every waking moment planning, thinking, watching.

One day, he decided to test the limits of his reach.

In the school's administrative office, filing cabinets lined the walls, each drawer labelled with the names of students. Ethan had seen the secretary leave for lunch, her desk empty and the door ajar.

His pulse quickened as he slipped inside, closing the door behind him. The room smelled faintly of paper and ink, the hum of the copier the only sound.

Ethan moved quickly, his hands steady as he searched for the drawer marked **H**.

There it was.

He opened it slowly, the metal sliding noiselessly on well-oiled tracks. Samantha's file sat near the front, her name printed neatly on the tab.

Ethan pulled it out, his eyes scanning the pages.

- Address: **34 Willow Lane**
- Birthdate: **May 14**
- Emergency Contact: **Rachel Hayes (Mother)**

The details felt intimate, almost too personal, but Ethan didn't stop. He memorized the address, the emergency contacts, the faint details of her life scribbled in black ink.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Before he left, he made a copy of the page with her address, tucking it into his pocket.

That night, Ethan drove past her house for the first time.

The small, white-panelled home sat nestled at the end of a quiet cul-de-sac, the porch light casting a soft glow on the lawn. Ethan parked down the street, his car's lights off, and watched.

Through the window, he could see her moving inside, her silhouette faint but unmistakable.

This was where she lived. Where she slept.

Ethan clenched the steering wheel, his jaw tightening. He was closer than ever, yet it still wasn't enough.

Ethan returned to Willow Lane the next night, this time under the cover of darkness. The moon hung low in the sky, casting pale light over the quiet neighbourhood.

He parked his car several blocks away, his footsteps silent against the cracked pavement as he approached Samantha's house. The air was crisp, the faint scent of pine mingling with the dampness of fallen leaves.

From his vantage point behind a large oak tree, he could see into her bedroom window. The curtain was pulled back just enough to reveal her desk, cluttered with books and papers.

Ethan crouched lower, his breath fogging the air as he watched. The faint glow of her desk lamp illuminated her silhouette. She was writing, her pen moving quickly across the page.

He imagined what she might be writing—a diary entry, perhaps, or a letter to a friend. The thought of her documenting her private thoughts, unaware of his presence, sent a shiver down his spine.

Ethan's hand brushed against the camera hanging around his neck. He hadn't intended to bring it, but now it felt like fate.

The soft click of the shutter broke the stillness.

He captured her in fragments—the curve of her neck as she tilted her head, the delicate outline of her profile. Each photo felt like a stolen secret, a piece of her world that only he could possess.

The rush of it made his head spin.

UNSEEN CHAINS

For the next week, Ethan visited Willow Lane nightly. He knew her routine by heart now—when she turned off the light, when she opened the window to let in the cool evening air.

He began leaving small tokens near her porch: a single flower, a folded note with no words, just her name written in his precise handwriting.

He told himself it was harmless, a way of expressing his feelings without frightening her. But deep down, he knew the truth.

He didn't want to be noticed. Not yet.

It was a Friday night when Ethan finally crossed the line.

The school was empty, the halls silent as he made his way toward Samantha's locker. His footsteps echoed faintly, each step heightening the thrill coursing through him.

This time, he wasn't just taking something. He was leaving something behind.

Ethan reached into his bag and pulled out an envelope. Inside was a photo—a picture he'd taken of her at the coffee shop, her head bent over her notebook, the light catching the strands of her hair.

He hesitated for a moment, his fingers brushing over the glossy surface. Then, with careful precision, he slid the photo into the narrow slats of her locker.

It wasn't enough to watch her from afar anymore. She needed to know someone was watching.

As he turned to leave, a faint sound caught his attention—the distant creak of a door.

Ethan froze, his heart pounding.

"Hello?"

The voice was soft but firm, and it sent a jolt of panic through him. He glanced toward the end of the hall, where a shadow stretched across the floor.

For a moment, he considered running. But instead, he stepped into the darkness, his movements slow and deliberate.

The shadow disappeared, the sound of retreating footsteps fading into silence.

Ethan exhaled, his hands shaking as he made his way to the exit. The thrill of almost being caught lingered, mingling with the anticipation of what would happen next.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He couldn't stop now.

Samantha was his.

She just didn't know it yet.

The Watcher

The morning air was thick with fog as Ethan parked his car at the edge of Willow Lane. The neighbourhood was still, the kind of eerie quiet that made each sound sharper, louder. Ethan sat in the driver's seat, his fingers drumming an uneven rhythm against the steering wheel.

From here, Samantha's house looked ordinary—white-panelled walls, a garden that was a little overgrown but charmingly so. But to Ethan, it was the epicentre of his world, the place where every thought led.

He had no plan this morning, no reason to be here other than the pull he couldn't resist. The same pull that had kept him awake until dawn, staring at the photos he'd taken the night before.

Through the fog, he saw movement—a figure stepping out of a neighbouring house. Ethan tensed, his grip tightening on the wheel. The man was broad-shouldered, his face obscured by the brim of a baseball cap. He carried a toolbox, his gait slow and deliberate.

The man glanced in Ethan's direction, his eyes narrowing briefly before he turned and walked toward a pickup truck parked in the driveway.

Ethan exhaled. Just a neighbour.

But the interaction left a sour taste in his mouth.

Ethan lingered in his car long after the man disappeared inside the pickup truck. His presence, however brief, had been enough to unravel Ethan's sense of control.

He had spent weeks cultivating the perfect routine—watching Samantha from a distance, learning her patterns, ensuring no one ever saw him. And now this man, this stranger, had stepped into the picture.

Ethan's jaw clenched. **What if he was watching her too?**

The thought gnawed at him, irrational but relentless.

Samantha's bedroom light flickered on, drawing Ethan's attention back to the house. Through the thin curtains, he could make out her silhouette as she moved around the room. She paused by her desk, her head tilting as though reading something.

His pulse quickened. **The note.**

UNSEEN CHAINS

He imagined her finding it, her fingers brushing over the paper, her brow furrowing with curiosity. He wanted her to wonder who had left it, to think about him without knowing it was him.

But another thought intruded, dark and unwelcome. **What if she thought it was from someone else?**

The idea tightened his chest. He couldn't bear the thought of her attention being drawn away, even unknowingly.

Ethan reached for his camera, the weight of it grounding him. He adjusted the lens, focusing on her window. Through the viewfinder, he could see her more clearly—the soft curve of her shoulder, the way her hair fell over her face as she leaned forward.

He snapped a photo, the sound of the shutter muffled but satisfying.

The neighbourhood was coming alive now. Lights flicked on in other houses, and the faint hum of a car engine broke the stillness. Ethan lowered the camera, his muscles tensing as he scanned the street.

The man with the toolbox was back, standing in the driveway of Samantha's house this time. Ethan's stomach churned. The man wasn't working—he was just standing there, looking up at Samantha's window.

Ethan's hand curled into a fist.

He didn't move, didn't call out. He simply watched, his breath shallow as the man stood there for what felt like hours but was likely only seconds. Then, without warning, the man turned and walked back to his truck, slamming the door behind him before driving away.

Ethan's heart raced. His mind spun with questions.

Who was this man? What was his connection to Samantha?

He gripped the steering wheel, his knuckles white. For the first time, the fear that someone else might be watching her too filled him with a cold, burning rage.

That night, Ethan sat at his desk, staring at the shadow box. The items inside—her mirror, her hairbrush, the folded note—felt insignificant now, like relics of a past version of himself.

He reached for his notebook, flipping to a blank page. His hand moved quickly, the pen scratching against the paper as he wrote.

Who is he?

UNSEEN CHAINS

The question stared back at him, stark and accusatory. Beneath it, he began listing possibilities, his mind spiralling with paranoia. A friend? A neighbour? Someone she trusted?

Ethan tapped the pen against the desk, his thoughts churning. He couldn't just wait and wonder.

He had to find out

Ethan couldn't sleep that night. His mind replayed the scene over and over—the man standing in Samantha's driveway, his gaze fixed on her window. There was something deliberate about it, something that made Ethan's stomach churn.

He sat at his desk, the notebook still open to the question he'd scrawled hours ago. The faint glow of his desk lamp bathed the room in an amber hue, casting long shadows across the walls.

Who is he?

Ethan's fingers drummed against the edge of the desk. The question clawed at him, each passing moment amplifying the need for an answer.

His gaze shifted to the camera sitting nearby. A thought surfaced, dark and persistent.

If he couldn't figure out who the man was, he would have to make sure the man didn't come back.

The next morning, Ethan arrived at school earlier than usual. The air was cool and damp, the faint scent of rain lingering in the breeze. Students milled about the parking lot, their voices blending into an indistinct hum.

Ethan ignored them. His focus was on Samantha, who had just stepped out of her car. She looked as she always did—effortlessly radiant, her hair loose around her shoulders, her bag slung over one arm.

But Ethan's attention wasn't on her today. It was on her surroundings.

His eyes scanned the parking lot, searching for any sign of the man from the night before.

Nothing.

Ethan exhaled, his grip on his camera loosening slightly. Still, the unease lingered, a knot tightening in his chest.

During lunch, Ethan made his way to the administrative office. He moved quickly, his steps purposeful as he approached the door.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The secretary looked up from her desk, her glasses perched low on her nose. “Can I help you?” she asked, her tone polite but distracted.

Ethan offered a small smile. “I, uh, left my wallet in Mr. Garvey’s class yesterday. He said he’d leave it here for me.”

The secretary frowned slightly, glancing at the small stack of items on her desk. “I don’t see anything here, but you can check the lost-and-found cabinet if you’d like.”

She gestured to a metal cabinet near the back of the room before returning to her work.

Ethan moved toward the cabinet, his pulse quickening. He opened it slowly, pretending to search through the items inside while keeping an eye on the secretary. She was focused on her computer, her fingers clicking steadily against the keyboard.

Satisfied that she wasn’t paying attention, Ethan straightened and turned his focus to the filing cabinet against the far wall.

His hands trembled as he pulled the drawer open, revealing rows of neatly labeled files. He found Samantha’s file easily, his fingers brushing over the tab before pulling it out.

Flipping through the pages, he skimmed over the familiar details: her address, her grades, her emergency contacts. But this time, something new caught his eye—a note attached to the back of the file.

Authorized visitors:

- Rachel Hayes (Mother)
- James Walker (Uncle)

Ethan’s stomach twisted. The name meant nothing to him, but the thought of someone else being authorized to see her made his chest tighten.

He snapped a photo of the note with his phone before slipping the file back into place.

That evening, Ethan parked his car on Willow Lane again. The street was quiet, the houses glowing faintly under the streetlights.

He watched Samantha’s house from a distance, his camera resting on the passenger seat beside him. The thought of the man—James Walker—haunted him, his name circling Ethan’s mind like a vulture.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Was he just her uncle? Or was there something more?

Ethan's grip tightened on the steering wheel. Whoever James Walker was, Ethan couldn't let him get in the way.

Samantha was his.

And anyone who tried to take her away would regret it.

Ethan couldn't stop thinking about the name.

James Walker. It echoed in his mind, circling endlessly, a puzzle he couldn't solve. Who was this man, and why was he listed in Samantha's file?

He tried to rationalize it. Perhaps he was just a relative, someone harmless. But the memory of the man standing in Samantha's driveway—the deliberate way he'd looked at her window—gnawed at him.

Ethan sat in his room, the shadows growing long as the sun dipped below the horizon. His laptop sat open on his desk, the screen glowing faintly.

He hesitated for a moment before typing the name into the search bar.

James Walker.

The results were overwhelming—hundreds of links and profiles, none of them immediately helpful. Ethan clenched his jaw, refining his search. He added the city, the name of the school, anything that might narrow it down.

Finally, he found something.

A local article from two years ago. The headline read: **“Walker Family Mourns Loss of Patriarch.”**

Ethan skimmed the article quickly, his eyes scanning for any mention of Samantha. His breath caught when he saw it:

“James Walker, beloved nephew of the late David Walker, attended the service alongside his sister, Rachel Hayes, and her daughter, Samantha Hayes.”

Nephew.

Ethan leaned back in his chair, his fists clenching at his sides. It wasn't the connection he'd feared, but the article didn't ease his paranoia. If anything, it made things worse.

James Walker was close to Samantha—close enough to attend family events, close enough to be listed in her school records.

UNSEEN CHAINS

And Ethan didn't trust him.

The next day, Ethan arrived at school earlier than usual. The hallways were nearly empty, the fluorescent lights casting a cold, sterile glow. He made his way to the library, his steps slow and deliberate.

Samantha was already there, sitting at her usual table near the window. Her notebook was open, and she was writing something, her pen moving in smooth, fluid strokes.

Ethan lingered near the shelves, pretending to browse as he watched her. She looked peaceful, her brow slightly furrowed in concentration.

For a moment, Ethan felt a strange sense of calm. Just watching her, knowing she was safe, was enough to quiet the storm in his mind.

But then the library door opened, and the calm shattered.

A boy walked in, his presence commanding in a way that made Ethan's stomach churn. He was tall and broad-shouldered, with dark hair and an easy smile that immediately drew attention.

Samantha looked up, and her face lit up with a smile that made Ethan's chest tighten.

"Hey, Liam," she said, her voice warm.

The boy—**Liam**—grinned as he walked over to her table. He dropped his bag onto the chair beside her and leaned in close, saying something that made her laugh.

Ethan's nails dug into the edge of the shelf.

Who was this boy? Why was she smiling at him like that?

The answer didn't matter. What mattered was the way Ethan's blood boiled as he watched them.

That night, Ethan added a new name to his notebook.

Liam.

He stared at the name for a long time, his pen hovering over the page. His mind raced with questions, each one darker than the last.

Who was Liam? How did he know Samantha? And why did he have the power to make her laugh like that?

Ethan closed the notebook slowly, his hands trembling.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Whoever Liam was, Ethan had to find out.

Ethan stared at the name in his notebook: **Liam.**

The boy had appeared out of nowhere, disrupting the fragile sense of control Ethan had built around Samantha. Something about Liam unsettled him—his confidence, the easy way he seemed to command attention without effort.

Ethan flipped to a blank page, his hand moving quickly as he began sketching the boy's face from memory. The sharp line of his jaw, the slight curve of his smirk.

When he finished, he stared at the drawing for a long time. There was something predatory about it, something smug.

Who are you? Ethan thought, his fingers tightening around the edge of the notebook.

The next day, Ethan found himself watching Samantha more closely than usual, searching for any sign of Liam.

He spotted her during lunch, sitting at her usual table in the library. She was alone, her head bent over a book, her pen moving steadily across the page. Ethan felt a strange mix of relief and anticipation.

If Liam was as close to her as he suspected, he'd show up eventually.

Ethan lingered near the shelves, pretending to browse as he kept one eye on Samantha. Minutes passed, then an hour, but Liam never appeared.

Ethan's chest swelled with a twisted sense of triumph. Whatever connection they had, it wasn't enough to keep Liam by her side.

But the thought didn't ease his paranoia. If anything, it fuelled it.

That evening, Ethan returned to social media, combing through Liam's profile for clues. He noted every detail—the sports teams he played for, the classes he took, the places he visited. Each piece of information felt like a thread he could pull, unravelling the boy's life bit by bit.

But the more he learned, the more the unease grew. Liam wasn't just another student. He was popular, well-liked, the kind of person who drew people to him effortlessly.

The kind of person Samantha might be drawn to.

Ethan closed the laptop abruptly, his jaw tightening. He wouldn't let that happen.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The following morning, Ethan arrived at school early, his mind set on one thing: finding Liam.

He spotted him near the gym, surrounded by a group of friends. Liam's laugh rang out above the chatter, easy and unbothered.

Ethan stayed back, watching from a distance. He noted the way Liam carried himself, the way people seemed to gravitate toward him.

But it wasn't until Liam glanced at Samantha across the courtyard—just a fleeting look—that Ethan's unease solidified into something darker.

Ethan's fists clenched.

Whatever Liam wanted; Ethan wouldn't let him have it.

Ethan couldn't shake the way Liam had looked at Samantha. It had been brief—just a passing glance—but to Ethan, it had carried weight, an unspoken message he couldn't ignore.

He sat in his car that evening, parked in a lot across from the school gym. The sun had long since set, and the glow of the gym's lights spilled out into the darkness. Inside, he could see Liam talking with a group of teammates, his posture relaxed, his laugh echoing faintly through the open doors.

Ethan's grip tightened on the steering wheel.

Liam's presence felt like an intrusion, a threat to the fragile world Ethan had built around Samantha.

For weeks, Ethan had been careful—watching from a distance, piecing together her routines, keeping his presence invisible. But now, this boy threatened to undo everything.

Ethan's gaze shifted to the camera sitting on the passenger seat. He hadn't planned to bring it tonight, but now it felt like fate.

The gym doors opened, and Liam stepped out, his duffel bag slung over one shoulder. He lingered near the entrance, scrolling through his phone, oblivious to the figure watching him from the shadows.

Ethan raised the camera, adjusting the lens until Liam's face came into focus. His finger hovered over the shutter, hesitation flickering for a brief moment before the faint click broke the silence.

The photo felt like a small victory, a way to contain Liam's presence, to hold him accountable.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan lowered the camera, his pulse quickening as Liam walked toward the parking lot.

For a moment, he considered following him—seeing where he lived, learning more about his routine. But the thought of leaving Samantha unguarded made his stomach twist.

Ethan stayed where he was, his mind racing.

Later that night, Ethan sat at his desk, the photo of Liam displayed on his laptop screen. He zoomed in, studying the boy's face, searching for some flaw, some weakness he could exploit.

The longer he stared, the more Liam seemed to taunt him.

Ethan's hand curled into a fist. Liam wasn't like him. He didn't see Samantha the way Ethan did. He couldn't possibly understand her the way Ethan did.

He leaned back in his chair, the tension in his chest refusing to ease.

There was only one solution.

Ethan needed to know everything about Liam—his schedule, his friends, his weaknesses. Only then could he protect what was his.

The next day, Ethan shadowed Liam for the first time.

He kept his distance, careful not to draw attention as he followed him through the halls. Liam was easy to track, his loud laugh and confident stride making him stand out in the crowd.

Ethan took note of every interaction—every handshake, every joke, every passing smile. Each moment felt like another piece of the puzzle falling into place.

When lunch came, Ethan watched from the shadows as Liam walked toward the courtyard. Samantha was already there, sitting at a small table near the edge of the lawn.

Ethan's stomach churned as Liam approached her.

"Hey, Samantha," Liam said, his voice carrying easily over the noise of the crowd.

Samantha looked up, her face lighting up with a smile. "Hey, Liam. What's up?"

Ethan's nails dug into his palms as he watched Liam sit down across from her, leaning forward slightly as they talked. Their conversation was light, casual, but every laugh, every glance felt like a dagger to Ethan's chest.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He stayed rooted in place, his breath shallow, his thoughts spiraling.

Liam was getting closer to her.

And Ethan couldn't let that happen.

Ethan stayed rooted in place, hidden in the shadow of the courtyard's stone archway. His eyes never left Samantha and Liam as they laughed together, their voices blending into the hum of student chatter.

Liam leaned closer, his elbow resting on the table as he said something that made Samantha throw her head back with laughter. The sound was light and carefree, but to Ethan, it felt like nails scraping against his nerves.

His hand tightened into a fist, the edge of the stone digging into his palm. Samantha wasn't supposed to laugh like that with anyone else.

Ethan's mind raced. **What did Liam have that he didn't?**

The thought consumed him as he watched Liam's every move—the way he gestured with his hands, the way his smile never wavered. Liam radiated a kind of effortless confidence that made Ethan feel small, invisible.

But Ethan wasn't invisible.

Not to Samantha.

That night, Ethan sat in his room, his desk bathed in the faint glow of his lamp. The shrine he'd built for Samantha felt different now—less like a collection of her essence and more like a mockery of how distant she seemed.

He stared at the photo of Liam on his laptop, his jaw tightening as he studied every detail.

The way Liam had leaned toward Samantha, his casual smirk—it was infuriating. Ethan's fingers hovered over the delete key, but instead, he closed the laptop with a sharp snap. The photo wasn't just an image. It was evidence.

Liam needed to go.

The next day, Ethan set his plan in motion.

He started with the small details, watching Liam closely, noting the way he moved through the day. Liam's schedule was predictable—class, gym, lunch, repeat.

Ethan followed him at a distance, blending into the crowd as he studied his routine. The pieces of Liam's life were falling into place, and with every passing moment, Ethan's resentment grew.

UNSEEN CHAINS

When school ended, Ethan lingered near the parking lot, his camera in hand. Liam walked to his car, throwing his gym bag into the backseat before pulling out his phone. Ethan raised the camera, adjusting the focus until Liam's face filled the frame.

Click.

The sound of the shutter was soft but satisfying, a small victory that sent a jolt of adrenaline through Ethan's veins.

He wasn't sure what he would do with the photos yet, but he knew they would be useful.

That evening, Ethan sat in his car outside Liam's house. The street was quiet, the glow of the streetlights reflecting off the damp pavement.

Liam's car was parked in the driveway, the engine still warm from the short drive home. Ethan watched as Liam stepped inside, the door closing behind him with a muffled thud.

Ethan's hand hovered over the door handle. Part of him wanted to step out, to get closer, to see what Liam's world looked like up close. But the risk was too great.

Instead, he stayed in the shadows, his fingers tracing the outline of the camera resting in his lap.

Liam might have been a threat now, but Ethan was patient. He knew how to wait.

As the hours dragged on, Ethan's thoughts turned darker.

He imagined a world without Liam—a world where Samantha's laughter was reserved only for him. The thought sent a shiver through him, a mix of fear and exhilaration.

This wasn't just about protecting Samantha anymore. It was about claiming what was his.

Ethan couldn't stop replaying the scene in his head: Samantha laughing, her eyes lighting up as Liam leaned closer. It had been hours since he'd seen them together, but the image burned behind his eyelids every time he blinked.

He sat in his room, the shadows stretching across the walls as the clock ticked past midnight. The shrine he'd built for Samantha seemed to mock him now, its carefully arranged items a reminder of how distant she felt.

Ethan's gaze fell on the photo of Liam still displayed on his laptop. His hand twitched toward the trackpad, zooming in on the boy's smirking face.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Liam didn't deserve her.

The thought echoed in his mind, gaining weight with each repetition. Liam was an invader, someone who didn't understand Samantha the way Ethan did. He couldn't let her get swept up by someone so...ordinary.

Ethan leaned back in his chair, his fingers tapping a restless rhythm against the desk. He needed a plan, something to remind Samantha of who truly cared about her.

The next day, Ethan arrived at school early.

The parking lot was nearly empty, the sky still tinged with the pink and orange hues of dawn. He parked in his usual spot and waited, his fingers drumming against the steering wheel.

Liam's car pulled in twenty minutes later, its engine rumbling as it came to a stop near the gym. Liam stepped out, his gym bag slung over one shoulder, and headed inside without a glance toward the other cars.

Ethan followed at a distance, his footsteps silent against the pavement.

Inside the gym, the air smelled of sweat and rubber, the faint squeak of sneakers echoing off the walls. Ethan lingered near the entrance, watching as Liam joined a group of teammates at the far end of the court.

They were laughing, their voices bouncing off the high ceilings. Liam seemed at ease, his movements confident as he dribbled a basketball across the floor.

Ethan's hands clenched into fists.

He turned away, retreating to the shadows near the bleachers. His heart was pounding, a mix of anger and something darker coursing through him.

This was his opportunity.

While the boys were distracted, Ethan slipped into the locker room. The air was cool and still, the rows of lockers stretching out before him like a labyrinth.

He found Liam's locker easily—it was marked with his name, a bold label that felt almost arrogant. Ethan's hand hovered over the lock, his mind racing.

Do it.

The thought wasn't his own, or at least it didn't feel like it. It was a whisper, low and insistent, urging him forward.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's fingers moved quickly, testing the lock's combination. After a few tries, it clicked open, the door swinging outward with a faint creak.

Inside was Liam's gym bag, neatly packed with clothes and other belongings. Ethan rummaged through it, his hands shaking slightly as he searched for something—anything—that could give him an edge.

At the bottom of the bag, he found a small notebook. The pages were filled with notes, some scribbled haphazardly, others carefully written.

Ethan flipped through them quickly, his eyes scanning for anything of importance. One page caught his attention—a list of upcoming games and practices, written in Liam's neat handwriting.

Ethan tore the page out, folding it carefully before slipping it into his pocket.

He closed the locker quietly, his breath coming in shallow gasps.

This wasn't enough, but it was a start.

That night, Ethan sat at his desk, the torn page spread out before him.

He traced the words with his finger, imagining the time Liam must have spent writing them. It was mundane, insignificant, but to Ethan, it felt like a piece of Liam's life he now controlled.

He stared at the page for a long time, his thoughts spiraling.

If Liam was going to stand in his way, Ethan needed to act.

And he wouldn't hesitate.

The next morning, Ethan stared at himself in the mirror. His reflection looked calm, composed—normal. But beneath the surface, his thoughts churned relentlessly.

Liam's name was written in bold letters at the top of his notebook, a growing list of details scrawled beneath it. His schedule, his routines, his interactions with Samantha—Ethan had documented it all.

But knowing wasn't enough anymore.

Ethan's hand brushed against the folded paper in his pocket, the page he'd taken from Liam's gym bag. His chest tightened as he thought of Liam's careless smirk, the way Samantha had smiled at him without hesitation.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The next practice was circled in bold red ink, a date and time seared into Ethan's mind. He knew where Liam would be, when he'd be there, and who would be watching.

No one but me.

Ethan closed the notebook, his jaw tightening.

At school, Ethan kept a low profile. He drifted through the hallways, blending into the background as he watched Liam from a distance.

Liam's laugh echoed down the corridor, loud and carefree, as he joked with a group of friends. Samantha wasn't with him this time, but that didn't ease the knot in Ethan's stomach.

Liam didn't deserve to walk through these halls so easily, as though he owned the world.

Ethan clenched his fists, his nails digging into his palms.

By the time lunch came, his resolve had hardened.

Ethan skipped his afternoon classes, slipping out of the school unnoticed. He drove to the edge of town, where the streets grew quieter, the houses more spaced out.

The small hardware store sat at the corner of an empty lot, its faded sign swaying slightly in the breeze. Ethan parked his car and stepped inside, the bell above the door jingling faintly.

The store was dimly lit, the air smelling faintly of sawdust and oil. Ethan moved quickly, his eyes scanning the shelves until he found what he was looking for.

A small utility knife.

He held it in his hand, feeling the weight of it, the way the blade glinted under the fluorescent light. It wasn't much, but it was enough.

The cashier didn't even glance at him as he paid, her eyes fixed on the small TV behind the counter.

Ethan slipped the knife into his pocket, his heart pounding as he walked back to his car.

That evening, Ethan arrived at the school gym just as the sun was setting. The parking lot was mostly empty, a few cars scattered here and there.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He parked near the edge, his hands gripping the steering wheel as he scanned the lot.

Liam's car was there, its glossy surface catching the fading light.

Ethan stepped out, his movements deliberate as he approached the gym. The faint sound of sneakers squeaking against the floor echoed through the open doors.

He slipped inside, keeping to the shadows as he moved along the edge of the bleachers.

Liam was on the court, dribbling a basketball as he practiced layups. The gym was mostly empty, a few stray players chatting near the sidelines.

Ethan's hand brushed against the knife in his pocket, the cool metal sending a shiver through him.

Not yet.

He sat in the shadows, watching Liam's every move, his mind racing with possibilities.

When practice ended, Ethan followed Liam to the locker room, keeping his footsteps light and measured.

The room was quiet, the air thick with the smell of sweat and detergent. Liam was alone, his teammates having left minutes earlier.

Ethan lingered near the entrance, his breath shallow as he watched Liam rummage through his bag.

The knife felt heavy in his pocket, its presence both comforting and suffocating.

But then Liam's phone buzzed, the sound cutting through the silence. He glanced at the screen, a faint smile crossing his face as he typed a reply.

Ethan froze.

Samantha.

He didn't know for sure, but the thought hit him like a blow. Liam was texting her, laughing with her, pulling her further away.

Ethan's hand tightened around the knife, his knuckles turning white.

For a moment, he considered stepping forward, imagined the look on Liam's face when he realized he wasn't alone.

UNSEEN CHAINS

But the thought of Samantha finding out, of her looking at him with fear instead of admiration, held him back.

Ethan turned and slipped out of the locker room, the weight of the knife still pressing against his leg.

That night, Ethan sat in his room, staring at the knife on his desk.

It gleamed under the light, a reminder of how close he'd come.

But not yet.

Soon.

Ethan's thoughts churned endlessly as he sat at his desk, the knife gleaming under the pale glow of his lamp. It felt alive in the silence of his room, as though it held a will of its own, urging him to finish what he'd started.

He tapped his fingers against the desk, the rhythm erratic and uneven. The image of Liam's smug smile played in his mind, over and over, like a loop he couldn't escape.

Liam wasn't just a rival. He was a threat—a living, breathing obstacle standing between Ethan and Samantha.

Ethan picked up the knife, turning it over in his hand. The blade was cold against his skin, its edge sharp enough to slice through paper with ease.

A part of him felt exhilarated by the thought of removing Liam from the equation, of eliminating the distraction that had pulled Samantha's attention away.

But another part of him hesitated.

Not because of guilt—Ethan had none. But because he didn't want to rush. He needed to be smart, to be careful.

For Samantha.

The next day, Ethan arrived at school earlier than ever. The campus was still shrouded in the soft gray of dawn, the air crisp and damp.

He parked near the far edge of the lot, his car blending into the shadows cast by the trees. From this vantage point, he could see Liam's usual parking spot clearly.

Ethan leaned back in his seat, his fingers drumming against the steering wheel as he waited.

Minutes ticked by. The sky began to lighten, and the first few students trickled into the lot, their laughter and chatter faint in the distance.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Then Liam's car pulled in, its engine rumbling as it slid into its usual spot.

Ethan's pulse quickened. He watched as Liam stepped out, his movements unhurried, his gym bag slung over his shoulder.

Ethan's hand brushed against the knife resting in his pocket, his resolve hardening with each passing second.

Liam disappeared into the gym, and Ethan followed, his footsteps light and deliberate. The faint squeak of sneakers and the hollow echo of bouncing basketballs filled the air as Ethan slipped into the shadows near the bleachers.

From here, he could see Liam on the court, his movements smooth and confident as he practiced layups.

Ethan's hand tightened around the knife in his pocket. His mind raced with possibilities, each one darker than the last.

But then Liam's phone buzzed on the bench, and he jogged over to check it.

The smile that crossed his face was unmistakable—warm, genuine, and all too familiar.

Ethan's chest tightened.

He didn't need to see the screen to know who Liam was texting.

Samantha.

Ethan turned and left the gym, his footsteps heavy against the polished floor. His mind felt like a storm, his thoughts chaotic and unrelenting.

By the time he reached his car, his hands were trembling, his breath coming in shallow gasps.

He sat behind the wheel for a long time, staring out at the empty parking lot as the morning sun crept higher into the sky.

He couldn't wait any longer. Liam needed to go. And Ethan knew exactly how to make it happen.

The Isolation

The cabin stood in the woods like a forgotten relic, its wooden frame warped by time and weather. The roof sagged under the weight of moss and decay, and the windows were smeared with dirt, allowing only the faintest glimmers of sunlight to filter through.

Ethan had stumbled upon it years ago while wandering aimlessly through the forest—a discovery he'd kept to himself ever since. Even back then, when his life was a picture of privilege and perfection, something about the cabin had spoken to him. It felt like a place outside of time, a space where the rules of the world no longer applied.

Now, it had become his sanctuary.

The inside of the cabin was a chaotic mess, a reflection of Ethan's fractured mind. Empty beer bottles littered the floor, remnants from whoever had occupied the space before him. Faded newspapers were scattered across the rotting furniture, their headlines yellowed and blurred by time.

In one corner, Ethan had created a small shrine. The shadow box rested on a makeshift table—a plank of wood balanced on cinder blocks—surrounded by notebooks filled with his sketches of Samantha and Liam. The once-pristine setup had grown messy in recent weeks, papers spilling onto the floor and photographs tacked haphazardly to the walls.

Ethan sat in the center of the room, cross-legged on the dirty wooden floor. The air was thick with the smell of mildew and stale alcohol, but he barely noticed anymore. His focus was on the shadow box, its glass front reflecting the dim light filtering through the grime-covered windows.

Inside were the objects he'd collected: Samantha's hairbrush, the mirror he'd stolen from her locker, and now, photographs of Liam.

Ethan's fingers brushed against the glass as he stared at the items. They were pieces of a puzzle, fragments of a world he was trying to build—a world where Samantha was his, and Liam no longer existed.

The cabin was the only place where Ethan felt truly in control. At school, he had to hide his obsession, forcing himself to blend into the crowd. At home, his father's watchful eyes and constant demands made him feel trapped, suffocated.

But here, in the cabin, he could let the mask slip.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He leaned back against the wall, the wood cool and rough against his shoulders. His notebook rested on his lap, its pages filled with plans and sketches, each one more chaotic than the last.

Ethan flipped to a blank page and began writing.

Liam.

The name stared back at him, stark and accusatory. Beneath it, he started listing everything he knew:

- Practices every Tuesday and Thursday.
- Drives a silver car, license plate 8PL-K32.
- Texts Samantha daily.

Ethan's pen hovered over the page as his thoughts spiraled. He imagined confronting Liam, the boy's confident smirk fading into fear. He imagined Samantha looking at him with gratitude, finally seeing him for who he truly was.

His hand trembled as he underlined Liam's name, the ink pressing deep into the paper.

"This is where it starts," Ethan muttered to himself, his voice low and uneven. The cabin absorbed the words, its silence both oppressive and comforting.

As the sun dipped below the horizon, the cabin grew darker, the shadows creeping across the walls like living things. Ethan lit a small lantern, its flickering flame casting an eerie glow over the room.

He stood and paced, his boots crunching against the broken glass on the floor. His thoughts were a whirlwind, each one pulling him further from reality.

The cabin felt alive now, its walls closing in as if urging him forward. This was where he belonged. This was where everything would come together.

Ethan turned back to the shadow box, his reflection distorted in the glass. His lips curled into a faint, twisted smile.

"Liam doesn't belong," he whispered. "But I'll fix that."

Ethan crouched in the shadows near the park, his breath clouding the air as he adjusted the focus on his camera. Liam sat on a bench not far away, his phone in hand, the faint glow of the screen lighting up his face.

It had been easy to track him here. Liam's routines were predictable—school, practice, and then an hour spent at the park most afternoons. Ethan watched from

UNSEEN CHAINS

the cover of the trees, his heart pounding in a steady rhythm as he snapped a photo.

Click.

The sound was faint, almost imperceptible, but it sent a jolt of satisfaction through Ethan's chest.

From here, Liam seemed ordinary, unremarkable. But Ethan knew better. He'd seen the way Samantha's face lit up when Liam walked into a room, the way she laughed at his jokes.

Ethan's fingers tightened around the camera. Liam wasn't just a boy; he was a threat, a distraction, a **barrier**.

Later that evening, Ethan returned to the cabin. The cold air followed him inside, clinging to his clothes as he slammed the door shut behind him.

The cabin felt alive tonight, its creaking timbers and shifting shadows matching the chaos in Ethan's mind. He tossed his bag onto the floor and dropped into the chair near the shadow box.

The photos he'd taken of Liam sat in a neat stack on the table, their glossy surfaces catching the light of the flickering lantern.

Ethan picked up the top photo, his eyes narrowing as he studied it. Liam looked relaxed, almost smug, his body language radiating confidence. It made Ethan's stomach churn.

"Look at you," Ethan muttered, his voice low and sharp. "So sure of yourself."

He set the photo down and picked up another, this one capturing Liam mid-laugh. The sight of it sent a wave of anger crashing through him.

Ethan grabbed his pen and scrawled across the photo in jagged letters: **You don't belong.**

The hours slipped away as Ethan worked. The cabin grew colder, but he barely noticed, his focus locked on the photos and notebooks spread out before him.

He began piecing together a timeline of Liam's life, his notes meticulous and unrelenting. Every practice, every hangout spot, every interaction with Samantha—it was all there, mapped out in black ink.

Ethan leaned back, his gaze flicking to the shadow box. The items inside seemed to taunt him, reminders of how far he still had to go.

He turned back to the notebook, flipping to a blank page.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Plan:

1. Follow Liam.
2. Gather more details.
3. **Eliminate.**

The last word felt heavy, final. Ethan stared at it for a long time, his hand trembling slightly as he underlined it.

Outside, the wind howled through the trees, rattling the cabin's loose windows. Ethan barely noticed. The cabin was his world now, a space where time didn't matter, where his thoughts could run free.

As the first light of dawn crept through the cracks in the wood, Ethan closed the notebook and leaned back in his chair.

Liam's time was running out.

Samantha frowned as she unzipped her bag, rummaging through its contents. Her pen case, the one with the small sunflower charm, was missing again.

She looked around the library table, hoping it had fallen out, but it was nowhere to be seen.

"Everything okay?" her friend Lily asked, glancing up from her laptop.

"Yeah," Samantha said with a small sigh. "I think I lost my pen case again. Second time this week."

Lily raised an eyebrow. "Maybe it's in your locker?"

"Maybe," Samantha replied, though doubt lingered in her voice.

She tried to brush off the unease creeping up her spine. It wasn't just the pen case. Little things had been going missing lately—a hair clip, a small notebook, even a folded grocery list she swore she'd left on her desk.

It wasn't enough to raise an alarm, but it was enough to make her pause.

Across the library, Ethan sat behind a row of bookshelves, his eyes fixed on Samantha. He could see the faint crease of her brow as she searched her bag, her lips pursed in that way she did when she was focused.

He knew exactly where her pen case was.

UNSEEN CHAINS

It rested in the shadow box back at the cabin, nestled among the other items he'd collected. To Ethan, it wasn't theft—it was preservation. These were pieces of her life, fragments of her world that she didn't even realize she was sharing with him.

He watched as Samantha gave up searching and turned back to her book, her expression softening. Ethan smiled to himself. She was resilient, unbothered by the small inconveniences.

But she didn't understand.

I'm protecting you, Samantha. You'll see it one day.

That evening, Ethan returned to the cabin, the pen case clutched in his hand. He traced the sunflower charm with his thumb, feeling the grooves of the plastic.

It was small and insignificant to anyone else, but to Ethan, it was a treasure. A piece of her.

He placed it carefully inside the shadow box, rearranging the items to make space. The hairbrush, the mirror, the photographs—they all fit together perfectly, a puzzle only Ethan could solve.

He stepped back, admiring his work. The shadow box wasn't just a collection; it was a story. Their story.

But something was missing.

His gaze flicked to the photos of Liam spread out across the table. The sight of them reignited the simmering anger in his chest.

Liam didn't belong in the story. He was an intruder, a disruption.

Ethan clenched his fists, his nails digging into his palms. The cabin seemed to echo his thoughts, its creaking walls and shifting shadows urging him forward.

Liam needed to be removed.

Meanwhile, Samantha stood in front of her locker, staring at the note taped to the inside of the door.

It wasn't threatening—just a piece of paper with her name written in looping, deliberate handwriting.

But something about it felt...wrong.

She pulled it down and stared at it, her brow furrowing. The handwriting wasn't familiar, and there was no other message. Just her name, written over and over again.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Creepy,” Lily said, peering over her shoulder. “Do you think someone’s messing with you?”

Samantha shrugged, though the unease was harder to shake this time. “It’s probably nothing,” she said, folding the note and tucking it into her pocket.

But as she walked to her next class, the feeling of being watched crept over her again, prickling at the back of her neck.

In the cabin, Ethan added a new note to the stack on his desk, the ink still wet as he traced Samantha’s name with his finger.

It wasn’t enough for her to notice him yet—not directly. But she would.

Soon.

The sound of breaking glass echoed through the house, sharp and sudden.

Ethan stood in the living room, his chest heaving as he stared at the shattered remains of the family photo on the floor. His father loomed over him, his face red with frustration, the veins on his neck bulging.

“What the hell is wrong with you, Ethan?” his father bellowed, his voice reverberating off the pristine walls.

Ethan didn’t respond. His fists were clenched at his sides, his nails digging into his palms hard enough to draw blood.

“You’ve been skipping school,” his father continued, his tone rising. “Avoiding your responsibilities, ignoring your future! This family has sacrificed everything for you, and you’re throwing it all away!”

Ethan’s jaw tightened. The words felt distant, hollow, like background noise. His father didn’t understand. How could he?

“I’m not throwing anything away,” Ethan said finally, his voice low but steady.

His father scoffed. “Really? Because from where I’m standing, it looks like you’ve given up on everything that matters. Do you even know what you’re doing with your life?”

Ethan’s gaze flicked to the broken photo on the floor. It had been taken years ago—his parents smiling, their arms wrapped around a younger version of himself. A perfect picture of a perfect family.

But it was all a lie.

“What I’m doing is none of your business,” Ethan said, his tone sharper now.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“None of my business?” His father took a step closer, his fists clenched at his sides. “You live under my roof, Ethan. Everything you do is my business.”

Ethan stepped back, his face twisting into a sneer. “Then maybe I shouldn’t live under your roof anymore.”

The words hung in the air, heavy and unspoken for too long.

His father stared at him, stunned into silence for a brief moment. Then his expression hardened. “If that’s how you feel, then maybe you shouldn’t,” he said coldly.

Ethan didn’t wait for another word. He turned and walked out the door, slamming it shut behind him.

The woods were cold and silent, the faint crunch of Ethan’s boots against the dirt path the only sound.

He didn’t feel angry anymore. The moment he stepped into the forest, the tension in his chest began to ease.

By the time he reached the cabin, his breath was steady, his mind clearer than it had been all day.

He opened the door and stepped inside, the familiar scent of mildew and wood smoke enveloping him. The shadow box gleamed faintly in the lantern light, its contents waiting for him like old friends.

Ethan moved to the table, his hand brushing over the photos and notes scattered across its surface. The cabin wasn’t just a hiding place—it was a sanctuary, a world where he was in control.

The confrontation with his father was already a distant memory, swallowed by the cabin’s embrace.

Ethan picked up his notebook and flipped to a blank page. His pen moved quickly, the words spilling out in uneven lines:

No one understands. No one else sees the truth. Only me. Only Samantha.

The ink smeared slightly under his hand as he underlined Samantha’s name, pressing harder with each stroke.

Ethan leaned back, his eyes drifting to the shadow box. The items inside seemed to glow in the dim light, each one a reminder of how far he’d come.

His father didn’t matter. Liam didn’t matter.

UNSEEN CHAINS

All that mattered was Samantha.

The library was quiet, the faint hum of the air conditioning blending with the soft rustle of turning pages. Ethan sat at his usual spot near the far corner, hidden behind a row of shelves. From here, he had a perfect view of Samantha, who was seated at a table near the window with her friend Lily.

He watched as Samantha tucked a loose strand of hair behind her ear, her pen tapping lightly against her notebook. She was smiling—an easy, carefree expression that made Ethan’s chest tighten.

But it wasn’t the sight of her smile that froze him. It was what she said next.

“Liam is so sweet,” Samantha said, her voice soft but clear.

Ethan’s hand tightened around the edge of the table, his nails digging into the wood.

“He’s been helping me with calculus,” she continued, her smile widening. “I was so stressed about that last test, but he explained everything so well. I actually think I might pass.”

Lily laughed. “That’s because Liam’s secretly a genius. Seriously, though, you two have been spending a lot of time together lately.”

Samantha shrugged, a faint blush creeping into her cheeks. “I guess. He’s just easy to talk to, you know? And he’s funny.”

Ethan felt his pulse pounding in his ears. The words twisted inside him like a blade, each one cutting deeper than the last.

Liam wasn’t just a distraction anymore. He was invading her world, pulling her further and further away.

Ethan left the library without another glance at Samantha, his footsteps heavy against the polished floor.

By the time he reached the parking lot, the cold air stung his face, but it did little to ease the storm raging inside him.

He got into his car, gripping the steering wheel so tightly his knuckles turned white. His mind raced with images of Liam and Samantha together—laughing, talking, growing closer with every passing day.

“No,” Ethan muttered under his breath. “He doesn’t deserve her.”

The cabin was calling him, its isolation and silence the only thing that could quiet his thoughts.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The walk through the woods felt longer this time, each step weighed down by the anger and despair swirling inside him. By the time he reached the cabin, the sun was beginning to set, casting long shadows across the forest floor.

Ethan pushed the door open and stepped inside, the familiar scent of mildew and dust greeting him like an old friend. He moved straight to the shadow box, staring at its contents with a mix of desperation and resolve.

Samantha's pen case, her hairbrush, the notes he'd written—all of it was there, carefully arranged and preserved. But it wasn't enough.

Ethan grabbed his notebook and began scribbling furiously, his handwriting jagged and uneven.

Liam.

The name filled the page, written over and over again until the ink bled through the paper. Beneath it, he scrawled:

He doesn't belong. He needs to go.

Ethan's breathing was ragged, his chest rising and falling as he stared at the words. He thought of Liam's face—the easy smile, the confident posture, the way Samantha spoke about him with warmth in her voice.

Ethan clenched his fists, his nails biting into his skin.

The cabin seemed to close in around him, the walls pressing closer as if echoing his thoughts. This wasn't just about Liam anymore. It was about protecting Samantha, about creating the world she deserved.

And if that meant removing Liam from it, so be it.

Ethan sat in the cabin, the lantern's dim light flickering against the shadow box. The air was thick, heavy with the scent of mildew and stale beer, but Ethan barely noticed. His focus was on the notebook in front of him, the pages filled with fragmented plans and jagged sketches.

He flipped to a clean page, the faint creak of the cabin's wooden floorboards the only sound as he pressed his pen to the paper.

Liam's Schedule:

- Monday: Gym after school, leaves by 6 PM.
- Tuesday: Practice ends at 5:30, goes to the park.
- Wednesday: Late practice, stays until 7.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The list went on, each detail meticulously noted and underlined. Ethan had spent weeks piecing it together, following Liam's every move, and now the plan was beginning to take shape.

Ethan leaned back in his chair, his gaze drifting to the photos pinned to the wall. Most were of Samantha, her face frozen in moments of laughter and concentration, but a few were of Liam.

One photo in particular drew Ethan's attention. It showed Liam at the park, sitting on a bench with his phone in hand. The faint outline of a smile tugged at his lips, his posture relaxed and confident.

Ethan grabbed the photo and held it up to the light, his jaw tightening. He didn't just want Liam gone—he needed him gone.

Outside, the wind howled through the trees, rattling the cabin's loose windowpanes. The sound only fuelled Ethan's thoughts, his mind spiralling as he scribbled across the photo in black ink:

You're not good enough for her.

He set the photo down, his hands trembling slightly as he reached for the utility knife on the table. Its blade caught the lantern light, gleaming sharp and cold.

Ethan traced the edge of the knife with his finger, the weight of it grounding him. It wasn't just a tool—it was a solution, a way to fix everything.

He stood and paced the cabin, his boots crunching against the broken glass and debris scattered across the floor. His thoughts were loud, chaotic, each one pulling him closer to a decision he couldn't take back.

"Liam doesn't belong," Ethan muttered, his voice barely audible over the wind. "He's in the way."

The cabin seemed to agree, its creaking walls echoing his words like a twisted affirmation.

The next day, Ethan arrived at school with a renewed sense of purpose.

He moved through the hallways like a shadow, unnoticed and unbothered as he watched Liam from a distance. The boy was surrounded by friends, his laugh loud and easy, his presence commanding attention wherever he went.

Ethan's chest tightened. Samantha deserved better than that. She deserved someone who saw her, who understood her. Someone like him.

By the time the final bell rang, Ethan had made his decision.

UNSEEN CHAINS

That evening, Ethan returned to the cabin, his bag heavy with supplies. He spread them out across the table: duct tape, gloves, a black hoodie. Each item felt deliberate, necessary, a step closer to solving the problem that had consumed him.

The utility knife sat at the center of the table, its blade gleaming in the lantern light.

Ethan stared at it for a long time, his thoughts whirling. The plan wasn't perfect, but it didn't need to be. All that mattered was the outcome.

Liam would be gone.

And Samantha would finally be safe.

The school was dark and silent, the hallways bathed in the faint glow of the emergency lights. Ethan moved carefully, his footsteps muffled by the rubber soles of his shoes.

He had waited until the janitor's cart disappeared around the corner before slipping through the side entrance. The lock had been easy to bypass—years of privilege had taught Ethan more than just etiquette.

Now, as he crept through the empty corridors, his heart pounded in his chest. The weight of his backpack felt heavier than usual, the supplies inside rattling softly with each step.

Liam's locker was near the gym, a stretch of hallway that always smelled faintly of sweat and disinfectant. Ethan paused at the edge of the corridor, scanning for any signs of movement.

Nothing.

The school was his.

Ethan approached the locker, his breath shallow and measured. Liam's name was printed neatly on the label, a small, mocking reminder of the boy's place in Samantha's life.

Ethan's hand tightened around the utility knife in his pocket. This wasn't about violence—**not yet**. It was about sending a message, shaking Liam's confidence, making him question his safety.

He crouched and pulled a small can of spray paint from his bag. The hiss of the nozzle broke the silence as he worked quickly, painting jagged, uneven letters across the metal door:

STAY AWAY.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan stepped back, his chest heaving as he stared at the words. The message was simple, direct—there would be no mistaking its meaning.

But it wasn't enough.

Ethan reached into his bag and pulled out a folded note. The handwriting was neat, deliberate, the words scrawled in the same looping style he used for Samantha's name in his notebook.

You don't belong here. She's mine.

He slipped the note through the slats in the locker, his fingers trembling slightly as he let it fall inside.

This wasn't just about intimidation. It was about control, about making Liam feel the way Ethan had felt for weeks—powerless, unworthy, **afraid**.

As Ethan left the school, the adrenaline pumping through his veins left him exhilarated. The weight in his chest had eased, replaced by a cold, calculated satisfaction.

Liam would see the message in the morning. He would feel the fear Ethan had carefully crafted, and he would know he was being watched.

The thought made Ethan's lips curl into a faint smile.

But as he stepped into the night, the shadows of the school looming behind him, a flicker of doubt crept into his mind.

What if Liam didn't back down?

What if Samantha didn't understand that this was all for her?

Ethan shook the thoughts away as he made his way back to the cabin. The wind whistled through the trees, carrying with it a faint sense of foreboding.

In the cabin, the shadow box gleamed under the flickering lantern light, its contents a silent reminder of how far Ethan had come.

And how much further he was willing to go.

The next morning, Ethan arrived at school early, parking in his usual spot near the far edge of the lot. The cold air bit at his face as he stepped out of the car, but the chill didn't bother him.

His heart raced as he made his way toward the gym, weaving through the sparse crowd of early arrivals. He knew what he was looking for: the moment Liam saw the message.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan slipped into the shadows near the hallway, leaning casually against the lockers as he waited.

It didn't take long.

"Whoa," someone muttered, their voice cutting through the morning quiet.

Ethan glanced toward the source of the voice. A group of students had gathered near Liam's locker, their eyes wide as they stared at the spray-painted letters.

The bold, jagged words—**STAY AWAY**—glared back at them, stark against the gray metal.

"What the hell?" another student said, their tone a mix of shock and amusement.

Liam arrived moments later, his gym bag slung over his shoulder and his usual confident stride faltering as he saw the crowd.

"What's going on?" he asked, his brow furrowing as he approached.

The students parted, revealing the vandalized locker. Liam's expression shifted from confusion to something colder, his jaw tightening as he stepped closer.

Ethan watched from the shadows, his chest tightening with anticipation.

Liam crouched, pulling the note from the slats of his locker. He unfolded it slowly, his eyes scanning the words.

His face darkened.

"Is this a joke?" Liam asked, his voice low and sharp.

The group exchanged uneasy glances, murmurs rippling through the crowd.

Ethan's lips twitched into a faint smile. **That's right. Feel it.**

Samantha arrived minutes later, her bag slung over her shoulder and her hair pulled back in a loose braid. She stopped when she saw the crowd, her brow furrowing in confusion.

"What's going on?" she asked, her gaze flicking between the students.

"Someone went after Liam," one of them replied, gesturing toward the locker.

Samantha's eyes widened as she stepped closer, her hand flying to her mouth when she saw the words scrawled across the door.

"Oh my God," she whispered.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Liam, still holding the note, turned to her with a faint scowl. “It’s probably just some idiot messing around.”

Samantha frowned, her gaze lingering on the message. There was something about it that made her uneasy, a chill creeping down her spine as she read the words again.

“It’s not funny,” she said softly. “This feels...wrong.”

Ethan’s stomach twisted at her reaction. This wasn’t how it was supposed to go.

She’s supposed to see that I’m protecting her. Not him. Never him.

By lunchtime, the vandalism had become the talk of the school. Rumors spread like wildfire, each one wilder than the last: Liam had enemies on the rival team. Someone was jealous of his popularity. It was a prank gone too far.

Ethan listened to the whispers as he sat in the library, his notebook open in front of him. He jotted down notes, sketching the scene in his mind and analyzing every detail.

But his thoughts kept drifting back to Samantha.

Her reaction had been wrong. Instead of seeing Liam as a danger, she’d been worried for him.

Ethan clenched his jaw, his pen digging into the paper.

She’ll understand eventually. She has to.

That evening, Ethan returned to the cabin, the cold air cutting through his jacket as he stepped inside. The lantern flickered faintly, casting long shadows across the room.

He dropped his bag onto the table and sat down, staring at the shadow box. It gleamed faintly in the dim light, its contents a silent reminder of his devotion.

But it wasn’t enough.

Ethan picked up a photo of Liam, the ink-streaked words he’d scrawled across it glaring back at him: **You don’t belong.**

He set the photo down and grabbed his notebook, flipping to the page where he’d written Liam’s name over and over again. Beneath it, he scrawled:

Next step.

Ethan’s pen hovered over the page as his thoughts spiraled. The locker had been a warning. The next step would need to be stronger, more deliberate.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Something that would make Liam stay away forever.

Samantha sat on the edge of the courtyard bench, her fingers nervously twisting the hem of her sweater. The faint chatter of students filled the air, but she barely heard it. Her mind was elsewhere—on the note, the painted words, and the gnawing unease that had been growing inside her for weeks.

“Do you think it’s serious?” she asked, her voice low.

Lily, sitting beside her, frowned. “I don’t know,” she admitted. “The note was creepy, yeah, but it could just be some idiot trying to get attention.”

Samantha shook her head. “It doesn’t feel like a joke. The way it was written... It felt personal. And the stuff with my locker—missing things, the weird notes—I can’t help but think it’s connected.”

Lily glanced around the courtyard, her eyes scanning the nearby groups of students. “Do you think someone’s...watching you?”

The question made Samantha’s stomach twist. She’d tried to push the thought away, convincing herself it was just paranoia, but now, hearing it aloud, it felt undeniable.

“I don’t know,” she said quietly. “But it’s starting to scare me.”

From across the courtyard, Ethan sat under the shade of a large tree, his notebook open on his lap. His pen moved in slow, deliberate strokes as he sketched the scene in front of him: Samantha and Lily, their heads bent close together, their expressions serious.

He couldn’t hear what they were saying, but he didn’t need to. The tension in Samantha’s posture, the way her fingers fidgeted with her sweater—it was enough to tell him that she was thinking about him.

She didn’t understand yet, but she would.

Ethan’s grip tightened on the pen. **Why is she talking to her? Why doesn’t she trust me?**

The rest of the day passed in a blur, the unease in Samantha’s chest growing heavier with each passing moment. By the time the final bell rang, she felt drained, her mind racing with questions she couldn’t answer.

On her way out, she spotted Liam standing by his car, laughing with a group of teammates. For a moment, she hesitated, then walked toward him.

“Liam,” she called, her voice cutting through the chatter.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He turned, his expression softening when he saw her. “Hey, Sam. What’s up?”

She glanced at the group, suddenly feeling self-conscious. “Can I talk to you for a second?”

“Yeah, sure.” Liam stepped away from the group, his brow furrowing slightly as he followed her to a quieter spot.

Samantha hesitated, her fingers brushing against the strap of her bag. “It’s about...what happened to your locker.”

Liam’s expression darkened. “I figured. Did you hear something?”

“No, it’s not that,” she said quickly. “It’s just... I’ve been noticing weird things, too. Notes in my locker, stuff going missing. And now this? It feels connected.”

Liam frowned, his gaze thoughtful. “You think someone’s messing with both of us?”

Samantha nodded. “I don’t know who, but...yeah. And it’s freaking me out.”

Liam placed a reassuring hand on her shoulder. “Hey, don’t worry. Whoever it is, they’re just a coward hiding behind stupid pranks. If they try anything else, we’ll deal with it.”

His words were meant to comfort, but they only made Samantha feel more exposed.

Ethan watched from the far side of the lot, his hands clenched into fists at his sides. The way Liam leaned toward Samantha, the way he touched her shoulder—it was infuriating.

His mind raced, a storm of anger and betrayal swirling inside him.

She wasn’t supposed to go to Liam for help. She wasn’t supposed to confide in anyone but him.

“She doesn’t understand,” Ethan muttered under his breath. “Not yet.”

The wind whispered through the trees, carrying with it the faint sound of laughter from Liam’s group. Ethan’s jaw tightened, his thoughts narrowing to a single, unshakable conclusion.

I need to make her see.

That night, Ethan sat in the cabin, the lantern’s flickering light casting eerie shadows across the walls. His notebook lay open in front of him, the pages filled with sketches of Liam and Samantha.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He flipped to a blank page and began writing.

She's mine. He doesn't deserve her. I'll protect her.

The words felt like a promise, heavy and unbreakable.

Ethan set the pen down and leaned back, his gaze shifting to the shadow box. The items inside seemed to glow faintly, a reminder of how far he'd come—and how much further he was willing to go.

Liam was standing in the way. Samantha was confused, distracted.

But Ethan knew how to fix that.

The cabin was suffocating in its silence. Ethan sat in the center of the room, the utility knife resting on the table before him, its blade catching the flickering light of the lantern.

The notebook lay open, its pages filled with scrawled plans and fragmented thoughts. Ethan's handwriting had grown more erratic, the once-neat lines devolving into jagged letters that slashed across the paper.

Liam doesn't belong.

Samantha is confused.

I will fix this.

The words blurred together as Ethan stared at them, his mind spinning. He felt like he was unraveling, his thoughts pulling him in a hundred different directions.

But one thing remained clear: Liam was the problem.

Ethan stood and began pacing the cabin, his boots crunching against the broken glass on the floor. He imagined the scene in his head, playing it out like a script.

Liam would be caught off guard, his confidence stripped away. He would understand, finally, that he didn't deserve Samantha, that he wasn't worthy of her.

Ethan's lips curled into a faint smile at the thought.

He glanced at the shadow box, its contents glowing faintly in the dim light. The hairbrush, the mirror, the stolen notes—they were reminders of Samantha's perfection, of why she needed him to protect her.

Ethan reached for the knife, its weight familiar in his hand.

"This is for her," he whispered.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The cabin seemed to breathe with him, its walls creaking faintly as though agreeing.

The next day, Ethan arrived at school earlier than ever. The hallways were empty, the faint hum of the fluorescent lights the only sound as he made his way toward Liam's locker.

The spray-painted message had been cleaned, but a faint outline of the words still lingered on the metal. It was a reminder of the control Ethan had already exerted, a taste of what was to come.

He slipped a second note into the slats of the locker:

You've been warned. Leave her alone.

The words were bold, sharp, written with the same calculated precision Ethan had used for everything else.

As he stepped back, his gaze drifted to Samantha's locker down the hall.

For a moment, he considered leaving her something too—a message to remind her that he was always watching, always protecting. But he stopped himself.

Not yet.

She needed to see Liam for what he was first. Only then would she understand.

That night, Ethan returned to the cabin. The wind howled through the trees, rattling the windows as he paced the room. His mind felt like a storm, his thoughts crashing against each other in chaotic waves.

He grabbed his notebook and flipped to a blank page, his pen moving quickly as he wrote:

Liam's Weaknesses:

- Arrogance.
- Predictable schedule.
- Too trusting.

Ethan underlined the last point, his jaw tightening. Liam didn't even know he was being watched, didn't realize how vulnerable he was.

The thought sent a shiver of satisfaction through Ethan's chest.

He glanced at the knife resting on the table, its blade gleaming in the lantern light. It wasn't just a tool anymore—it was a promise, a solution.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The cabin grew colder as the night deepened, but Ethan didn't notice. He was too focused, too consumed by the plans unfolding in his mind.

By the time the first light of dawn crept through the cracks in the walls, Ethan had made his decision.

He would confront Liam directly.

And this time, there would be no warnings.

The cabin was darker than usual that night, the lantern's weak flame casting long, trembling shadows across the room. Ethan sat at the table, his head resting in his hands as he replayed the encounter with Liam in his mind.

The words echoed like a haunting refrain: **"You're acting crazy. Leave her alone."**

Crazy.

Liam didn't understand. He couldn't see the bigger picture, couldn't comprehend how dangerous he was to Samantha.

Ethan's hands curled into fists, his nails biting into his palms. "He's wrong," he whispered to himself. "He's the one who doesn't belong."

The cabin seemed to agree, its walls creaking faintly as the wind howled outside. Ethan stood, his movements jerky and restless as he paced the room.

The shadow box caught his eye, its glass front gleaming faintly in the dim light. He stepped closer, his gaze drifting over its contents: the stolen pen case, the hairbrush, the folded notes.

Each item felt like a thread, connecting him to Samantha in ways Liam never could.

"She'll understand," Ethan muttered, his voice low and uneven. "When he's gone, she'll see."

Ethan grabbed his notebook and flipped to the page labelled **Plan**. Beneath the carefully outlined schedule of Liam's movements, he began writing:

No more warnings. No more waiting. Make it final.

His handwriting was jagged, the letters uneven as his thoughts spilled onto the page. The utility knife sat on the table beside him, its blade catching the light as he reached for it.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan turned it over in his hand, the cold metal grounding him. It felt like an extension of his will, a tool for shaping the world into what it was meant to be.

By the time the first light of dawn crept through the cracks in the cabin's walls, Ethan had made his decision.

He packed his bag with the precision of someone preparing for war: gloves, the knife, a dark hoodie to keep him hidden in the shadows.

The shrine in the shadow box seemed to glow as he slung the bag over his shoulder, the items inside watching him like silent witnesses.

Ethan stepped out into the woods, the cold morning air biting at his face. The trees loomed tall and foreboding, their bare branches clawing at the sky as he made his way toward the edge of town.

This wasn't just about Liam anymore.

It was about Samantha. About protecting her, saving her, ensuring she saw the truth.

Ethan's steps quickened as he reached the outskirts of Liam's neighbourhood. The houses were quiet, their windows dark as the rest of the world slept.

Ethan crouched in the shadows, his breath forming faint clouds in the cold air as he stared at Liam's house.

Tonight, everything would change.

Glimpse of Normalcy.

The early morning air was cold and damp, wrapping around Ethan like a second skin as he crouched in the shadows outside Liam's house. The street was silent, the faint hum of distant traffic the only sound breaking the stillness.

Ethan's breath clouded in the air, his pulse steady as he watched the darkened windows. He had been here for hours, waiting, watching, memorizing the rhythms of the house. Lights on, lights off. Curtains shifting in the wind. A car pulling into the driveway, then leaving again.

But tonight, there had been nothing.

The weight of the knife in his bag pressed against his side, a constant reminder of what he had come to do. Ethan's fingers flexed against the strap, his thoughts circling back to Liam's smug expression in the park, the dismissive tone in his voice.

You're acting crazy. Leave her alone.

The words replayed like a taunt, growing louder with each repetition.

Ethan gritted his teeth. **I'm not crazy. You're the one who doesn't belong.**

The faint sound of movement from inside the house snapped Ethan back to the present. He stiffened, his eyes narrowing as he focused on the dim light that had flickered on in one of the upstairs windows.

A silhouette passed behind the curtains, slow and deliberate.

Ethan's hand hovered over the zipper of his bag, his chest tightening as he considered his next move. He could slip inside now, catch Liam off guard, make him understand—

But his body refused to move.

Something deep within him hesitated, a faint voice whispering against the tide of his anger. The house felt like it was watching him, its darkened windows staring back with silent judgment.

Ethan exhaled sharply, his breath fogging the air. **Not yet.**

He straightened slowly, retreating further into the shadows as the light in the window went out. The moment wasn't right. Liam wasn't ready to see the truth.

But he would.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan returned to the cabin as the first light of dawn broke through the trees. The walk felt longer this time, the silence of the woods pressing down on him like a weight.

Inside, the air was stale and cold, the lantern flickering faintly as he lit it. The shadow box gleamed in the dim light, its contents unchanged but somehow more accusing.

Ethan sat heavily at the table, his hands trembling as he pulled out his notebook. The page labeled **Plan** stared back at him, the words blurring slightly as his vision wavered.

He's not ready. She's not ready. But soon.

The knife sat on the table beside him, its blade catching the light. Ethan stared at it for a long time, his thoughts spiraling.

For a brief moment, the weight of it all threatened to crush him—the sleepless nights, the constant surveillance, the overwhelming need to control everything.

But then he thought of Samantha.

Her laugh, her smile, the way she lit up the room without even trying.

The storm inside him calmed.

This wasn't about him. It was about her.

Ethan leaned back in his chair, his gaze fixed on the shadow box. The pen case, the hairbrush, the photographs—they were reminders of what he was fighting for.

“Soon,” he whispered, the word barely audible over the creaking of the cabin.

The cabin felt suffocating in the light of day. Ethan sat at the table, the notebook and knife in front of him, their presence both comforting and maddening. He had spent hours planning, scribbling notes and crossing them out, only to start over again.

The window creaked as the wind pressed against it, a faint whisper breaking the oppressive silence. Ethan clenched his fists. He couldn't stay here, trapped in this cycle of indecision.

He needed to act.

The school parking lot was bustling with activity when Ethan arrived. He parked near the far edge, his car blending into the line of older sedans and SUVs.

UNSEEN CHAINS

From his vantage point, he could see Liam leaning against his car, chatting with a teammate. His posture was relaxed, his laugh loud and easy.

Ethan gritted his teeth, his fingers tapping against the steering wheel. Liam looked invincible, untouchable, as if the notes and warnings had rolled off him like water.

But Ethan knew better. No one was invincible.

Inside the school, Ethan moved through the hallways like a ghost, unnoticed and unbothered. The buzzing chatter of students filled the air, but it was all background noise to him.

He approached Samantha's locker slowly, his gaze darting to either side of the hallway. Students passed without sparing him a glance, their conversations blending into an indistinct hum.

Ethan reached into his pocket and pulled out a folded piece of paper. The handwriting was deliberate, almost elegant, the words carefully chosen:

He's not who you think he is. Be careful.

His hand trembled slightly as he slipped the note into the slats of her locker. The action felt intimate, almost sacred, as though he were leaving her a gift.

Ethan stepped back, his heart pounding as he turned and disappeared into the crowd.

By lunchtime, Samantha had found the note.

She stood in front of her locker, her brow furrowed as she unfolded the paper. Lily hovered beside her, peering over her shoulder.

"What does it say?" Lily asked, her voice hushed.

Samantha hesitated, her fingers tightening around the paper. "It's about Liam," she said finally, her tone uncertain.

Lily frowned. "Another note? That's two in one week. Are you going to tell him?"

Samantha shook her head. "I don't know. This one feels...different. Like a warning."

Lily leaned closer, her voice dropping. "Do you think it's the same person who messed with his locker?"

"I don't know," Samantha admitted. Her gaze flicked to the crowd, her stomach twisting with unease. The school felt different lately, its familiar hallways tinged with an undercurrent of tension she couldn't explain.

UNSEEN CHAINS

She folded the note carefully and tucked it into her bag. “Maybe it’s just a prank,” she said, though the words felt hollow even to her.

Ethan watched from the far end of the hallway, his back pressed against a row of lockers. He couldn’t hear their conversation, but he didn’t need to.

The way Samantha held the note, the way her expression shifted from confusion to worry—it was enough to tell him she was thinking about him.

She didn’t understand yet, but she would.

Ethan’s lips curled into a faint smile as he turned and walked away, his steps light and deliberate.

Liam leaned against the lockers near the gym, a frown tugging at the corners of his mouth as he reread the note Samantha had given him. The words were neat, carefully written, but they carried an unmistakable weight:

He’s not who you think he is. Be careful.

“What the hell is this supposed to mean?” Liam muttered under his breath.

His teammate, Marcus, glanced over. “You okay, man?”

Liam folded the note and shoved it into his pocket. “Yeah, just someone messing around.”

But his words lacked conviction. The note wasn’t the first strange thing to happen in the past few weeks. First, there was the vandalism on his locker, then the whispers in the hallways, and now this.

Someone was targeting him, and it wasn’t just a random prank.

Liam’s gaze drifted toward Samantha across the courtyard. She sat with Lily at their usual spot, her expression tense as she picked at the corner of her notebook.

She’d seemed distracted lately, distant in a way he couldn’t quite put into words.

Liam straightened, slinging his gym bag over his shoulder. “I’ll catch you later,” he said to Marcus, heading toward Samantha’s table.

Samantha looked up as Liam approached, her lips pressing into a faint smile. “Hey,” she said softly.

“Hey,” Liam replied, dropping into the seat across from her. He hesitated for a moment before pulling the note from his pocket and placing it on the table. “What’s this about?”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha's smile faltered. "I don't know," she admitted. "I found it in my locker this morning."

Liam frowned, his fingers brushing over the paper. "Do you think it's connected to the stuff that happened to my locker?"

"Maybe," Samantha said, her voice barely above a whisper. "But I don't get it. Who would do something like this?"

"That's what I'm trying to figure out." Liam leaned closer, his voice dropping. "Have you noticed anyone acting weird? Someone watching you or following you?"

Samantha hesitated, her mind flashing to the unsettling sensation she'd had lately—that prickling feeling of being watched, of someone just out of sight.

"No," she said finally, though the word felt like a lie.

Ethan watched the interaction from the shadows near the courtyard's edge, his chest tightening with a mix of jealousy and satisfaction.

Liam's reaction to the note was exactly what Ethan had hoped for—confusion, frustration, a crack in his confident exterior.

But Samantha's response... That was the part that mattered most.

The way she looked at Liam, the hesitation in her voice—it was proof that the doubt had taken root.

"She's starting to see," Ethan muttered under his breath, his hands tightening into fists. "She's starting to understand."

But as he watched Liam lean closer, his hand brushing against Samantha's on the table, a surge of anger coursed through Ethan's veins.

Liam was still in the way, still clinging to her, still poisoning her mind with his lies.

Ethan's thoughts spiraled as he turned and walked away, his footsteps heavy against the concrete. He didn't have time to linger.

There was more work to be done.

The cabin was alive with the faint creaks of the wind against its walls as Ethan hunched over his notebook, the pages spread out like a blueprint for the perfect plan. The table was a mess of scattered photographs, notes, and scratched-out ideas, but amid the chaos, a single thread was beginning to emerge.

UNSEEN CHAINS

It wasn't enough to intimidate Liam anymore. He'd proven that with his defiance, his refusal to step aside. If Liam wouldn't leave, Ethan would have to force him out another way—by turning Samantha against him.

Ethan's pen moved quickly across the paper as he wrote:

Plant doubt. Make her see who he really is.

The next morning, Ethan arrived at school before sunrise, the sky still painted in shades of gray and blue. The empty hallways echoed with his footsteps as he made his way to Liam's locker.

He reached into his bag and pulled out a folded piece of paper, the words on it written in the same careful hand as before:

He's hiding something. Look closer before it's too late.

Ethan slipped the note through the slats in the locker door, his fingers trembling slightly. It was a calculated risk, but one he was willing to take.

Samantha had to believe it.

By the time the first bell rang, Ethan was sitting at the back of the library, his notebook open in front of him. He watched as the students began trickling in, their voices low and drowsy with the early hour.

And then he saw her.

Samantha walked past, her bag slung over one shoulder and her gaze distant. She looked tired, the kind of tired that comes from restless nights and nagging thoughts.

Ethan's chest tightened as he watched her, his mind spinning with the possibilities. The notes, the missing items, the carefully planted clues—they were working. She was starting to question everything, to feel the doubt creeping in.

Good, he thought. **It's what she needs.**

But Ethan's satisfaction was short-lived.

Later that day, as he passed by the courtyard, he saw Samantha and Liam sitting together again, their heads bent close as they talked. Liam was gesturing animatedly, his voice carrying faintly across the space.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan couldn't hear what they were saying, but he didn't need to. The way Samantha looked at Liam, her brow furrowed with concern, made Ethan's stomach churn.

She was still trusting him, still listening to him.

Ethan's fingers curled into fists as he turned and walked away, his footsteps heavy against the concrete.

This isn't enough, he thought. She needs more proof.

That night, Ethan sat in the cabin, the lantern casting flickering shadows across the room. He stared at the shadow box, its contents gleaming faintly in the dim light.

The shrine felt incomplete, like a story missing its final chapter.

Ethan reached for his notebook, his pen hovering over the page. His mind raced with ideas, each one darker and more desperate than the last.

He thought of Liam—his confidence, his arrogance, his refusal to leave.

And he thought of Samantha—her warmth, her kindness, the way she deserved someone who truly understood her.

Ethan's hand began to move, the words spilling onto the page:

Tomorrow. New plan. Make her see.

Samantha's fingers brushed against something unfamiliar as she unzipped her bag between classes. She frowned, pulling out a folded piece of paper she didn't remember placing there.

Her heart sank as she unfolded it.

He's hiding something. Look closer before it's too late.

The handwriting was eerily similar to the note she'd found in her locker earlier that week. The same deliberate loops, the same steady hand.

Samantha's pulse quickened as she glanced around the hallway. Students bustled past, their conversations blending into an indistinct hum, but no one seemed to be watching her.

"Not again," she muttered under her breath, shoving the note into her pocket.

By lunchtime, the unease had settled into a heavy weight in her chest. Samantha sat at her usual table in the courtyard, her sandwich untouched as she stared blankly at the notebook in front of her.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Lily nudged her. “You’ve been quiet all morning. What’s up?”

Samantha hesitated, her fingers brushing against the note in her pocket. “I found another one,” she said finally, her voice low.

Lily’s brow furrowed. “Another note? Are you serious?”

Samantha nodded, pulling the paper from her pocket and sliding it across the table. Lily unfolded it, her frown deepening as she read the words.

“This is messed up,” she said, her voice hushed. “You have to tell someone.”

Samantha shook her head. “What would I even say? That I’m getting cryptic notes from someone I don’t know, and I think it’s connected to Liam’s locker? They’ll just say it’s a prank.”

Lily’s expression softened. “It’s not just a prank, Sam. Someone’s going out of their way to freak you out. You need to talk to Liam about this.”

Samantha glanced across the courtyard, where Liam was sitting with his teammates. He looked so at ease, laughing and joking like nothing had happened.

The idea of involving him made her stomach twist.

“I don’t want to bother him with this,” she said quietly.

Lily sighed. “You can’t just ignore it. What if it gets worse?”

Ethan watched from the edge of the courtyard, his gaze fixed on Samantha and Lily. He couldn’t hear their conversation, but the tension in Samantha’s posture was enough to tell him the notes were working.

She was worried. She was thinking.

Good, Ethan thought. **She’s starting to understand.**

But as his gaze shifted to Liam, a flicker of frustration rose in his chest. The boy was oblivious, carefree, completely untouched by the chaos Ethan had carefully orchestrated.

Ethan clenched his fists. **Not for long.**

That evening, Samantha sat at her desk, the notes spread out in front of her like pieces of a puzzle she couldn’t solve. The words were cryptic, but their intent felt personal, almost invasive.

She picked up the most recent note, tracing the letters with her finger.

He’s hiding something. Look closer before it’s too late.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha's thoughts drifted to Liam. He'd been nothing but kind to her, supportive and patient, but the notes had planted a seed of doubt she couldn't shake.

What if she was wrong about him?

She shook her head, folding the notes and tucking them into the back of her notebook. **No. Liam's a good person. He wouldn't hurt me.**

But the thought lingered, a faint whisper at the back of her mind.

Meanwhile, Ethan sat in the cabin, his pen scratching against the paper as he drafted his next message. The cabin was dark, the faint glow of the lantern casting shifting shadows across the walls.

The notes had done their job, but it wasn't enough.

Samantha was still too close to Liam, too trusting.

Ethan's hand tightened around the pen as he wrote:

He's not who you think he is. You need to see the truth.

Ethan sat in the cabin, the lantern flickering faintly as he stared at the words he had just written:

He's not who you think he is. You need to see the truth.

The letters glared back at him, bold and deliberate, a reflection of the chaos swirling in his mind. He set the pen down, his chest tightening as he imagined Samantha reading the note, her expression shifting from confusion to realization.

"She'll understand," he muttered, his voice low and strained. "She has to."

But even as he spoke the words, doubt gnawed at the edges of his thoughts. Samantha had spent the entire day sitting with Liam, laughing with him, trusting him.

Ethan's fists clenched.

She doesn't see it yet. But she will.

He folded the note carefully and slipped it into his bag, his movements sharp and precise. Tomorrow, he would place it somewhere Samantha couldn't ignore.

The next morning, Ethan moved through the school hallways like a shadow. Students bustled around him, their voices blending into a low hum, but he barely noticed.

UNSEEN CHAINS

His focus was on the note tucked into his pocket, the carefully chosen words that would push Samantha closer to the truth.

When he reached her locker, he paused, glancing down the hallway. No one was watching.

Ethan slipped the note through the slats, his heart pounding as it disappeared inside. He lingered for a moment, imagining the moment Samantha would find it, the way her fingers would tremble as she unfolded the paper.

A faint smile tugged at his lips.

Samantha found the note just before lunch.

She stood in front of her locker, her fingers trembling slightly as she pulled the paper free. The handwriting was the same as before—neat, deliberate, and unsettling.

He's not who you think he is. You need to see the truth.

Her stomach churned as she read the words, a cold knot of fear twisting in her chest.

“Samantha?”

She jumped, nearly dropping the note as Liam’s voice broke through her thoughts. He was standing a few feet away, his brow furrowed with concern.

“You okay?” he asked, stepping closer.

Samantha hesitated, then nodded quickly, tucking the note into her bag. “Yeah, I’m fine.”

Liam didn’t look convinced. “You sure? You seem kind of...off.”

“It’s nothing,” Samantha said quickly, forcing a smile. “Just tired, I guess.”

Liam’s gaze lingered on her for a moment before he nodded. “Alright. Let me know if you need anything, okay?”

Samantha nodded, her smile faltering as he walked away.

Ethan watched the exchange from the far end of the hallway, his chest tightening as he saw Samantha speaking to Liam.

She had the note—he had seen her take it from her locker—but instead of pulling away from Liam, she had let him comfort her.

Why can't she see it?

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's mind raced as he turned and walked away, his footsteps heavy against the tiled floor. The notes were supposed to make her question Liam, to plant the seeds of doubt that would push her closer to Ethan.

But something wasn't working.

Ethan clenched his fists, his nails biting into his palms. He needed to try harder, to make her see the truth before it was too late.

That night, Ethan returned to the cabin, the air cold and sharp as he stepped inside. The shadow box gleamed faintly in the lantern light, its contents a silent reminder of everything he was fighting for.

Ethan sat at the table, his hands trembling as he opened his notebook. He flipped past the pages filled with notes about Liam—his schedule, his routines, his weaknesses—and focused on Samantha.

Her laugh, her smile, the way she lit up every room she entered.

Ethan pressed his pen to the paper, his grip tightening as he began to write:

She needs to be protected. He's poisoning her. I have to save her.

The words felt like a vow, heavy and unbreakable.

Ethan leaned back in his chair, his gaze drifting to the knife resting on the table. Its blade caught the flickering light, gleaming sharp and cold.

This wasn't about Liam anymore.

It was about Samantha.

And Ethan was running out of time.

The knife gleamed on the table, its presence both comforting and suffocating. Ethan stared at it for a long time, his fingers twitching as though drawn to its cold, unyielding surface.

His mind replayed the moment in the hallway: Samantha tucking the note away, Liam leaning closer to her, offering his false comfort. It was all wrong.

Liam wasn't protecting her. He was confusing her, pulling her further away from the truth.

Ethan picked up the knife, the weight of it grounding him. He stood and began pacing the cabin, his boots crunching against the debris scattered across the floor.

"Liam," he muttered, his voice low and strained. "You need to stop. She doesn't belong to you."

UNSEEN CHAINS

He paused, shaking his head. The words felt wrong, hollow, like they wouldn't be enough. He tried again, his voice louder this time.

"You're lying to her," Ethan said, his grip on the knife tightening. "She deserves better than you."

But even as he spoke, he could hear Liam's mocking laughter, see the dismissive smirk he wore in the park.

Ethan's chest tightened, a mix of rage and frustration bubbling to the surface. He couldn't leave it to chance. He needed to be ready.

Ethan moved to the shadow box, the items inside glowing faintly in the flickering lantern light. He picked up Samantha's pen case, tracing the sunflower charm with his thumb as he pictured her face.

"You'll see," he whispered, his voice trembling. "You'll understand why I had to do this."

He set the pen case back in its place and turned to the table. The knife glinted at him, a silent reminder of what had to be done.

Ethan crouched and reached into his bag, pulling out a tattered hoodie and gloves. He slipped them on, the fabric worn and fraying at the edges, but it didn't matter. This wasn't about appearances.

He practiced slipping the knife in and out of the pocket, timing his movements, rehearsing them until they felt natural. Each action was deliberate, methodical, a ritual that calmed the storm in his mind.

The hours slipped by as Ethan paced and spoke, his words echoing off the cabin walls. He imagined Liam standing before him, imagined the look of realization on his face as Ethan exposed him for the fraud he was.

"You don't deserve her," Ethan said, his voice rising with each repetition. "You don't belong in her life. You're nothing but a distraction."

He slashed the knife through the air, the motion quick and precise. His heart raced, the adrenaline coursing through him like fire.

But as the energy drained away, the doubts crept back in. What if Liam didn't back down? What if he convinced Samantha to turn against Ethan?

The thought sent a shiver through him, his breath coming in shallow bursts. He dropped into the chair, his hands trembling as he set the knife down.

Not yet, he told himself. **Not yet.**

UNSEEN CHAINS

The cabin seemed to breathe with him, its walls creaking as the wind howled outside. The lantern's flame flickered, casting shadows that danced across the room.

Ethan leaned forward, his head resting in his hands. The pressure was unbearable, the weight of his obsession threatening to crush him.

But then he thought of Samantha—her laugh, her smile, the warmth in her voice.

Ethan sat up, his resolve hardening.

This wasn't about him. It was about her. About protecting her from the lies and poison that surrounded her.

And if that meant confronting Liam, making him see the truth...so be it.

Ethan stood in the middle of the cabin, the knife heavy in his hand as he replayed Liam's mocking voice in his mind. It wasn't real—just an echo of his own frustration—but it felt tangible enough to make his chest tighten.

"You think you can just take her from me?" he said aloud, his voice sharp and strained. "You think you deserve her?"

He jabbed the knife forward, as though Liam were standing in front of him, the tip slicing through the air with a faint whistle.

"She's better than you," Ethan continued, his voice rising. "She's too good for you."

He took a step forward, then another, each movement deliberate and measured. His breaths came in shallow bursts, his hands trembling as the weight of his anger and anticipation threatened to overwhelm him.

For a moment, Ethan froze, his mind spiraling. What if he hesitated when the time came? What if Liam laughed in his face, brushed him off like before?

The thought sent a jolt of panic through him, and he dropped the knife onto the table with a sharp clatter.

Ethan pressed his palms against the surface, his head hanging low as he struggled to steady his breathing.

This has to work, he thought. She needs to see the truth.

His gaze drifted to the shadow box, its contents illuminated by the flickering lantern light. The sight of Samantha's belongings calmed him, grounding him in his purpose.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan reached for the pen case, holding it tightly in his hands. He could still feel the faint grooves of the sunflower charm, the memory of the day he took it rushing back to him.

“You’ll thank me for this,” he whispered, his voice soft but resolute. “You’ll see that I was right.”

The hours stretched on as Ethan paced the cabin, his movements erratic and restless. He rehearsed the confrontation over and over, speaking the words aloud, perfecting the way he would deliver them.

“Stay away from her,” he muttered. “You don’t deserve her.”

But even as he repeated the lines, doubt crept into his thoughts. What if Liam didn’t take him seriously? What if Samantha didn’t believe him?

Ethan’s fists clenched, his nails digging into his palms. The cabin felt smaller now, the air thick and suffocating as his mind spiraled deeper into uncertainty.

He grabbed the knife from the table, the cold metal grounding him once more.

I’ll make him understand, he thought. **I’ll make them both understand.**

When the first light of dawn broke through the cracks in the cabin’s walls, Ethan was still awake, his body heavy with exhaustion but his mind racing.

He slipped the knife into his bag, along with the gloves and hoodie he had rehearsed with the night before. Each item felt like a piece of armor, a tool for carrying out what needed to be done.

As he stepped out into the cold morning air, the world felt quieter than usual, the weight of his decision pressing down on him.

Ethan’s path was clear now.

And there was no turning back.

Ethan gripped the knife tighter, imagining the smug look on Liam’s face, the way he leaned toward Samantha, the way she trusted him.

“You think she belongs to you?” Ethan growled under his breath. His voice echoed faintly in the empty cabin, blending with the creaking of the wooden beams above. “You’re a liar. A fraud.”

He stepped forward, slashing the knife through the air as though Liam stood before him. His breaths came in sharp bursts, his heart pounding in his chest.

UNSEEN CHAINS

But the knife felt heavy in his hand, the weight pressing down on him like an accusation. Ethan froze mid-motion, his mind spiraling into the same pit of doubt that had haunted him for days.

What if he failed?

The thought hit him like a blow, and his grip on the knife faltered. He stumbled back, dropping into the chair by the table as the blade clattered against the wood.

For a long moment, Ethan sat there, his head in his hands, the room spinning around him. The flickering lantern light cast shifting shadows across the walls, their movements erratic and chaotic, like his thoughts.

The shadow box gleamed faintly in the corner, drawing Ethan's gaze. It stood as a testament to everything he'd done, every step he'd taken to protect Samantha.

He pushed himself to his feet, his movements sluggish and uneven. The pen case sat inside the box, its sunflower charm catching the light.

Ethan reached for it, holding it tightly in his hands as he closed his eyes. He could still see Samantha's smile, hear her laugh—the way she lit up every room she entered.

"She doesn't know yet," Ethan whispered. "But she will. She'll see what I've done for her."

He placed the pen case back into the shadow box, carefully rearranging the items so that each one fit perfectly, like pieces of a puzzle.

The knife lay on the table, its blade catching the faint glow of the lantern. Ethan stared at it, his chest tightening as his resolve hardened.

By the time dawn broke, Ethan had rehearsed the confrontation a dozen times. Every word, every movement, every detail had been practiced to perfection.

He slipped the knife into his bag, along with the gloves and hoodie that would keep him hidden. Each item felt like a tool, a necessity for what needed to be done.

Ethan stepped out into the cold morning air, the forest around him still and quiet. The path to town stretched out before him, winding through the trees like a dark, unbroken thread.

This time, there would be no hesitation.

Liam needed to understand.

And Ethan would make sure he did.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The parking lot was quiet in the early hours, the faint glow of the streetlights reflecting off the wet asphalt. Ethan crouched low behind a row of cars, his breath clouding in the cold air as he watched Liam's silver sedan parked near the far corner.

Liam had stayed late after practice. Ethan had followed him from the gym, waiting for the perfect moment to act.

His bag felt heavy on his shoulder, the knife inside pressing against his side like a silent reminder. The gloves were already on his hands, their fabric worn but functional.

Ethan's pulse quickened as he approached the car, his footsteps light against the pavement. His gaze darted around the lot, searching for any sign of movement, but it was empty.

This was his moment.

The car door handle was cold under Ethan's gloved hand. He tried it once, but it didn't budge. Locked.

Ethan's jaw tightened. He reached into his bag and pulled out a scrap of paper, the words scrawled in the same careful handwriting as before:

You can't hide forever.

He pressed the note under the windshield wiper, his hands trembling slightly as he stepped back to survey his work. The words stared back at him, bold and deliberate, a warning that couldn't be ignored.

But it wasn't enough.

Ethan crouched near the rear tire, his hand brushing against the cold rubber as he slipped a small nail into the tread. It was subtle, something Liam wouldn't notice until it was too late—a reminder that he was being watched, that he wasn't safe.

Ethan's heart raced as he slipped back into the shadows, his breaths coming in shallow bursts. The parking lot stretched out before him, quiet and still, but the tension in the air was suffocating.

He watched from a distance as Liam emerged from the gym, his bag slung over his shoulder and his expression relaxed.

Ethan's fists clenched. How could he be so calm, so oblivious to the danger closing in around him?

UNSEEN CHAINS

Liam paused when he reached the car, his gaze catching on the note. He pulled it free, his brow furrowing as he read the words.

For a moment, Liam froze, his posture stiffening as he scanned the lot. His eyes passed over Ethan's hiding spot, but he didn't see him.

Ethan felt a surge of satisfaction, his chest tightening as he watched Liam crumple the note in his hand.

The boy's movements were sharper now, his confidence rattled as he tossed his bag into the car and slammed the door shut.

The engine roared to life, and the car pulled out of the lot, disappearing into the darkness.

Ethan retreated into the woods, his footsteps heavy as he made his way back to the cabin. The satisfaction from the parking lot lingered, a faint hum beneath the exhaustion that clung to him like a second skin.

Inside, the cabin felt colder than usual, the shadows deeper and more oppressive. Ethan dropped his bag onto the table and sat heavily in the chair, his head resting in his hands.

The knife gleamed from the corner of his vision, its presence both comforting and suffocating.

This wasn't over.

Ethan knew that Liam would retaliate, that he would try to protect his place in Samantha's life.

But Ethan was ready.

He leaned back in his chair, his gaze drifting to the shadow box. The items inside seemed to glow faintly, a reminder of everything he was fighting for.

"You'll understand soon," Ethan whispered, his voice barely audible over the creaking of the cabin.

The wind howled outside, carrying his words into the night.

The cabin was dark, the only light coming from the faint glow of the lantern on the table. Ethan sat in the center of the room, his head resting in his hands as his thoughts swirled in an endless loop.

He replayed the moment in the parking lot—the look on Liam's face as he read the note, the tension in his movements as he scanned the empty lot.

UNSEEN CHAINS

For a brief moment, Ethan had felt a surge of triumph, a spark of satisfaction that Liam was finally beginning to feel the weight of his presence.

But it wasn't enough.

Ethan leaned back in his chair, his gaze drifting to the shadow box in the corner. The items inside felt incomplete, their presence a reminder of everything he hadn't yet accomplished.

Liam was still there, still clinging to Samantha, poisoning her mind with his lies.

Ethan's fists clenched at the thought, his nails digging into his palms.

"She doesn't see it yet," he muttered, his voice low and sharp. "But she will. Soon."

Outside, the wind howled through the trees, rattling the windows and pressing against the walls of the cabin. Ethan stood and began pacing, the weight of his obsession pressing down on him like a physical force.

He thought of Samantha—her laughter, her smile, the way she had looked at Liam that day in the courtyard.

It was wrong.

She was meant to look at Ethan that way, to see him as the one who understood her, who protected her.

But Liam was in the way, always in the way.

Ethan grabbed his notebook and flipped to a blank page, his pen moving quickly as he scrawled the words that had been circling in his mind:

No more warnings. No more waiting. Make him understand.

He underlined the last phrase, the ink pressing deep into the paper. His hand trembled as he set the pen down, his chest heaving with shallow breaths.

Ethan turned to the table, where the knife lay gleaming in the lantern light. Its presence was comforting, a silent promise of control, of resolution.

He picked it up, the cool metal grounding him as he turned it over in his hands.

This ends soon.

The next morning, Ethan arrived at school earlier than usual. The hallways were empty, the fluorescent lights casting a pale glow over the polished floors.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He slipped down the corridor toward Liam's locker, his footsteps light and deliberate.

Reaching into his bag, Ethan pulled out another folded note. The words were sharper this time, more direct, written in the same careful hand:

I'm watching you. You can't escape this.

He slipped the note through the slats of the locker, his heart pounding as he stepped back. The message was bold, unmistakable—a declaration of control.

Ethan's lips curled into a faint smile as he turned and walked away.

This time, Liam wouldn't be able to ignore him.

By lunchtime, the tension in the school was palpable. Rumors about the note had already started spreading, whispered fragments carried from one group to the next.

Ethan lingered near the edge of the courtyard, his eyes fixed on Liam. The boy's usual confidence was gone, replaced by a sharp edge of frustration and unease.

Liam sat with his teammates, his movements agitated as he spoke in low, hurried tones.

Ethan's chest tightened with satisfaction. Liam was unraveling, his control slipping.

But then he saw Samantha approach the table, her expression filled with concern as she leaned in to speak with Liam.

Ethan's satisfaction soured, replaced by a gnawing sense of betrayal.

She's still with him. Still trusting him.

His fists clenched at his sides, his nails biting into his palms.

"She doesn't understand," Ethan muttered under his breath. "Not yet."

The wind stirred around him, carrying the faint sound of Liam's voice. Ethan turned and walked away, his footsteps heavy against the concrete.

He needed to act, and he needed to act soon.

That evening, Ethan returned to the cabin, his mind racing with possibilities. The shadows seemed darker than usual, the flickering lantern light casting jagged shapes across the walls.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan sat at the table, the knife resting in front of him, its blade glinting like a silent promise. He reached for his notebook and flipped to the page labeled **Plan**, his pen hovering over the paper.

He thought of Liam, of the way he looked at Samantha, of the way she still believed in him.

Ethan began writing, his strokes sharp and deliberate:

No more warnings. No more time. Make her see.

The words felt heavy, final.

Ethan leaned back in his chair, his chest tightening as the weight of his obsession threatened to crush him.

But then he thought of Samantha—her laughter, her smile, the warmth in her voice.

And Ethan knew he couldn't stop now.

Liam sat in his car, the crumpled note clenched tightly in his fist. The parking lot was nearly empty now, the last few stragglers from practice heading toward their vehicles.

His mind raced as he stared at the note:

I'm watching you. You can't escape this.

The words felt like a punch to the gut, their intent unmistakable. This wasn't a prank. It wasn't just someone messing around.

Someone was targeting him.

Liam's gaze shifted to the mirror, scanning the dimly lit parking lot for any sign of movement. The shadows seemed to press in around him, the faint hum of the streetlights doing little to ease the tension in his chest.

He thought of Samantha—the way she'd looked at lunch, her concern evident as they talked. The unease in her eyes mirrored his own.

"Who the hell are you?" Liam muttered, his grip tightening on the note.

He pulled out his phone and typed a quick message to Samantha:

Can we talk tomorrow? Something's not right.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Across town, Ethan sat in the cabin, his notebook open in front of him. The words he had written earlier stared back at him, their weight pressing down on him like an unspoken promise:

No more warnings. No more time. Make her see.

Ethan's fingers trembled as he flipped the page, the blank sheet staring up at him like a challenge. He picked up his pen, his strokes jagged and uneven as he began outlining the next step in his plan.

1. Watch Liam.

2. Find the opening.

3. Make him understand.

His breathing was shallow, his chest rising and falling in uneven bursts. The cabin felt smaller tonight, its walls closing in as his thoughts spiraled.

The knife lay on the table beside him, its blade glinting faintly in the lantern light. Ethan picked it up, the cold metal grounding him as he turned it over in his hands.

"This ends now," he whispered, his voice low and strained.

The next day, Samantha found herself pacing outside the library, Liam's text replaying in her mind.

Can we talk tomorrow? Something's not right.

She hadn't replied yet. The truth was, she didn't know what to say.

The notes, the missing items, the vandalism—they all felt connected, like pieces of a puzzle she couldn't quite put together.

Samantha leaned against the wall, her arms crossed tightly over her chest. She thought of Liam, of the way he'd looked at lunch: tense, frustrated, but also scared.

And then she thought of the notes.

Her bag felt heavier than usual, the weight of the folded papers pressing against her back.

Ethan watched from a distance, his chest tightening as he saw Samantha standing alone. The way she shifted her weight, the way her brow furrowed in thought—it was clear she was thinking about him.

She didn't understand yet, but she would.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's grip tightened on the strap of his bag as he turned and walked away, his footsteps muffled against the carpeted floor.

He needed to find Liam.

Liam was in the gym, the sound of sneakers squeaking against the polished floor blending with the rhythmic bounce of a basketball. He moved through the drills with a mechanical precision, his mind elsewhere.

The note, the tire, the locker—it all swirled in his head, a chaotic storm he couldn't escape.

"Liam!" a voice called, snapping him back to the present.

He turned to see Marcus jogging toward him, his expression a mix of concern and annoyance. "You good, man? You've been off all day."

Liam forced a smile, though it didn't reach his eyes. "Yeah, just tired."

Marcus raised an eyebrow but didn't press further. "Alright, just don't let Coach see you slacking. You know how he gets."

Liam nodded, his grip tightening on the basketball.

As Marcus walked away, Liam's gaze drifted to the far end of the gym. For a brief moment, he thought he saw movement—a shadow slipping behind the bleachers—but when he looked again, it was gone.

The ball slipped from his hands, bouncing once against the floor before rolling to a stop.

Ethan slipped out of the gym, his chest heaving as he stepped into the cool evening air. The sound of Liam's voice still echoed in his mind, the way it grated against his nerves like sandpaper.

He reached into his bag and pulled out another note, the words scrawled in bold, jagged strokes:

You've been warned. Stay away from her.

Ethan's hands trembled as he folded the paper and slipped it into his pocket.

Tomorrow, Liam would find it.

And this time, there would be no mistaking its intent.

Confrontation

The morning air was crisp and cold, the faint mist clinging to the empty school grounds as Samantha sat on the stone bench near the main entrance. She had arrived early, the weight of Liam's message sitting heavy in her chest.

"I need to tell you something. Meet me tomorrow morning."

Her fingers tightened around the strap of her bag as she stared at the faint outline of the track field in the distance. She had barely slept, her mind swirling with the notes, the strange tension in Liam's voice, and the creeping sensation that someone was watching her.

"Samantha."

She looked up sharply, her heart racing. Liam stood a few feet away, his gym bag slung over one shoulder. His hair was slightly mussed, and there were faint shadows under his eyes.

"Hey," she said softly, offering a faint smile.

Liam sat beside her, his usual easy confidence replaced by something heavier, more cautious. "Thanks for coming," he said, his voice low.

Samantha nodded, her stomach twisting with unease. "What's going on?"

Liam exhaled, his hands tightening around the strap of his bag. "It's about the notes. The tire. The locker." He paused, his gaze flicking to the horizon before settling back on her. "I think someone's messing with me. Like...seriously messing with me."

Samantha's chest tightened. "Do you think it's the same person who's been leaving notes in my locker?"

Liam frowned, his expression growing darker. "Maybe. I don't know. But it's not just stupid pranks anymore. That note on my car? The one that said 'You can't escape'? That's not random, Sam."

Samantha swallowed hard, her fingers brushing against the folded papers in her bag. The notes she had kept felt heavier now, their words echoing in her mind.

He's not who you think he is. Be careful. Look closer before it's too late.

"I don't get it," she said finally, her voice barely above a whisper. "Who would do something like this?"

UNSEEN CHAINS

“That’s what I’m trying to figure out,” Liam said, his jaw tightening. “I don’t think it’s about me. Not really.”

Samantha blinked, her brow furrowing. “What do you mean?”

Liam hesitated, his gaze searching hers. “I think it’s about you, Sam.”

The words sent a jolt through her, her breath catching in her throat. “Me?”

“Yeah,” Liam said, his voice steady but grim. “I think whoever’s doing this is trying to get to you through me.”

Samantha’s mind reeled as Liam’s words sank in. It felt impossible, like something out of a bad dream.

“I don’t—” she started, but her voice faltered. “Why would someone...?”

“I don’t know,” Liam admitted, his shoulders slumping slightly. “But I know one thing: this isn’t going to stop until we figure out who’s behind it.”

Samantha’s gaze drifted to the school building, her thoughts swirling with fragments of the past few weeks. The missing pen case, the strange feeling of being watched, the carefully written notes—they all pointed to something bigger, something she couldn’t yet see.

“Do you think we should tell someone?” she asked hesitantly.

Liam shook his head. “Not yet. Not until we know for sure what’s going on. I don’t want to sound crazy.”

Samantha nodded slowly, though the unease in her chest remained.

From the shadows near the far side of the building, Ethan watched them.

His fists were clenched at his sides, his nails digging into his palms as he studied their faces. The way Samantha leaned toward Liam, the way Liam’s expression softened as he spoke—it made Ethan’s stomach churn.

She’s still listening to him, Ethan thought, his jaw tightening. **She’s still trusting him.**

The cold air bit at his face, but he barely noticed. His focus was entirely on them, on the way Liam’s presence was still poisoning Samantha’s mind.

Ethan’s breathing quickened as he stepped back into the shadows, his resolve hardening.

This couldn’t go on any longer.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan retreated to the side of the school, his footsteps muffled against the cold, damp ground. His chest heaved, his breaths shallow and quick as his thoughts raced.

Liam was getting to her—Ethan could see it in the way Samantha had leaned in, the concern written all over her face. She was letting Liam manipulate her, letting him pull her further away from the truth.

She doesn't see it yet, Ethan thought, his fists clenching at his sides. **But she will.**

The parking lot stretched out before him, empty except for a few scattered cars. Ethan's gaze fixed on Liam's silver sedan, the note he had left the night before flashing in his mind.

I'm watching you. You can't escape this.

The words had rattled Liam—Ethan could see it in his tense shoulders, the way his gaze flicked over the empty lot like he expected someone to jump out at him.

Good.

Ethan's lips curled into a faint smile. Liam was beginning to feel the pressure, beginning to understand that he wasn't in control anymore.

But it wasn't enough.

Back inside the building, Samantha and Liam walked side by side down the quiet hallway, their voices low.

"I don't want to freak you out," Liam was saying, his hands jammed into his pockets. "But I really think we need to be careful."

Samantha nodded, her fingers brushing against the strap of her bag. "You're right," she said softly. "But what are we supposed to do? Whoever's doing this...they're always a step ahead."

Liam stopped walking, his brow furrowing as he turned to face her. "Maybe we've been looking at this the wrong way," he said.

"What do you mean?"

"What if it's not just random?" Liam asked, his voice steady but low. "What if it's someone we know?"

The thought sent a shiver down Samantha's spine. She had been so focused on the notes and the strange events that she hadn't considered the possibility that the person behind them might be closer than she realized.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Someone...we know?” she echoed, her voice barely above a whisper.

Liam nodded. “Think about it. How else would they know so much about us?”

Ethan’s fingers tightened around the edge of the doorframe as he listened, his chest tightening with every word.

They were starting to piece things together.

His gaze flicked to Samantha, her brow furrowed in thought as she processed Liam’s words. She was so close—so close to understanding.

But Liam was pulling her in the wrong direction, twisting her thoughts, turning her against Ethan before she even realized the truth.

Ethan’s breath came in shallow bursts as he stepped back into the shadows. His hands trembled as he reached for his notebook, flipping to the page where he had scrawled the day’s plan:

- 1. Watch Liam.**
- 2. Confront him.**
- 3. Make him understand.**

The knife was in his bag, its weight a comforting reminder of what had to be done.

By the time lunch rolled around, Ethan was ready.

He spotted Liam heading toward the parking lot, his steps brisk and purposeful. Samantha was nowhere to be seen—she had probably gone to her next class, leaving Liam to stew in his paranoia.

Ethan followed at a distance, his movements careful and deliberate. The hallways were empty, the muffled sounds of students filtering in from the cafeteria.

When they reached the parking lot, Ethan made his move.

“Liam.”

The boy turned, his eyes narrowing as he spotted Ethan stepping out of the shadows. “What do you want?”

Ethan stopped a few feet away, his hands clenched at his sides. The cold wind bit at his face, but he barely felt it.

“I need to talk to you,” Ethan said, his voice low but steady.

Liam scoffed. “Yeah? About what?”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan took a step closer, his gaze unwavering. “About Samantha.”

Liam’s jaw tightened, his stance shifting slightly as he crossed his arms over his chest. “What about Samantha?” he asked, his tone sharp.

Ethan’s gaze flicked toward the school building for a brief moment before settling back on Liam. The parking lot felt empty, isolated, like the whole world had narrowed to just the two of them.

“I think you need to leave her alone,” Ethan said, his voice low and deliberate.

Liam blinked, clearly caught off guard. Then his expression darkened. “Excuse me?”

“You heard me,” Ethan said, his fists clenching at his sides. “She doesn’t need you messing with her life.”

Liam laughed, the sound short and humorless. “Are you serious right now? Messing with her life? I’ve been helping her deal with all this crazy crap, and you’re—”

“You’re distracting her,” Ethan interrupted, his voice rising slightly. “You’re filling her head with lies, making her doubt herself.”

Liam took a step forward, his brow furrowing as he stared at Ethan. “What the hell are you even talking about? You don’t know anything about Samantha, do you?”

Ethan flinched, but he quickly masked it with a scowl. “I know more than you think.”

Liam’s gaze sharpened, his posture straightening as realization flickered across his face. “Wait a second...” he said slowly, his voice dripping with suspicion. “The notes. The locker. That wasn’t random, was it?”

Ethan said nothing, his breathing quickening as his mind raced.

“It was you,” Liam said, his voice hardening. “You’re the one who’s been messing with her.”

“You don’t know what you’re talking about,” Ethan snapped, his hands trembling at his sides.

“Don’t I?” Liam took another step forward, his eyes narrowing. “You’ve been watching her, haven’t you? Stalking her?”

Ethan’s vision blurred with a mix of rage and panic. “I’ve been protecting her,” he hissed.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Protecting her?” Liam repeated, his voice incredulous. “From what? From me? You’re the one who’s scaring her!”

The accusation hit Ethan like a slap, his chest tightening as he struggled to find the words to defend himself.

“She’s confused,” Ethan said, his voice shaking. “She doesn’t understand what you’re doing to her.”

“I’m not doing anything to her!” Liam shot back. “But you? You’re the problem, man. You’re the one who’s been creeping around, leaving notes, messing with her stuff. You’re the reason she’s scared.”

Ethan’s fists clenched, his nails biting into his palms. The knife in his bag felt like it was burning a hole through the fabric, its weight calling to him.

“She doesn’t need you,” Ethan said through gritted teeth. “You’re in the way.”

Liam shook his head, disbelief etched across his face. “You’re insane,” he muttered, taking a step back.

The word sent a jolt through Ethan’s chest, his vision narrowing as his heart pounded in his ears.

“I’m not crazy,” he said, his voice low and dangerous. “You’re the one who’s ruining her life.”

The sound of footsteps broke the tension. Both boys turned to see Samantha walking toward them, her bag slung over one shoulder and her expression a mix of confusion and concern.

“Liam? Ethan?” she called, her voice hesitant. “What’s going on?”

Liam straightened, his jaw tightening as he glanced at Ethan before turning to her. “Samantha, you need to know something. He—”

“Enough,” Ethan said sharply, cutting Liam off.

Samantha frowned, her gaze flicking between the two boys. “What are you talking about?”

Liam hesitated, his fists clenching at his sides. “He’s been watching you, Sam. The notes, the locker, all of it—it’s him.”

The world seemed to stop as the words hung in the air.

Samantha’s eyes widened, her hand tightening around the strap of her bag. “Ethan,” she said slowly, her voice trembling. “Is that true?”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's breath caught in his chest, the weight of Samantha's question pressing down on him like a boulder. The way she looked at him—her wide eyes, her trembling voice—sent a jolt of panic through him.

"I was...helping you," Ethan said finally, his voice barely above a whisper.

Samantha took a step back, her confusion deepening. "Helping me?"

"Yes," Ethan said quickly, his words tumbling out in a rush. "I saw how he was manipulating you, how he was pulling you away. I had to do something."

"Manipulating her?" Liam snapped, his voice sharp. "What are you even talking about? I've been helping her deal with all this crap—you're the one who's been creeping around, messing with her stuff!"

Ethan shot Liam a venomous glare. "You don't understand her like I do. You don't know what she needs."

"You're insane," Liam said, his voice rising. "You don't get to decide what's best for her!"

"I'm not insane!" Ethan shouted, his voice echoing across the parking lot.

Samantha flinched at the outburst, her heart pounding as she took another step back. "Ethan," she said, her voice unsteady, "this doesn't make sense. Why would you do this? Why would you leave those notes?"

"They weren't meant to scare you," Ethan said, his tone softening as he turned to her. "They were meant to protect you. To show you the truth."

"The truth?" Samantha repeated, her voice shaking. "Ethan, I don't even know what you're talking about."

"She's scared of you," Liam said, stepping between Ethan and Samantha. "You think you're helping her? All you're doing is making things worse."

Ethan's fists clenched, his jaw tightening as his gaze flicked to Samantha. "He's lying," he said, his voice pleading. "He's trying to turn you against me."

Samantha stared at him, her expression a mix of fear and disbelief. "Ethan..."

The way she said his name—so distant, so unsure—sent a crack through Ethan's chest. He reached for her, his movements frantic.

"I did this for you," he said, his voice trembling. "Everything I've done has been for you. Don't you see? He's the one who's been keeping you trapped. I was trying to free you!"

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Stop,” Samantha said, her voice firm despite the tremor in her hands. “Just...stop.”

Ethan froze, his arm falling to his side as her words cut through him like a blade.

“I don’t need you to protect me,” Samantha said, her voice heavy with emotion. “I don’t even know who you are anymore.”

Ethan’s world tilted, her words ringing in his ears. **I don’t even know who you are anymore.**

Liam stepped closer to Samantha, his stance protective as he glared at Ethan. “You need to leave,” Liam said, his voice steady. “Now.”

Ethan stared at them, his chest rising and falling in shallow bursts. For a moment, everything felt frozen—the parking lot, the cold wind, the world itself.

And then he turned and walked away, his footsteps heavy against the pavement.

The shadows swallowed him as he disappeared into the distance, his mind racing with fragments of the confrontation.

He had tried to save her.

But she didn’t understand.

Not yet.

Ethan’s footsteps echoed in the empty alley behind the school as he walked, his breaths coming in uneven bursts. The confrontation replayed in his mind, each word cutting deeper than the last.

“I don’t even know who you are anymore.”

Samantha’s voice was etched into his thoughts, her expression burned into his memory. The disbelief, the fear—it wasn’t supposed to be like this.

He stumbled into the woods that bordered the town, the familiar path to the cabin dark and twisted in the fading light. The shadows felt alive, pressing in around him as though they were mocking his failure.

Ethan clenched his fists, his nails biting into his palms as his chest tightened.

She doesn’t see it yet. She doesn’t understand.

The cabin door groaned as Ethan shoved it open, the stale air wrapping around him like a suffocating blanket. He dropped his bag onto the table, the knife spilling out with a dull clatter.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The shadow box loomed in the corner, its contents glowing faintly in the dim lantern light. Samantha's stolen items seemed to mock him now, their presence a reminder of everything he had sacrificed for her.

Ethan sat heavily in the chair, his hands trembling as he grabbed his notebook. The pages were filled with fragments of his plans, his scrawled thoughts chaotic and disjointed.

He flipped to the most recent page, his pen pressing hard against the paper as he wrote:

She'll see the truth. He'll pay for what he's done. I'll save her.

The words blurred as tears pricked his eyes, his chest heaving with a mix of anger and despair. He had tried to protect her, to show her what Liam really was.

But she had rejected him.

The lantern flickered, its light casting jagged shadows across the room. Ethan stood and paced, his hands running through his hair as his thoughts spiraled.

Liam was the problem. He was the one twisting Samantha's mind, turning her against Ethan.

Ethan's gaze flicked to the knife on the table, its blade gleaming in the faint light. He picked it up, his grip tightening around the handle as his mind raced.

This ends tonight.

The thought sent a surge of adrenaline through him, his movements quick and frantic as he grabbed his hoodie and gloves.

Ethan's breaths came in shallow bursts as he left the cabin, the cold night air biting at his face. The path through the woods was dark, but he didn't need light to find his way.

He knew where Liam would be.

Liam sat on the bench at the edge of the park, his head in his hands as the events of the day replayed in his mind. The confrontation with Ethan had left him rattled, his words swirling in Liam's thoughts like a storm.

"I've been protecting her. You're the one ruining her life."

The way Ethan had said it—the conviction in his voice, the wild look in his eyes—had sent a chill down Liam's spine.

UNSEEN CHAINS

His phone buzzed in his pocket, and he pulled it out to see a message from Samantha.

Are you okay? I'm worried.

Liam exhaled sharply, typing back quickly: **I'm fine. We'll talk tomorrow.**

He set the phone down beside him, his gaze drifting to the dark line of trees that bordered the park.

For a moment, he thought he saw movement—a shadow shifting between the trunks.

Liam straightened, his heart pounding as he squinted into the darkness. “Hello?” he called, his voice sharp.

The only answer was the rustle of leaves in the cold wind.

Ethan watched from the shadows, his chest tightening as he saw Liam’s silhouette illuminated by the faint glow of the streetlights.

He gripped the knife tightly, his breathing shallow as he stepped closer, the world narrowing to the figure in front of him.

This is for her, he thought, his pulse pounding in his ears. **This is the only way.**

The park was silent, the stillness broken only by the faint crunch of Ethan’s footsteps on the frost-covered grass.

Liam turned, his eyes widening as he spotted the figure approaching. “Ethan?” he said, his voice tinged with confusion and unease. “What the hell are you doing here?”

Ethan stopped a few feet away, the knife hidden in the folds of his hoodie. His chest heaved as he stared at Liam, his thoughts swirling with rage and desperation.

“This ends now,” Ethan said, his voice low and trembling.

Liam’s brow furrowed as he stepped back, his gaze flicking to Ethan’s clenched fists. The way Ethan stood—his shoulders rigid, his breath coming in uneven bursts—sent a chill down Liam’s spine.

“What ends?” Liam asked, his voice steady despite the unease creeping into his chest.

Ethan took a step closer, his grip tightening around the knife hidden in his hoodie. The cold night air bit at his face, but he barely felt it. His focus was entirely on

UNSEEN CHAINS

Liam—the boy who had poisoned Samantha’s mind, who had stolen her trust, her attention.

“You don’t deserve her,” Ethan said, his voice low but sharp.

Liam’s jaw tightened. “What are you even talking about?”

Ethan’s chest heaved as his emotions surged, a chaotic mix of anger, jealousy, and desperation. “She’s better than you,” he said, his voice trembling. “You’re ruining her life, filling her head with lies. You need to leave.”

Liam took another step back, his hands raised slightly in a gesture of defense. “You’re not making any sense,” he said. “If this is about Samantha—”

“This is all about her!” Ethan shouted, his voice echoing through the empty park. “She doesn’t see it yet, but she will. I’ve been protecting her, keeping her safe from you.”

The words hung in the cold air, their weight settling over the space between them. Liam’s gaze sharpened, realization flickering in his eyes.

“You’ve been watching her,” he said, his voice low and steady. “The notes. The locker. It was you all along.”

Ethan flinched, but he didn’t deny it. His hands trembled as he tightened his grip on the knife, his vision blurring with tears of frustration.

“I did it for her,” Ethan said, his voice breaking. “She doesn’t understand what you’re doing to her. She doesn’t see the way you’re dragging her down.”

Liam shook his head, disbelief etched across his face. “You’re the one who’s hurting her. You’re the one who’s been scaring her.”

“Shut up!” Ethan snapped, his voice cracking. “You don’t know anything about her. You don’t know what she needs.”

“I know she’s terrified,” Liam said, his tone hardening. “And I know you’re the reason why.”

The words sent a jolt through Ethan’s chest, his breath catching as his vision narrowed. The knife felt heavier in his hand, its blade cold and unyielding against his skin.

“You don’t get to decide that,” Ethan said, his voice trembling. “You don’t get to take her from me.”

Liam’s stance shifted, his shoulders squaring as he stepped forward. “Listen to yourself, man. You’re obsessed. You need to stop before you make this worse.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Worse?” Ethan repeated, a bitter laugh escaping his lips. “You’ve already made it worse. You’re the reason she’s scared. You’re the reason she’s pulling away.”

Liam took another step forward, his expression darkening. “I’m not the one who’s been stalking her, Ethan.”

The accusation hit like a slap, and Ethan’s vision blurred with a mix of rage and desperation.

Without thinking, he lunged forward, the knife flashing in the faint light as he swung it wildly.

Liam reacted on instinct, his arm shooting up to block the strike. The blade grazed his sleeve, the sound of tearing fabric sharp in the stillness.

“Are you insane?” Liam shouted, shoving Ethan back with a burst of adrenaline.

Ethan stumbled but recovered quickly, his chest heaving as he gripped the knife tighter. His mind raced, a chaotic swirl of emotions drowning out reason.

“This is for her!” Ethan screamed, lunging again.

Liam dodged, his movements quick and fluid as he grabbed Ethan’s wrist, forcing the knife downward. The two boys struggled, their breaths loud and uneven as they wrestled for control.

The knife clattered to the ground, its metallic ring echoing through the empty park.

Liam shoved Ethan backward, his chest heaving as he glared at him. “Stay the hell away from her,” he said, his voice low and dangerous.

Ethan stared at him, his chest tight, his hands trembling. For a moment, everything was silent except for the sound of their labored breathing.

Then, without another word, Ethan turned and fled, disappearing into the shadows of the trees.

Liam stood there for several moments, his body tense as the adrenaline coursed through him. His gaze drifted to the knife lying on the ground, its blade glinting faintly in the moonlight.

He pulled out his phone, his fingers trembling as he dialed.

“Samantha?” he said when she picked up, his voice unsteady. “We need to talk. Now.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan ran blindly through the woods, the cold air slicing at his face and lungs. The trees loomed tall and foreboding around him, their shadows twisting in the moonlight as though mocking his failure.

His mind raced, each thought more frantic than the last. **He doesn't deserve her. He doesn't understand her. Why can't she see it? Why can't she see me?**

The cabin appeared in the distance, its dark silhouette barely visible against the inky blackness of the forest. Ethan stumbled toward it, his knees threatening to buckle as exhaustion and adrenaline fought for control of his body.

Inside, the lantern light flickered weakly, casting jagged shadows across the walls. Ethan slammed the door shut behind him, the sound reverberating through the cramped space.

He leaned against the table, his chest heaving as he gripped its edges tightly. The shadow box caught his eye, its contents glowing faintly in the dim light.

The pen case. The notes. The little fragments of Samantha's life that he had collected like sacred relics.

They felt hollow now, like echoes of a dream he couldn't touch.

Ethan sank into the chair, his head falling into his hands.

"I tried," he whispered, his voice breaking. "I tried to save you."

At the same time, Liam sat on the edge of his couch, his phone clutched tightly in his hand. The call with Samantha had been short, her voice trembling as she promised to meet him.

Liam stared at the knife on the coffee table, its blade still smeared with dirt from the park. The sight of it made his stomach churn.

He thought of Ethan's wild eyes, the desperation in his voice. The boy had been on the verge of losing control—no, he already had.

Liam rubbed his face with one hand, trying to steady his breathing.

This wasn't just about the notes anymore. This wasn't just about scaring someone.

This was dangerous.

Samantha arrived at Liam's house twenty minutes later, her jacket pulled tightly around her as she stepped inside. The sight of Liam—pale and shaken, his sleeve torn—made her chest tighten with worry.

"What happened?" she asked, her voice soft.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Liam gestured for her to sit, his movements slow and deliberate. He sat across from her, his hands clasped tightly in his lap.

“It was Ethan,” Liam said finally.

Samantha’s brow furrowed. “What do you mean?”

“He confronted me,” Liam said, his voice low and steady. “In the park. He had a knife, Sam. He...he tried to attack me.”

Samantha’s breath caught, her eyes widening. “What? No, that can’t be—”

“It was him,” Liam said firmly, cutting her off. “I don’t know what’s going on in his head, but he’s obsessed. With you.”

Samantha shook her head, her mind reeling. Memories of Ethan flashed through her thoughts—the way he always seemed to appear when she needed something, the way his presence had gone from comforting to unsettling.

And then the notes. The missing items. The creeping sensation of being watched. Her chest tightened as the pieces began to fall into place.

“What are we supposed to do?” Samantha asked finally, her voice trembling.

Liam hesitated, his jaw tightening. “We can’t let this go on. He’s dangerous, Sam. We need to tell someone—your parents, the school, the police, someone.”

Samantha nodded slowly, though the thought of dragging everything into the open made her stomach churn.

She thought of Ethan—his quiet smile, his steady presence—and tried to reconcile it with the version of him Liam had described.

It didn’t seem possible.

But the fear in Liam’s voice was real. The knife was real.

And the thought of what Ethan might do next sent a shiver down her spine.

Back at the cabin, Ethan sat in silence, the flickering lantern casting faint light over his notebook. The words on the page blurred together, their meaning slipping through his fingers like sand.

He picked up the pen and began writing, his strokes sharp and jagged:

She’ll see. She’ll understand. She has to.

The wind howled outside, rattling the windows as though urging him forward. Ethan closed the notebook and stood, his movements slow and deliberate.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He wasn't done yet.

Not by a long shot.

Rejection

The weight of the decision sat heavy on Samantha's chest as she stared at her phone, Liam's voice from their earlier conversation echoing in her mind.

"You have to talk to him, Sam. He needs to hear it from you."

She had argued at first, her fear outweighing her desire to confront Ethan. But Liam had been insistent. The events of the past few weeks—the notes, the missing items, the confrontation in the park—had spiraled out of control.

And now, there was no avoiding it.

Her fingers hovered over the keyboard, her stomach twisting with unease as she typed the message:

"Can we talk after school? Just the two of us."

She hesitated for a moment before hitting send, the small sound of the message being delivered making her heart race.

Samantha set the phone down, pacing her room as her thoughts raced. Part of her hoped Ethan would ignore the message, that he wouldn't respond, and she could delay the inevitable.

But her phone buzzed almost immediately.

"Of course. I'll meet you by the library."

Ethan stared at his phone, his heart pounding as he read Samantha's message again. She wanted to talk to him—alone.

He sat at the edge of his bed, his hands trembling slightly as he gripped the phone. This was it. The moment he had been waiting for.

Samantha had finally seen the truth. She had realized that Liam was the problem, that Ethan was the one who truly understood her, who truly cared.

He stood quickly, his mind racing as he began preparing. His bag was already packed, the knife and gloves tucked neatly inside. The notebook lay open on his desk, the words he had written earlier that morning glaring back at him:

She'll understand. She'll finally see.

Ethan grabbed the notebook, flipping to a blank page. His pen moved quickly, sketching out the things he wanted to say, the points he needed to make.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“This is for her,” he muttered under his breath, his grip on the pen tightening. “She’ll see that this was all for her.”

Samantha leaned against the lockers outside the library after school, her heart pounding as she watched the students slowly filter out of the building. The usually familiar halls felt oppressive, the fluorescent lights casting harsh shadows over the polished floors.

Her phone buzzed again.

“I’m almost there.”

She tucked the phone into her pocket, her fingers trembling slightly. The logical part of her knew this was the right thing to do—to confront Ethan, to make him understand that his behaviour was unacceptable—but fear gnawed at the edges of her resolve.

Samantha turned as she heard footsteps behind her. Ethan approached slowly, his bag slung over one shoulder and a faint, almost hopeful smile on his face.

“Hey,” he said softly, stopping a few feet away.

“Hi,” Samantha replied, her voice tight.

The tension between them was palpable, the air thick with unspoken words. Samantha took a deep breath, summoning the courage to begin.

“Thanks for meeting me,” she said, her voice wavering slightly.

“Of course,” Ethan replied quickly, his eyes fixed on her. “I’m glad you wanted to talk. There’s...there’s a lot I’ve been wanting to say too.”

Samantha nodded, her stomach twisting with unease. “Yeah. Me too.”

Ethan stood rigid, his chest tightening as he waited for Samantha to speak. The way she looked at him—calm, almost hesitant—made his heart race. He wanted to believe this was it, the moment she would finally say the words he had been longing to hear.

Samantha tucked a strand of hair behind her ear, her gaze flicking to the floor before meeting his. “Ethan,” she began, her voice soft but steady, “I wanted to talk because...well, things have felt off lately.”

“Off?” Ethan repeated, his brow furrowing slightly.

“Yeah,” she said, nodding. “I mean, you’ve always been...there for me. You’ve been kind, and I’ve always appreciated that, but...”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Her words trailed off, and Ethan took a small step closer, his chest swelling with hope.

“I knew it,” he said, his voice barely above a whisper. “You finally see it. You know that I’ve been looking out for you.”

Samantha froze, her stomach twisting as she registered the intensity in his gaze. “What do you mean?”

“I mean, Liam,” Ethan said, his tone sharpening slightly. “He’s been lying to you, dragging you into his mess. I’ve been trying to protect you from him. From people like him.”

“Ethan...” Samantha started, her voice wavering.

“I know it’s been hard,” Ethan interrupted, his voice quickening. “You’ve been surrounded by people who don’t really understand you. But I do, Samantha. I’ve always understood you.”

He smiled faintly, his eyes gleaming with a mix of relief and determination. “That’s why I did it. All of it. For you.”

The words hit Samantha like a wave, her breath catching in her chest. “Wait,” she said, her voice rising slightly. “What do you mean, ‘all of it’?”

Ethan blinked, his smile faltering. “The notes,” he said, as though it were obvious. “The warnings. The things I did to show you the truth about Liam.”

Samantha’s chest tightened, her mind racing as the pieces clicked together. The notes in her locker. The vandalism. The confrontation Liam had described in the park.

“Ethan...” she said slowly, her voice trembling. “You wrote those notes?”

Ethan hesitated, his gaze flicking away for the briefest moment before returning to hers. “You weren’t listening to me,” he said. “I had to find a way to get through to you.”

Her stomach churned, and she took a step back. “You...you did all of that? You’ve been watching me?”

“I’ve been protecting you,” Ethan said quickly, his voice rising with urgency. “From him. From people who don’t deserve you.”

Samantha shook her head, her mind reeling. “Ethan, that’s not—”

UNSEEN CHAINS

“You don’t see it yet,” Ethan interrupted, his tone pleading. “But you will. You’ll see why I had to do it. I’ve been the only one looking out for you, Samantha. The only one who truly cares.”

Samantha’s breaths came in shallow bursts as she took another step back, her heart pounding. “Ethan, this isn’t caring. This...this is stalking. It’s controlling.”

The words sent a jolt through Ethan, his body stiffening as his chest tightened painfully. “No,” he said, shaking his head. “No, you don’t understand. Everything I’ve done has been for you. You’re just confused right now, but I can help you see—”

“No,” Samantha said firmly, cutting him off. “I don’t need you to help me. I don’t need you to protect me. I don’t...Ethan, I don’t feel safe around you anymore.”

The world seemed to tilt as the words left her mouth, each one driving a jagged crack through Ethan’s chest. He stared at her, his vision blurring as his mind raced to process what she had said.

“You don’t mean that,” he whispered, his voice trembling.

“I do,” Samantha said, her voice breaking slightly. “You’ve crossed a line, Ethan. This has to stop.”

Ethan’s breathing quickened as he stood frozen, his hands trembling at his sides. The hope that had burned so brightly in his chest was snuffed out in an instant, replaced by a swirling mix of despair and disbelief.

Samantha took another step back, her gaze lingering on him for a moment before she turned and walked away.

Ethan watched her go, his chest heaving as his vision narrowed to the empty space she left behind.

This isn’t over, he thought, his fists clenching. **She’ll see the truth. She has to.**

Ethan stood in the empty courtyard long after Samantha had walked away, her words reverberating in his mind.

“I don’t feel safe around you anymore.”

Each syllable cut deeper, the weight of her rejection pressing down on his chest like a vise. He had envisioned this moment so many times—their conversation, the way she would finally see the truth—but it had all crumbled into something unrecognizable.

The hope that had burned so brightly in him was gone, snuffed out in an instant.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“No,” Ethan muttered, his voice trembling. “She’s just confused. She doesn’t understand yet.”

He began pacing the courtyard, his hands trembling as his thoughts spiraled.

Liam.

It had to be Liam.

Ethan’s breath quickened, his mind latching onto the idea with frantic desperation. Liam had been poisoning her mind from the start, twisting her thoughts, filling her head with lies.

“She doesn’t mean it,” Ethan whispered, his voice breaking. “She’s scared because of him. He’s the one who’s done this.”

The anger that surged through him was a lifeline, drowning out the despair that threatened to consume him. His fists clenched at his sides as he turned and stalked toward the woods, his footsteps heavy and deliberate.

The cabin was cold and dark when Ethan returned, the faint light from the lantern barely illuminating the cluttered interior. The familiar sight of the shadow box greeted him from the corner, its contents gleaming faintly in the dim glow.

He dropped his bag onto the table, the knife spilling out with a metallic clatter. The sound echoed through the room, sharp and jarring.

Ethan stared at the blade, his chest heaving as his thoughts raced. He reached for it slowly, his fingers curling around the hilt.

“This isn’t over,” he muttered, his voice low and shaking. “She doesn’t see it yet. She doesn’t see what I’ve done for her.”

His gaze flicked to the notebook lying on the table, its pages filled with scrawled plans and fragmented thoughts. He grabbed it, flipping to the page where he had written Samantha’s name over and over, surrounded by phrases like **“Protect her”** and **“She’ll understand.”**

Ethan’s grip tightened on the pen as he scrawled a single word across the page:

Liam.

Meanwhile, Samantha sat on the edge of her bed, her hands trembling as she recounted the conversation to Liam over the phone.

“He admitted it,” she said, her voice shaking. “The notes, the stalking—he admitted all of it.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

“What did he say?” Liam asked, his tone sharp with concern.

Samantha hesitated, her chest tightening as she recalled Ethan’s words. “He said he was protecting me. That he thought he was helping.”

“Helping?” Liam repeated, disbelief coloring his voice. “Sam, this guy’s delusional. He’s dangerous.”

“I know,” Samantha said quietly.

She glanced at her window, the darkness outside pressing against the glass like a living thing. The fear that had taken root in her chest earlier had only grown, twisting into something cold and unrelenting.

“What do we do?” she asked finally, her voice barely above a whisper.

Liam’s pause on the other end of the line was heavy with meaning. “We have to go to someone,” he said. “Your parents, the school—anyone. He’s not going to stop, Sam.”

Back at the cabin, Ethan sat in silence, his mind racing as the pieces of his plan began to fall into place. The shadow box gleamed faintly in the lantern light, its contents a reminder of everything he had done, everything he had sacrificed for Samantha.

The pen case, the hairbrush, the notes—they were symbols of his devotion, of his commitment to keeping her safe.

But Liam had poisoned everything.

Ethan’s breathing steadied as his resolve hardened. He wasn’t finished. Not yet.

“She’ll see the truth,” he whispered, his voice steady now. “And when she does, she’ll understand.”

The knife glinted in the dim light as Ethan picked it up, his grip firm and deliberate.

This wasn’t over.

Not by a long shot.

The night felt darker than usual as Samantha sat at the kitchen table, her fingers tracing the edge of her phone. Her parents were in the living room, the faint sound of the television filtering through the house, but the noise did little to ease her growing sense of unease.

Liam’s words from earlier repeated in her mind:

UNSEEN CHAINS

“We have to tell someone. He’s not going to stop.”

She knew he was right. The look in Ethan’s eyes during their conversation had been enough to convince her. It wasn’t just obsession anymore—it was desperation.

Her phone buzzed, pulling her from her thoughts. She picked it up to see a message from Liam:

“Are you okay? Did he try to contact you again?”

Samantha typed back quickly: **“I’m fine. No, he hasn’t said anything. But I’m scared, Liam. What if he...”**

Her fingers hesitated over the keyboard before she hit send.

At the cabin, Ethan sat hunched over his notebook, the pen flying across the page as he scribbled frantically. The words spilled out like a mantra, their repetition grounding him as his thoughts spiraled:

“She’ll see. She’ll understand. She’ll thank me.”

The knife rested beside him on the table, its blade gleaming in the flickering lantern light. He reached for it, running his fingers along the hilt as he pictured Liam’s face—the smug, self-assured expression that had haunted him for weeks.

Liam was the problem. Liam was the obstacle standing between Ethan and Samantha.

Ethan’s grip tightened on the knife.

“He’s taken everything from me,” he muttered, his voice low and strained. “But I’ll fix it. I’ll fix everything.”

The next morning, Samantha met Liam at the café near school, her hands trembling as she clutched her cup of coffee. The bright, cheerful atmosphere of the café felt at odds with the weight of the conversation they were about to have.

“I talked to my mom,” she said quietly, her gaze fixed on the table. “She’s calling the school today.”

Liam nodded, his expression grim. “Good. We can’t handle this on our own, Sam. He’s dangerous.”

“I just...” Samantha hesitated, her chest tightening. “I feel guilty. Like, I should have seen it sooner.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

“This isn’t your fault,” Liam said firmly, his hand resting on hers. “He’s the one who’s been doing this. He’s the one who’s crossed every line.”

Samantha nodded, though the knot of guilt in her chest remained. She thought of Ethan’s face during their confrontation—the mixture of hope and desperation in his eyes—and felt a pang of sadness despite her fear.

“What if he tries to hurt someone?” she asked softly.

Liam’s jaw tightened. “Then we stop him before he gets the chance.”

Ethan watched from across the street, his heart pounding as he saw Samantha and Liam sitting together in the café.

The way Liam leaned toward her, the way Samantha let him—it was a betrayal Ethan hadn’t been prepared for.

She’s choosing him, he thought, his chest tightening painfully. **She’s letting him win.**

His fists clenched at his sides as he turned and walked away, his mind racing.

This wasn’t over.

Not yet.

Samantha and Liam walked back to school together, their conversation low and tense. Samantha glanced over her shoulder more than once, the nagging feeling of being watched making her skin crawl.

“You okay?” Liam asked, his tone concerned.

“Yeah,” Samantha said quickly, though her voice wavered.

They reached the school gates, and Samantha hesitated, her hand lingering on the strap of her bag. “Do you think he’s still around?”

Liam’s expression darkened. “I don’t know. But we’re not letting him get any closer.”

Ethan watched them disappear into the school, his body trembling with rage and despair.

They didn’t understand. Samantha didn’t understand.

But she would.

Ethan turned and headed back toward the woods, his footsteps quick and deliberate. The cabin loomed ahead, its dark silhouette blending into the trees.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Inside, the shadow box gleamed faintly in the dim light, a reminder of everything Ethan had sacrificed, everything he had fought for.

He placed the knife on the table, its blade catching the faint glow of the lantern.

“She’ll see the truth,” he whispered, his voice steady now. “Even if I have to show her myself.”

The cabin felt alive with shadows as Ethan sat in the flickering lantern light, his gaze fixed on the shadow box in the corner. The items inside seemed to gleam mockingly, as if accusing him of failure.

The pen case, the charm, the notes—they had been symbols of his devotion, proof of how much he cared. But now, they felt hollow.

Samantha’s voice echoed in his mind:

“I don’t feel safe around you anymore.”

The memory sent a fresh wave of anger surging through him. She was wrong. She didn’t understand what he had done for her, what he had sacrificed. And Liam—Liam was the reason she couldn’t see it.

Ethan’s hand trembled as he reached for the knife, its blade cold and unyielding in his grip. The air in the cabin felt thick, suffocating, as though it too were waiting for him to make his move.

“She’ll see,” he muttered, his voice barely audible over the wind rattling the windows. “I’ll show her. I’ll make her see.”

At school, Samantha sat in the counselor’s office, her hands clasped tightly in her lap. The room was quiet, the faint hum of the overhead lights the only sound as she recounted the events of the past few weeks.

The counselor listened intently, her expression a mix of concern and professionalism.

“And he admitted to writing the notes?” the counselor asked, her pen hovering over a notepad.

Samantha nodded, her chest tightening. “He said he was protecting me, but...it didn’t feel right. He’s not okay.”

The counselor set the pen down, folding her hands on the desk. “You did the right thing coming here, Samantha. This isn’t something you should have to handle on your own.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha nodded again, though the knot of anxiety in her chest remained.

“What happens now?” she asked quietly.

“We’ll contact his parents,” the counselor said gently. “And the school will take appropriate steps to ensure your safety. You’re not alone in this.”

The words were meant to be reassuring, but Samantha still felt uneasy.

Liam waited for Samantha outside the office, his arms crossed as he leaned against the wall. When she emerged, her expression heavy, he straightened.

“How’d it go?” he asked.

Samantha shrugged, pulling her jacket tighter around herself. “They said they’ll take care of it, but...I don’t know. I just want this to be over.”

“It will be,” Liam said firmly. “They’ll make sure he can’t get near you again.”

Samantha hesitated, her gaze drifting down the hallway. “Do you think he knows?”

Liam frowned. “Knows what?”

“That I went to the school,” Samantha said quietly.

Ethan sat in the woods just outside the school, his breath visible in the cold air as he waited. He had seen Samantha enter the counselor’s office earlier, her face pale and tense, and the realization of what she was doing had hit him like a punch to the gut.

She was turning against him.

Ethan’s chest tightened as the thought took hold. She was choosing Liam, believing his lies, and now she was trying to cut Ethan out of her life entirely.

The idea was unbearable.

Ethan’s grip on the knife tightened as he watched her and Liam leave the building together, their voices low and their heads close.

They didn’t notice him as they passed, their attention focused on each other.

Ethan’s jaw clenched as he watched them walk away, his thoughts growing darker with each passing moment.

UNSEEN CHAINS

She'll understand, he thought. **She has to.**

The woods were eerily silent as Ethan walked the familiar path back to the cabin, the moonlight filtering through the twisted branches above. The cold air bit at his face, but he barely noticed. His thoughts were louder than the wind, sharper than the knife he carried.

His grip on the bag's strap tightened as the cabin came into view, its dark silhouette blending with the shadows of the trees.

Inside, the air was thick with the scent of mildew and old wood, the faint flicker of the lantern casting jagged shadows across the walls. Ethan dropped his bag onto the table, the knife clattering against the worn surface as he sat heavily in the chair.

The notebook lay open, its pages covered in frantic scrawls and fragmented plans. Ethan flipped to the most recent entry, his hand trembling slightly as he traced the words he had written earlier:

"Remove the problem. Fix everything."

Liam's face flashed in his mind, his smug smile, the way he leaned toward Samantha like he had any right to be near her.

Ethan's chest tightened as he reached for the knife, its cold weight grounding him as he turned it over in his hands.

"This ends now," he muttered, his voice low and strained. "No more waiting."

The next day at school, Samantha felt the tension before she even stepped through the doors. The hallways buzzed with quiet murmurs, students exchanging glances as they passed her.

"Do you think they know?" she whispered to Liam as they walked to their lockers.

Liam frowned, his brow furrowing. "Know what?"

"About Ethan," Samantha said, her voice tight.

Liam hesitated, glancing over his shoulder before leaning closer. "They'll find out soon enough. The school has to deal with him now."

Samantha nodded, though the unease in her chest remained. She couldn't shake the feeling that Ethan was watching her, waiting just out of sight.

Ethan lingered in the parking lot, his hoodie pulled up against the cold wind as he watched the students filter into the building. His chest burned with anger as he spotted Samantha and Liam walking together, their heads close as they spoke.

UNSEEN CHAINS

They had turned her against him.

Ethan's fists clenched at his sides as he imagined the lies Liam must have told her, the way he had poisoned her mind.

He's the problem. He's always been the problem.

The thought repeated like a mantra as Ethan stepped back into the shadows, his mind racing.

Today, he would take action.

Samantha's day dragged on, her nerves stretched thin as the hours passed. She tried to focus in class, but her thoughts kept drifting back to Ethan—the look in his eyes, the intensity in his voice when he had confronted her.

It wasn't just fear anymore. It was dread.

By lunchtime, she couldn't take it anymore. "I need to get out of here," she said to Liam as they sat at their usual table in the courtyard.

"What do you mean?" Liam asked, frowning.

"I just... I can't be here right now," Samantha said, her voice shaking. "I feel like he's everywhere."

Liam nodded slowly, his gaze scanning the courtyard. "Alright. Let's go somewhere. Anywhere you want."

Samantha hesitated before nodding. "The library. It's quiet there."

Ethan watched from the far edge of the courtyard, his chest tightening as he saw Samantha and Liam stand.

They were leaving together. Again.

His nails bit into his palms as he turned and walked toward the woods, his footsteps heavy and deliberate.

The cabin felt colder than usual when he entered, the faint creak of the wooden boards echoing in the stillness. Ethan set his bag down on the table, pulling out the knife and laying it beside the notebook.

His breathing steadied as he opened the notebook and flipped to a blank page. His hand trembled as he began to write, each word pressing deeper into the paper:

"Tonight. No more waiting. No more lies."

UNSEEN CHAINS

The shadow box gleamed faintly in the corner, its contents a reminder of everything he had done for Samantha.

“She’ll see the truth,” Ethan whispered, his voice steady now. “And when she does, she’ll understand.”

The wind howled outside, rattling the windows as though urging him forward. Ethan stood, his resolve hardening as he grabbed the knife and slipped it into his bag.

This was the only way.

The evening came quickly, the town bathed in the soft orange glow of the setting sun. Samantha sat at her desk, her textbook open in front of her, though she hadn’t turned a page in over an hour.

Her phone buzzed, and she snatched it up quickly, expecting a message from Liam. Instead, the notification came from an unknown number.

“I need to see you. One last time.”

Her heart stopped. She knew who it was before she even opened the message.

Ethan.

Her fingers hovered over the keyboard, her breath coming in shallow bursts. She thought of the counselor’s words earlier that day, of the way Liam had urged her to cut all contact.

But what if ignoring him made things worse?

She typed back hesitantly: **“Ethan, I think it’s best if we don’t talk anymore. I’m sorry.”**

The reply came almost instantly.

“You don’t mean that. You just don’t understand yet. I’ll make it clear. Wait for me.”

Samantha’s chest tightened, fear clawing at her insides as she stared at the screen.

Ethan stood in the woods just beyond Samantha’s house, the darkness wrapping around him like a second skin. He had watched her light flicker on in her bedroom, the faint silhouette of her pacing visible through the curtains.

His phone buzzed in his pocket. He pulled it out and saw her reply—those cold, distant words that felt like knives pressing into his chest.

“Ethan, I think it’s best if we don’t talk anymore. I’m sorry.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

She was still under Liam's spell, still blind to the truth. But that didn't matter. Tonight, he would make her see.

Ethan tightened his grip on the knife in his pocket and stepped closer to the house, his heart pounding in his chest as he approached the back door.

Samantha sat frozen at her desk, the message still glowing on her phone screen. Her breathing quickened as she stood and locked her bedroom door, her hands trembling.

She grabbed her phone and dialed Liam, her heart racing as the line rang once, twice, three times—

"Sam?" Liam's voice was sharp with concern.

"It's him," Samantha said quickly, her voice shaking. "He just texted me. He said he's coming here."

"Stay where you are," Liam said firmly. "Lock all the doors and call the police. I'm on my way."

Samantha nodded, though he couldn't see her. "Okay. Please hurry."

She hung up and dialled 911, her voice trembling as she explained the situation to the dispatcher.

Outside, Ethan crept along the side of the house, his breaths shallow and controlled. The faint glow of Samantha's room guided him, a beacon in the darkness.

He tested the back door handle, but it didn't budge. Locked.

Ethan's jaw tightened as he moved to the side window, his reflection flickering faintly in the glass. He pulled the knife from his pocket and tapped the handle against the pane, the sound sharp and deliberate.

Inside, Samantha froze, her eyes darting to the window as the faint tapping echoed through the house. Her blood ran cold.

"Who's there?" she called, though she already knew the answer.

Ethan didn't reply. He raised the knife again, harder this time, the blade glinting in the faint light as it struck the glass.

Liam's car screeched to a halt in front of Samantha's house, the headlights casting long shadows across the lawn. He jumped out, his heart pounding as he spotted the faint outline of a figure by the side window.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Hey!” he shouted, his voice cutting through the night like a whip.

Ethan turned sharply, his face a mask of anger and frustration. For a moment, the two boys stared at each other, the tension between them palpable.

Liam stepped closer, his fists clenched at his sides. “What the hell are you doing, Ethan? Get away from her house!”

“You don’t understand,” Ethan said, his voice trembling. “She’s mine. She needs me.”

Liam shook his head, his chest tightening as he took another step forward. “You’re sick. Leave her alone, or I swear—”

“You don’t get to tell me what to do!” Ethan screamed, his voice cracking as he lunged forward, the knife glinting in his hand.

Liam reacted instinctively, grabbing a nearby garden chair and swinging it in front of him. The knife struck the metal with a sharp clang, the force of the impact sending Ethan stumbling back.

“Stay down!” Liam shouted, his voice raw.

Ethan glared at him, his chest heaving with rage and desperation. For a moment, it looked like he might charge again—but then the distant sound of sirens cut through the night.

His expression shifted, fear flickering in his eyes as the realization of what was happening sank in.

Ethan turned and fled into the darkness, the shadows swallowing him whole.

Samantha rushed out of the house as the police arrived, her hands trembling as she clung to Liam. The officers fanned out, their flashlights cutting through the trees as they searched for Ethan.

But he was already gone.

Back at the cabin, Ethan sat in the darkness, his breaths coming in uneven gasps as he clutched the knife tightly in his hands. His thoughts swirled chaotically, fragments of the night replaying in his mind.

She doesn’t see it yet. She doesn’t understand.

The sirens still echoed faintly in the distance, a reminder of how close he had come to being caught.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's gaze drifted to the shadow box, its contents glowing faintly in the dim light. The objects that had once brought him comfort now felt like taunts, reminders of everything he had lost.

"She'll see," he whispered, his voice hollow. "She'll understand. One day."

The cabin creaked around him as the wind howled outside, the darkness pressing in like a living thing.

Ethan sat motionless, the knife still in his hands, as the last light of the lantern flickered and died.

First Blood

The cabin felt colder than usual, the wind howling outside like a living thing. Ethan sat hunched over the table, the knife resting in front of him. Its blade gleamed faintly in the lantern light, a constant reminder of his failure the night before.

He replayed the confrontation in his mind, his teeth grinding as Liam's voice echoed in his thoughts:

"You're sick. Leave her alone."

Ethan's hands clenched into fists, his nails biting into his palms. He had given Samantha everything—his devotion, his protection—and she had thrown it all away because of Liam.

Liam, with his smug smile and hollow words, was the problem. He had turned Samantha against Ethan, filling her head with lies, poisoning her thoughts.

"She doesn't see it yet," Ethan muttered, his voice low and trembling. "But she will. Once he's gone, she'll finally understand."

The thought sent a chill through him, but it was quickly replaced by a surge of determination. This was the only way to save her.

The next morning, Samantha sat in the police station with Liam, the events of the previous night weighing heavily on her.

"Can you describe what happened again?" the officer asked, his pen poised over a notepad.

Samantha glanced at Liam, her hands tightening in her lap. "He was outside my house," she said, her voice trembling. "He tried to get in through the window."

"And then he came at me," Liam added, his tone sharp. "He had a knife. If I hadn't stopped him—"

He broke off, his jaw tightening.

The officer nodded, his brow furrowed. "And you said his name is Ethan?"

"Yes," Samantha said quickly. "Ethan Sawyer. He's a student at our school."

The officer scribbled something down before looking up. "We'll contact his parents and let them know about the situation. In the meantime, we'll increase patrols in your area. If you see him again, call us immediately."

Samantha nodded, though the officer's words did little to ease her fear.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Liam walked her home after the meeting, his expression grim. “You should stay with your parents for a few days,” he said. “Don’t go anywhere alone.”

Samantha frowned. “What about you?”

“I can handle myself,” Liam said, though his voice lacked its usual confidence.

The image of Ethan’s face—twisted with anger, his eyes wild and unhinged—flashed through Liam’s mind. He knew Ethan wasn’t going to stop.

But Liam wasn’t going to let him win.

Back at the cabin, Ethan paced the floor, his mind racing with fragmented thoughts. He pictured Liam with Samantha, his arm around her, his voice filling her ears with lies.

The thought made Ethan’s chest tighten with rage.

He grabbed his notebook, flipping to a blank page and scrawling Liam’s name at the top. Beneath it, he began listing everything he had observed about Liam over the past few weeks:

Gym after school. Walks home at 7 PM. Always alone.

Ethan’s pen pressed harder against the paper as he wrote, his grip tightening. His thoughts grew sharper, his plan taking shape.

“Tonight,” he whispered, his voice steady. “It ends tonight.”

The school day passed in a blur, the usual hum of activity replaced by a strange undercurrent of unease. Samantha sat in her final class, her attention drifting as she glanced at her phone.

Liam had messaged her earlier: **“I’ll walk you home after practice. Stay near people until then.”**

She appreciated his protectiveness, but it wasn’t enough to quiet the gnawing sense of dread that had settled in her chest. The memory of Ethan outside her house, the look in his eyes—it lingered, making her stomach churn.

Across town, Ethan sat in his car parked near the gym. He had left the cabin early, his bag packed and his plan carefully laid out in his notebook.

He watched through the windshield as the students began filtering out of the school, their laughter and chatter grating against his nerves.

And then he saw him.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Liam emerged from the building, his gym bag slung over one shoulder and his earbuds in. He walked with the same easy confidence that made Ethan's blood boil.

"Arrogant," Ethan muttered under his breath. "Smug."

He gripped the steering wheel tightly as he watched Liam head toward the track.

The track field was quiet, the faint hum of traffic in the distance the only sound as Liam began his evening run. He liked coming here after practice—it was a chance to clear his head, to push himself without the weight of everything that had been happening.

But tonight, something felt off.

Liam paused at the far end of the track, his breaths visible in the cool evening air. He pulled out one earbud, his brow furrowing as he scanned the empty field.

The faint rustle of leaves caught his attention, but when he turned toward the tree line, there was nothing there.

"Paranoid," he muttered to himself, shaking his head as he resumed his run.

But the unease didn't leave him.

Ethan watched from the shadows, his chest tightening as he followed Liam's movements. The way Liam carried himself, so self-assured, so certain of his place in Samantha's life—it made Ethan's hands tremble with rage.

You don't deserve her. You've never deserved her.

Ethan's grip on the knife in his pocket tightened as he stepped closer, his movements slow and deliberate. The plan he had crafted in his notebook replayed in his mind, each step calculated and precise.

This was the moment he had been waiting for.

As Liam finished his final lap, the unease that had been gnawing at him all evening reached a breaking point. He pulled both earbuds out, stopping near the bleachers to catch his breath.

The silence was heavy now, the usual sounds of the night—distant traffic, rustling leaves—fading into the background.

"Hello?" Liam called, his voice echoing faintly.

No response.

He shook his head, forcing a laugh. **Get a grip, man. It's just your imagination.**

UNSEEN CHAINS

But as he turned toward the parking lot, he caught a glimpse of movement from the corner of his eye.

Liam froze, his heart racing as he turned back toward the bleachers.

A figure stepped out of the shadows, the faint glow of the streetlights illuminating his face.

Ethan.

“Ethan?” Liam said, his voice sharp with confusion and unease. “What the hell are you doing here?”

Ethan took a step closer, his hands trembling at his sides. “You’ve taken everything from me,” he said, his voice low and strained.

Liam frowned, his chest tightening as he took a step back. “What are you talking about?”

“You know what I’m talking about,” Ethan said, his voice rising. “Samantha. You’ve poisoned her against me. You’ve ruined everything.”

Liam’s fists clenched at his sides. “Look, I don’t know what’s going on in your head, but you need to back off. Now.”

Ethan’s lips curled into a faint, bitter smile. “You think you’re so much better than me,” he said, his tone venomous. “But you’re nothing. You don’t deserve her.”

“Deserve her?” Liam repeated, his voice incredulous. “You’re insane, man. Leave her alone.”

Ethan’s chest heaved as his rage boiled over, his hand darting to the knife in his pocket.

“This ends now,” he said, his voice trembling.

Liam’s muscles tensed as Ethan stepped closer, the gleam in his eyes sending a chill down Liam’s spine. The knife glinted faintly in Ethan’s hand, its blade catching the dim glow of the streetlights.

“Ethan, put that down,” Liam said, his voice low and steady. He raised his hands slightly, trying to diffuse the tension. “You don’t want to do this.”

Ethan’s lips curled into a bitter smile. “Don’t I? You’ve done nothing but ruin everything. You’ve lied to her. Manipulated her.”

Liam took a cautious step back, his heart pounding as he calculated the distance between them. “I didn’t do anything to her, Ethan. You’re the one scaring her.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Shut up!” Ethan shouted, his voice cracking. His grip on the knife tightened, his hand trembling as he pointed it at Liam. “You don’t get to talk about her like that! You don’t understand what I’ve done for her!”

“I understand that you’re obsessed,” Liam said, his voice sharp. “And that you need help.”

The words sent a jolt through Ethan, his chest tightening as anger surged through him. “You don’t get it,” he said, his voice low and trembling. “You’ve never understood her. You’ve never deserved her.”

Liam’s gaze flicked to the side, searching for anything he could use to defend himself. The bleachers loomed behind him, their cold metal surface offering no cover.

He took another step back, his pulse racing. “Ethan, listen to me,” he said, his tone measured. “This doesn’t have to end badly. Just put the knife down, and we can talk.”

Ethan’s breath quickened, his vision narrowing as his grip on the knife tightened. “Talk?” he said, his voice laced with bitterness. “You think there’s anything left to say?”

Liam opened his mouth to respond, but Ethan lunged forward, the knife flashing through the air.

Liam reacted instinctively, twisting to the side as the blade grazed his arm. Pain shot through him, but he didn’t have time to process it. He grabbed Ethan’s wrist, forcing the knife downward as they struggled.

The two boys wrestled near the bleachers, their breaths loud and uneven as they fought for control. The knife slipped from Ethan’s grip, clattering to the ground between them.

Liam shoved Ethan backward, his chest heaving as he scrambled to his feet. Blood seeped through his sleeve, the cut on his arm burning like fire.

Ethan stood slowly, his eyes wild as he stared at Liam. The knife lay between them, its blade glinting faintly in the dim light.

“You think this changes anything?” Ethan spat, his voice shaking with rage. “You’re nothing. You’ve always been nothing.”

“And you’re insane,” Liam shot back, his voice steady despite the fear twisting in his chest.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's fists clenched at his sides, his body trembling with barely restrained anger. "She'll see," he muttered, more to himself than to Liam. "She'll understand."

"Stay the hell away from her," Liam said firmly.

For a moment, the two boys stared at each other, the tension between them thick and suffocating.

Then, without warning, Ethan turned and fled into the shadows, disappearing into the night.

Liam dropped to his knees, his breaths coming in short, sharp bursts as the adrenaline drained from his body. His arm throbbed, the blood dripping onto the ground in dark, uneven splatters.

He grabbed his phone with trembling hands, dialing Samantha. The line rang twice before she picked up.

"Liam?" Her voice was panicked, breathless.

"It's him," Liam said, his voice unsteady. "He came after me."

"What?" Samantha's voice cracked. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine," Liam said quickly, though the pain in his arm begged to differ. "He's gone, but—" He broke off, his jaw tightening as he glanced around the empty track. "He's not going to stop, Sam."

Samantha's silence on the other end of the line was deafening.

Back at the cabin, Ethan sat in the darkness, his breaths shallow and uneven. The knife was back in his hands, its blade stained faintly red.

He stared at it, his chest heaving as his mind raced. The confrontation with Liam had gone wrong—Liam was still alive, still standing between him and Samantha.

But this wasn't the end.

Ethan's grip on the knife tightened, his gaze drifting to the shadow box in the corner. The objects inside gleamed faintly in the dim light, a reminder of everything he had fought for.

"She'll see," he whispered, his voice low and unsteady. "This is only the beginning."

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan sat motionless in the cabin, the knife resting in his lap. The room felt suffocatingly quiet, save for the faint creak of the wind pressing against the warped wooden walls.

His chest rose and fell with shallow breaths as he stared at the blade, the faint smear of blood a haunting reminder of the night's events.

It wasn't supposed to happen like this.

Ethan's jaw tightened as anger surged through him, his nails digging into his palms. Liam had fought back, had tried to make him look weak.

But he wasn't weak.

Liam's blood on the knife proved that Ethan had taken the first step.

"She'll understand," Ethan whispered, his voice trembling. "She'll see what I've done for her."

The shadow box loomed in the corner, its contents bathed in the dim glow of the lantern. Samantha's stolen belongings—her pen case, the charm—felt like sacred relics, tangible proof of her connection to him.

Ethan stood abruptly, the chair scraping against the floor as his chest heaved. The blood on the knife seemed to pulse in the flickering light, drawing his gaze like a magnet.

He grabbed a cloth from the table and wiped the blade clean with deliberate movements, his expression hardening.

This wasn't over.

Liam leaned against the edge of the bathroom sink, his breath hissing through clenched teeth as he examined the cut on his arm. Blood stained his shirt, the deep red stark against the pale fabric.

The antiseptic stung as he poured it over the wound, the sharp pain grounding him.

"Liam?" Samantha's voice came from the phone, which rested precariously on the counter.

"I'm here," he said, his voice tight.

"You need to call the police," Samantha said urgently. "You need to report this."

"I will," Liam said, though the idea of reliving the encounter made his stomach churn. "But Sam...he's not done. I know it."

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha was silent for a moment, her breathing audible through the speaker. “I can’t believe this is happening,” she said finally, her voice trembling. “I thought—I thought he just needed help.”

“This isn’t someone who needs help,” Liam said firmly. “This is someone who’s dangerous. To both of us.”

Across town, Samantha sat curled on her bed, her hands gripping her phone tightly. The image of Ethan outside her window replayed in her mind, his eyes wild with desperation.

She had tried to reason with him, to let him down gently, but nothing had worked.

And now Liam was hurt.

A sharp knock at the door jolted her out of her thoughts. “Sam?” Her mom’s voice carried through the closed door.

“Yeah?” Samantha called, her voice wavering.

Her mom opened the door, her expression lined with concern. “Are you okay, sweetie? You’ve been in here all night.”

“I’m fine,” Samantha lied, her throat tightening. “Just...a lot on my mind.”

Her mom nodded slowly but didn’t press further. “Let me know if you need anything, okay?”

“Okay,” Samantha said, forcing a faint smile.

As the door closed, Samantha’s resolve hardened. She couldn’t keep pretending this would go away on its own.

Ethan wasn’t going to stop until someone made him.

Ethan sat at the edge of his bed, the notebook open on his lap. The pages were filled with jagged, frantic writing, the words blurring together as his hand moved across the paper:

“He’s the obstacle. He’s the reason she can’t see me. Remove the problem. Fix everything.”

He paused, his pen hovering over the page. His vision blurred with unshed tears as Samantha’s voice echoed in his mind.

“I don’t feel safe around you anymore.”

The memory burned like a brand, searing through his chest.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's jaw tightened as he ripped the page from the notebook and crumpled it in his fist. He stood abruptly, the bloodied cloth still on the table catching his eye.

"She'll understand," he said again, his voice trembling but resolute. "She has to."

The shadows outside the cabin stretched long and dark as Ethan slipped into the night, his bag slung over one shoulder. His breathing was steady now, his movements deliberate as he stepped onto the familiar path through the woods.

The knife sat heavy in his pocket, its presence both a comfort and a burden.

Ethan's chest tightened as he thought of Samantha, her smile, her laughter, the way she had once looked at him like he was her anchor.

Liam had taken all of that from him.

Ethan's grip tightened on the strap of his bag as his pace quickened, his mind spiraling with plans and possibilities.

This wasn't over.

Not by a long shot.

The woods were silent except for the crunch of leaves beneath Ethan's boots. The faint glow of the town's streetlights cut through the trees ahead, a reminder of the world he had left behind in the cabin's suffocating darkness.

His thoughts churned with fragments of the confrontation with Liam—the sharp clang of the knife against the chair, the blood dripping from Liam's arm. The image was burned into his mind, both a failure and a victory.

He hadn't finished the job, but he had sent a message.

Liam knew now that Ethan wasn't going to back down.

But it wasn't enough.

Ethan reached the edge of the woods, the bright lights of the track field just visible through the gaps in the trees. His grip on the strap of his bag tightened as his gaze fixed on the distant outline of the bleachers.

This was where it had all started to go wrong. Tonight, he would set it right.

Samantha sat on the couch, her knees tucked to her chest as her phone vibrated on the coffee table. Liam's name flashed on the screen, and she quickly snatched it up.

"Hey," she said, her voice shaky. "Are you okay?"

UNSEEN CHAINS

"I called the police," Liam said, his voice tight with exhaustion. "They're opening a report and adding more patrols in the area."

Samantha exhaled slowly, the tension in her chest easing slightly. "Good. That's...that's good."

"But Sam," Liam continued, his tone darkening, "this isn't going to stop him. Not really."

Samantha frowned. "What do you mean?"

"I mean, he's obsessed," Liam said. "And until someone physically stops him, he's not going to give up."

Samantha's stomach twisted at the thought. She glanced toward the window, her heart pounding as the shadows outside seemed to shift and move.

"He's dangerous, Sam," Liam said firmly. "And we need to be ready."

Ethan crouched near the edge of the field, his breaths shallow and controlled as he scanned the empty track. He had been watching for hours, his eyes fixed on the gym doors, waiting for Liam to emerge.

The night air was cold, the frost biting at his skin, but Ethan barely noticed. His focus was absolute.

When the gym doors finally swung open, Ethan's chest tightened. Liam stepped out, his gym bag slung over his shoulder, his phone glowing faintly in his hand.

Ethan's fists clenched as he watched Liam walk toward the parking lot, his movements calm and unhurried, as if nothing had happened.

Arrogant. Smug. He thinks he's untouchable.

Ethan slipped out of the shadows, his footsteps silent against the frost-covered grass as he followed at a distance.

Liam paused near his car, his hand on the door handle. The uneasy feeling that had been gnawing at him all day surged to the forefront of his mind.

He turned sharply, his eyes scanning the dark expanse of the parking lot.

"Ethan?" he called, his voice cutting through the silence.

No response.

Liam's chest tightened as he reached for his phone, his fingers trembling slightly as he dialed Samantha.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The line rang once, twice—

“Liam?” Samantha’s voice came through the speaker, soft but filled with concern.

“He’s here,” Liam said, his voice low. “I know it.”

“What?” Samantha’s voice sharpened. “Where are you?”

“At the school,” Liam said. “In the parking lot.”

“Liam, get out of there,” Samantha said quickly. “Now.”

Liam turned, his pulse racing as he unlocked his car. But before he could open the door, a shadow moved behind him.

“Going somewhere?” Ethan’s voice was low and sharp, cutting through the silence like a knife.

Liam spun around, his chest tightening as he saw Ethan step out of the shadows. His hoodie was pulled up against the cold, but there was no mistaking the glint of the knife in his hand.

“Ethan,” Liam said, his voice steady despite the fear twisting in his gut. “You need to stop this.”

Ethan tilted his head, his gaze intense. “You don’t get to tell me what to do.”

“This isn’t going to fix anything,” Liam said, his tone firm. “It’s only going to make it worse.”

“Worse?” Ethan repeated, his voice trembling with anger. “You’ve already made it worse. You’ve ruined everything.”

Liam’s grip on his phone tightened as he glanced toward the gym, hoping someone else was still inside. But the lot was empty, the building dark and lifeless.

“Ethan,” Liam said carefully, “you don’t want to do this.”

Ethan took a step closer, his knuckles white around the knife’s handle. “You don’t know what I want,” he said, his voice low. “You don’t know anything about me.”

Liam held his ground, his heart racing as Ethan took another step forward. The knife glinted faintly in the dim light, its sharp edge catching the glow from the parking lot’s overhead lamps.

“Ethan,” Liam said, his voice steady but firm, “this isn’t going to end the way you think it will.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's lips curled into a bitter smile. "And how's that, Liam? You think you're going to stop me? You think you can save her from me?"

Liam's gaze flicked to the knife, then back to Ethan's face. The unhinged look in his eyes sent a chill through Liam's chest.

"This isn't about saving her from you," Liam said slowly. "It's about you saving yourself. You don't have to do this."

"You don't get it!" Ethan shouted, his voice cracking as his grip on the knife tightened. "She's mine! She always has been!"

Liam flinched at the venom in Ethan's voice, his stomach twisting with unease. He took a step back, raising his hands in a gesture of peace.

"Look, man," Liam said carefully, "I don't know what's going on in your head, but this isn't the way to fix it. You need help—real help."

Ethan's chest heaved as he stared at Liam, his mind racing. The words sounded like hollow platitudes, empty and meaningless.

"You're the one who needs help," Ethan hissed, his voice trembling. "You've been lying to her, twisting her against me."

Liam shook his head, his fists clenching at his sides. "You're the one twisting everything, Ethan. She's scared of you. She doesn't want this."

The words hit Ethan like a physical blow, his vision blurring with rage.

"Shut up!" he shouted, his voice echoing through the empty lot. "You don't know anything about her! About us!"

Liam braced himself as Ethan lunged, the knife flashing through the air. He twisted to the side, narrowly avoiding the blade as it sliced through his jacket.

"Ethan, stop!" Liam shouted, his voice raw.

But Ethan was relentless. He swung again, the knife grazing Liam's arm. Pain flared, but Liam didn't falter. He shoved Ethan backward, the force of the impact sending the smaller boy stumbling.

"Stay down!" Liam shouted, his voice filled with a mix of anger and fear.

Ethan didn't listen. He scrambled to his feet, his chest heaving as he charged again, the knife clutched tightly in his hand.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Liam reacted instinctively, grabbing the first thing within reach—a heavy metal garbage can lid. He swung it with all his strength, the dull clang echoing through the lot as it struck Ethan's arm.

The knife clattered to the ground, its metallic ring cutting through the tense silence.

Ethan fell to his knees, his hands trembling as he clutched his wrist. His breaths came in shallow, ragged bursts as he stared at the knife lying just out of reach.

Liam stood over him, his chest heaving as adrenaline coursed through his veins. He glanced at the knife, then back at Ethan, whose face was twisted with anger and despair.

“Ethan,” Liam said, his voice sharp but steady, “this has to stop. Right now.”

Ethan's gaze flicked up to Liam, his eyes wild with desperation. “You don't get to take her from me,” he said through gritted teeth. “She's mine. She's always been mine.”

Liam shook his head, his expression filled with a mix of pity and frustration. “She doesn't belong to you. She doesn't belong to anyone.”

Ethan's jaw tightened, his chest heaving with suppressed rage.

“You don't understand,” he said, his voice trembling. “She needs me. I'm the only one who can protect her.”

“She doesn't need you,” Liam said firmly. “What she needs is for you to leave her alone.”

The words hit Ethan like a slap, his body tensing as his mind raced. His gaze shifted to the knife again, his fingers twitching.

But before he could move, the distant wail of sirens broke through the tense silence.

Ethan froze, his breaths coming in sharp gasps as the sound grew louder.

Liam stepped back, his stance still defensive as the flashing red and blue lights illuminated the parking lot.

The police cars screeched to a halt, their doors flying open as officers poured out, their weapons drawn.

“Drop the weapon!” one of them shouted, their voice commanding.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's chest tightened as he glanced between the officers and Liam. His mind raced, panic clawing at the edges of his thoughts.

This wasn't how it was supposed to end.

Ethan raised his hands slowly, his body trembling as he stared at the knife lying on the ground.

The officers moved in quickly, grabbing his arms and pulling him to his feet. Ethan didn't resist, his mind too clouded by despair and anger to focus on anything else.

Liam leaned against his car, his chest heaving as the officers restrained Ethan and began questioning him.

One of them approached Liam, their gaze flicking to the blood staining his jacket. "Are you okay?" they asked, their tone professional but concerned.

"I'm fine," Liam said, though his voice wavered. "Just...glad it's over."

But as he watched Ethan being led away, his stomach twisted with unease.

Something told him this wasn't the end.

Back in the police car, Ethan stared out the window, his expression blank as the town lights blurred past.

This wasn't over.

Not by a long shot.

The sound of Samantha's phone vibrating pulled her from the restless haze she had been lost in. She grabbed it quickly, her pulse racing when she saw Liam's name on the screen.

"Liam?" she answered, her voice sharp with worry. "What happened? Are you okay?"

There was a pause on the other end of the line before Liam spoke, his voice heavy. "He attacked me."

Samantha's heart stopped. "What? When? Where are you?"

"I'm fine," Liam said quickly, though his voice betrayed the exhaustion and tension he was feeling. "It was in the parking lot after practice. The police showed up before it got worse."

Samantha sank onto her bed, her hands trembling as she pressed the phone tighter to her ear. "I knew he wouldn't stop. I knew it."

UNSEEN CHAINS

“He’s in custody now,” Liam said, his tone grim. “But Sam, this isn’t over. He’s not...he’s not right. He thinks he’s doing all of this for you.”

The words sent a chill through Samantha’s chest, her breath hitching as she thought of Ethan’s face the last time she had seen him.

“Liam, what if he—”

“Stop,” Liam interrupted gently. “We’re not going to let him get near you again. You’re safe, Sam.”

Samantha nodded, though the fear twisting in her chest didn’t subside.

At the police station, Ethan sat in the interrogation room, the fluorescent lights casting harsh shadows across his face. His hands were cuffed in front of him, and his eyes were locked on the table in front of him, unblinking.

A detective sat across from him, his notepad resting on the table. “Ethan,” he said slowly, his tone measured, “do you understand why you’re here?”

Ethan didn’t respond. His mind was elsewhere, replaying the confrontation with Liam in vivid detail—the sound of the knife hitting the ground, the way Samantha’s name had echoed in his thoughts.

The detective leaned forward, his gaze steady. “You attacked someone tonight, Ethan. A boy your age. Do you realize how serious this is?”

Ethan’s jaw tightened, his chest rising and falling with shallow breaths. “He deserved it,” he muttered finally, his voice barely audible.

“Why do you say that?” the detective asked, his tone calm.

Ethan’s eyes flicked up to meet the detective’s, his gaze sharp and unrelenting. “He’s the reason she’s confused. He’s the one keeping her from seeing the truth.”

The detective exchanged a glance with the officer standing by the door, his expression unreadable.

“Who’s ‘she’?” the detective asked.

Ethan’s lips curled into a faint, bitter smile. “Samantha,” he said softly, as though the name itself was a sacred word.

The next morning, Samantha sat at the kitchen table, her hands wrapped around a mug of coffee she had no intention of drinking. Her mom sat across from her, concern etched across her face.

“Sweetie, you need to tell me what’s going on,” her mom said gently.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha hesitated, her stomach twisting. “It’s Ethan,” she said finally. “He’s...he’s not okay. And last night, he went after Liam.”

Her mom’s eyes widened, her hand flying to her chest. “Oh my God. Is Liam alright?”

“He’s fine,” Samantha said quickly, though the knot of fear in her chest didn’t loosen. “But Ethan...he’s obsessed with me, Mom. He thinks everything he’s doing is for me.”

Her mom reached across the table, taking Samantha’s hand in hers. “We’ll make sure he can’t hurt you,” she said firmly. “I promise.”

Samantha nodded, though the promise felt fragile, like it could shatter under the weight of her fear.

At school, Liam was the center of whispered conversations. The cut on his arm, hastily bandaged and peeking out from under his jacket, drew curious glances and murmurs as he walked through the halls.

Samantha found him by the lockers, her chest tightening as she saw his tired expression.

“Hey,” she said softly, her hand brushing his arm. “How are you holding up?”

Liam shrugged, though his eyes betrayed his exhaustion. “I’m fine,” he said, forcing a faint smile. “You don’t have to worry about me.”

“I do, though,” Samantha said, her voice trembling. “He went after you because of me.”

“Sam,” Liam said, his tone firm but kind, “none of this is your fault. He’s the one who’s doing this. Not you.”

Samantha nodded, though the guilt in her chest remained.

Back at the cabin, the silence was deafening. The shadow box sat undisturbed in the corner, its contents gleaming faintly in the dim light.

The knife lay on the table, its blade clean but still carrying the weight of the night’s events.

Ethan stood near the window, his gaze fixed on the trees outside. The faint sound of birds chirping felt out of place, almost mocking in its cheerfulness.

He clenched his fists at his sides, his thoughts swirling. The police hadn’t understood him. They had taken him in, questioned him, and then released him on the condition that he stay away from Liam and Samantha.

UNSEEN CHAINS

But they didn't see the truth.

Liam was the problem.

And Samantha needed him.

Ethan turned to the shadow box, his expression hardening. The objects inside weren't just memories—they were reminders of his devotion, his sacrifice.

"This isn't over," he muttered, his voice low and steady.

He grabbed the notebook from the table, flipping to a blank page. His pen moved quickly, the words pouring out like a mantra:

"She'll understand. She'll see the truth. This is only the beginning."

The wind rattled the windows as Ethan closed the notebook and stood, his resolve hardening.

The first step had been taken.

Now, it was time for the next.

The New Samantha

The years had been kind to Samantha Hayes. At twenty-four, she had built a life she was proud of—a promising career in event planning, a cozy apartment in the city, and a loving relationship with Liam West. The horrors of her teenage years, though never fully forgotten, had faded into the background of her busy and fulfilling life.

But shadows lingered where light shone brightest.

Ethan Carter, now 25, had spent the past seven years in quiet, obsessive preparation. After the events of his teenage years—the attack on Liam, the confrontation with Samantha, and his arrest—his wealthy parents had stepped in, desperate to protect their family’s reputation.

Rather than allow Ethan to face public scrutiny or legal consequences, they had sent him abroad to an exclusive boarding school in Switzerland. The hope had been that a change in environment, far removed from Samantha and his past, would break his fixation and set him on a new path.

But they couldn’t have been more wrong.

Ethan excelled academically, his intelligence and focus earning him accolades from his professors. On the surface, he was the picture of a reformed young man—poised, disciplined, and eager to succeed.

Yet behind closed doors, Ethan’s obsession with Samantha only deepened. He kept her picture hidden in a locket, wearing it beneath his uniform like a sacred talisman. Every letter or message from home became a source of information, feeding his hunger for updates about Samantha’s life.

Ethan graduated with honors, his parents proud of what they believed was his transformation. But when Ethan returned to his family’s sprawling mansion at 25, it became clear they had merely given him time to sharpen his skills and cultivate his obsession.

Now back home, Ethan spent his days pretending to be the dutiful son, helping his father manage the estate’s finances and entertaining his mother’s social circle when required. But his nights were consumed by something far darker.

The cabin in the woods—long abandoned and hidden from prying eyes—was Ethan’s sanctuary. It had remained untouched for years, the floorboards warped, and the air thick with dust and decay. Yet to Ethan, it was sacred.

UNSEEN CHAINS

In the dim light of a lantern, Ethan sat at the small, rickety table where it had all begun. Papers, photographs, and stolen artifacts were spread before him. At the center of it all was the shadow box, now a grotesque shrine. Locks of Samantha's hair were pinned alongside pictures of her smiling at various stages of her life. Her stolen pen rested next to an old charm bracelet he had snatched from her locker years ago.

Ethan traced a finger over one of the photographs, his expression cold and focused. It was a recent picture—one he had taken just days ago. Samantha stood on a sunlit street, laughing as she held hands with Liam.

The sight of Liam beside her made Ethan's chest tighten with rage.

"She doesn't belong with you," Ethan muttered, his voice low and trembling. "She's always belonged to me."

Samantha stood in the kitchen of her apartment, humming softly as she prepared dinner. The scent of garlic and herbs filled the air, and she smiled to herself, glancing at her phone to check the time. Liam would be home soon.

She leaned against the counter, scrolling absentmindedly through her social media feed. A picture of her uncle James appeared, posted by her cousin earlier that day. Samantha's smile widened as she thought of him—always the steady, reassuring presence in her life.

The photo showed James at his woodworking shop, his sleeves rolled up as he worked on a project. "Still tinkering away," she said to herself with a fond laugh.

Unbeknownst to her, Ethan had seen the same picture hours earlier. It had only fuelled the fire that burned in him.

Later that evening, Ethan sat in his car, parked just beyond the tree line near Samantha's apartment. The engine idled as he stared at the glowing screen of his phone. Samantha's picture filled the display—a candid shot of her and Liam walking through the park.

Ethan's grip tightened on the steering wheel, his knuckles whitening as his thoughts spiralled.

"She doesn't see it yet," he whispered, his voice trembling. "But she will. I've waited long enough."

He reached into the passenger seat and picked up his notebook, flipping to a page filled with scrawled plans and sketches. In the center of the page was Liam's name, circled and underlined multiple times.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's gaze hardened as he closed the notebook and set it aside.

"First, I'll deal with him," he muttered, his voice cold and resolute. "Then she'll finally be free."

The streets were quiet as Ethan parked his car a block away from Samantha's apartment. He turned off the engine and sat in silence, his gaze fixed on the dimly lit building. The occasional shadow passed by her window, and his pulse quickened with every flicker of movement.

She was there. She was always there.

Ethan leaned back in his seat, his fingers drumming against the steering wheel. He had memorized her routines—when she left for work, when she returned, the nights Liam stayed over. He had been careful not to get too close, always watching from a safe distance.

Tonight was different.

Ethan slipped on a pair of gloves, the thin leather creaking softly as he flexed his fingers. He opened the glove compartment and pulled out a small pair of binoculars. Raising them to his eyes, he focused on her window.

Samantha sat on the couch, her laughter faint but audible through the cracked window. Liam was beside her, his arm draped casually over her shoulders as they watched something on the television.

The sight made Ethan's jaw tighten.

He lowered the binoculars, his breathing shallow as his thoughts raced. Liam's presence was a constant thorn in his side—a parasite leeching Samantha's attention and affection.

You don't deserve her,

Ethan thought, his hands gripping the binoculars tightly.

You've stolen everything from me.

Inside the apartment, Samantha leaned into Liam, a warm smile on her face as she watched him fumble with the remote. "You're terrible at this," she teased, nudging him playfully.

"Hey, I'm just getting started," Liam replied with a grin.

Their laughter filled the room, a sound that would have once brought Samantha nothing but joy. But tonight, there was an undercurrent of unease.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Her mind drifted back to earlier that day, when she had sworn she'd seen someone watching her from across the street. The figure had been gone when she looked again, but the feeling lingered, clawing at the edges of her thoughts.

"Samantha?" Liam's voice pulled her back to the present.

"Hmm?" she said, forcing a smile.

"You okay?" he asked, his brow furrowing slightly. "You've been quiet."

"I'm fine," she lied, her fingers twisting a loose thread on her sweater. "Just...long day at work."

Liam nodded, though his eyes lingered on her face, searching for something unspoken. "Well, if you need to talk, you know I'm here," he said softly.

Samantha's smile widened slightly. "I know."

But as she leaned back into him, her gaze flicked toward the window, the unease in her chest refusing to dissipate.

Ethan's hands trembled as he lowered the binoculars and turned his attention to the notebook on the passenger seat. He flipped to the latest page, where a crudely drawn map of Samantha's neighbourhood filled the margins. Her apartment building was circled in red, with notes detailing entry points, blind spots, and the location of nearby security cameras.

Ethan's pen hovered over the page as he added a final detail—a small X marked where Liam parked his car.

"She'll see the truth," he muttered under his breath. "Once he's gone, she'll finally see me."

His phone buzzed, pulling him from his thoughts. He glanced at the screen, a faint smile tugging at his lips as he read the notification.

It was a social media post—Samantha's. She had shared a picture of her uncle James earlier that evening, along with a caption: **"Always proud of everything he builds ❤️."**

Ethan's smile widened.

James. The name carried weight in Ethan's mind, a mix of resentment and envy. James had always been there for Samantha, a pillar of strength and support. Ethan had hated him for it—hated the way Samantha looked up to him, trusted him.

But now, James was a means to an end.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's gaze shifted back to Samantha's apartment. The lights flickered off one by one, leaving the building bathed in shadow.

He closed the notebook, his movements slow and deliberate as he placed it back in the glove compartment. The engine roared to life, and he drove away, his thoughts sharper and more focused than they had been in years.

Back at the mansion, Ethan retreated to his room, locking the door behind him. The shadow box gleamed faintly in the moonlight, its contents casting jagged shadows on the walls.

He approached it slowly, his fingers brushing against the glass as his breathing steadied.

"She'll understand," Ethan whispered, his voice barely audible. "She'll thank me when it's done."

His gaze drifted to a picture pinned in the corner of the box—a candid shot of James and Samantha from years ago, laughing together at a family picnic.

Ethan's jaw tightened as he pulled the photo from its place, the edges curling slightly in his grip.

"This is where it begins," he muttered, his voice low and cold.

He folded the photo carefully and slipped it into his pocket.

The cabin would be his next stop.

The road to the cabin was rough and overgrown, the headlights of Ethan's car barely piercing the dense woods. Branches scraped against the windows, creating faint, whispering sounds that matched the chaotic rhythm of his thoughts.

Ethan gripped the steering wheel tightly, his knuckles pale against the leather. The folded photograph of James and Samantha sat on the passenger seat, a constant reminder of what needed to be done.

"She'll understand," Ethan muttered under his breath, his voice barely audible over the hum of the engine. "This is for her. This is all for her."

The cabin loomed ahead, its crooked silhouette barely visible in the moonlight. The years had not been kind to the structure—the roof sagged, the windows were cracked, and the door hung on rusted hinges. Yet to Ethan, it was perfect.

This was where it had all started, and this was where it would all end.

Inside, the air was heavy with the scent of damp wood and decay. Ethan lit a lantern, the dim light casting jagged shadows across the walls. The rickety table

UNSEEN CHAINS

in the center of the room was littered with old papers, notebooks, and tools, remnants of his earlier plans.

Ethan placed the photograph in the center of the table, smoothing it out carefully. His hands trembled slightly as he stared at it, his mind racing with possibilities.

James had always been an obstacle. He was a constant presence in Samantha's life, a source of support and stability that Ethan envied with every fiber of his being. But more than that, James represented the life Ethan could never have—the warmth, the laughter, the love.

“You took her from me,” Ethan whispered, his voice trembling. “You took everything from me.”

His gaze shifted to the shadow box mounted on the wall, its grotesque contents illuminated by the flickering light. The items within—locks of Samantha's hair, stolen trinkets, faded photographs—were symbols of his devotion, but they weren't enough anymore.

Ethan reached for the notebook on the table, flipping to the most recent page. The words scrawled across it were erratic, barely legible:

“Eliminate the obstacle. Make her see.”

He picked up a knife from the table, its blade dull but sturdy. He turned it over in his hands, the metal cold against his skin as he imagined the act—quick, deliberate, final.

The cabin creaked as Ethan moved to the corner, where a weathered trunk sat covered in dust. He opened it slowly, revealing an array of items he had collected over the years: ropes, tarps, duct tape, and other tools of his twisted trade.

This wasn't a spur-of-the-moment decision. Ethan had been planning this for years, waiting for the right time to act.

And now, with James so close and Samantha within reach, the time had finally come.

Ethan closed the trunk and stood, his silhouette casting long, jagged shadows across the walls. The knife gleamed faintly in the lantern light as he slipped it into his pocket.

He glanced at the photograph one last time, his expression cold and unrelenting.

“This is where it begins,” he muttered.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The wind howled outside as Ethan extinguished the lantern, plunging the cabin into darkness.

Back at the mansion, Ethan's parents were oblivious to his absence. They had long since stopped questioning his late-night disappearances, content to believe their son was simply an eccentric recluse.

In his room, the shadow box remained untouched, a shrine to Samantha's innocence and beauty. But Ethan no longer needed to stare at it for inspiration.

Now, he had a mission.

The morning sun broke through the trees, casting fractured beams of light over the quiet suburb where James Hayes lived. The air was crisp, the kind of day where life felt vibrant and peaceful—except for the man sitting in the dark sedan parked a few houses down.

Ethan adjusted the rearview mirror, catching a glimpse of himself. His face was calm, his expression neutral, but his eyes betrayed the storm churning beneath the surface.

James's car was in the driveway, as it always was on Saturdays. Ethan had memorized his routine over the past week—early mornings spent at his woodworking shop, followed by a visit to Samantha's apartment or her cousin's house.

Ethan's gaze lingered on the house. James had always exuded a quiet strength, the kind of man Samantha could rely on without question. Ethan hated him for it.

"You're in the way," Ethan muttered under his breath, gripping the steering wheel tightly.

He watched as the front door opened and James stepped out, his sleeves rolled up and a thermos in hand. He was headed for his truck, his movements unhurried.

Ethan's chest tightened as he started the engine, keeping a safe distance as James pulled out of the driveway. The truck's taillights disappeared down the road, and Ethan followed, his hands steady on the wheel.

The woodworking shop was a small, rustic building on the outskirts of town, surrounded by dense woods. James parked near the entrance, climbing out with his thermos and a toolbox. Ethan pulled off the road a short distance away, hidden among the trees.

He sat in the car, watching as James unlocked the door and stepped inside.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The shop was quiet for the next hour, the occasional sound of a saw or hammer drifting out into the still morning air. Ethan waited, his patience unshakable.

Finally, James emerged, his hands full with a few wooden pieces. He loaded them into the back of the truck before heading inside again.

Ethan's gaze shifted to the truck, his mind racing.

What if I make it look like an accident?

The thought flickered briefly before he dismissed it. No, it had to be personal. James had to know why this was happening.

Ethan stepped out of the car, his movements deliberate and silent as he approached the shop. The cool air bit at his skin, but he barely noticed. His focus was absolute.

Inside the shop, James hummed to himself as he worked, the rhythmic sound of the saw cutting through the quiet. The scent of freshly cut wood filled the air, mingling with the faint metallic tang of tools.

Ethan stepped inside, the creak of the door loud in the otherwise silent space.

James looked up, startled. "Can I help you?"

For a moment, Ethan said nothing, his gaze sweeping over the room. The walls were lined with shelves of tools, and sawdust coated the floor like a fine layer of ash.

"You're James Hayes," Ethan said finally, his voice low and steady.

James frowned, setting down the piece of wood he'd been working on. "Yeah. Do I know you?"

Ethan took a step closer, his hands slipping into the pockets of his jacket. "Not really," he said. "But I know you."

James's frown deepened, his posture shifting slightly as unease crept into his expression. "Look, if you're here to buy something, the shop's not open right now. You'll have to come back—"

"I'm not here to buy anything," Ethan interrupted, his voice sharp.

The tension in the room thickened as James studied him. "Then what do you want?"

Ethan pulled the folded photograph from his pocket and held it up. James's eyes flicked to it, his brow furrowing as he recognized the image.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“That’s...that’s from Samantha’s post,” James said slowly. “What does this have to do with her?”

Ethan’s lips curled into a faint, bitter smile. “Everything.”

James took a step back, his unease giving way to something colder. “Who are you?” he demanded.

Ethan stepped closer, his movements deliberate. “I’m the one who’s going to make sure she gets what she deserves,” he said, his voice trembling with a mix of anger and twisted conviction.

James’s expression hardened as he reached for his phone. “You need to leave—now.”

But before he could dial, Ethan lunged.

The struggle was brief but violent. The phone clattered to the ground as James fought back, his strength surprising Ethan. The two men grappled, the scent of sawdust and sweat filling the air as the sounds of their struggle echoed through the shop.

Ethan’s hand closed around a nearby hammer, and he swung it with all his strength.

James staggered, blood streaking his forehead as he fell to the ground. His breaths came in sharp, ragged bursts as he tried to push himself up, but Ethan was already standing over him, the hammer poised for another strike.

“You’ve taken everything from me,” Ethan snarled, his voice shaking. “But not anymore.”

The hammer came down again, and the shop fell silent.

Ethan stood over James’s lifeless body, his chest heaving as blood pooled on the sawdust-covered floor. He wiped his hands on his jacket, his movements slow and deliberate as he surveyed the scene.

His gaze drifted to the photograph lying on the ground, now spattered with blood. He picked it up carefully, his fingers trembling as he folded it and slipped it back into his pocket.

This was only the beginning.

Ethan stepped outside, the cold air biting at his skin as he locked the shop door behind him. The woods swallowed him as he disappeared into the trees, leaving only silence and blood in his wake.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha was wrapping up a morning meeting at the event planning office when her phone buzzed on the desk beside her. She glanced down to see her cousin's name flashing on the screen.

"Hey, is everything okay?" Samantha asked, tucking her phone between her ear and shoulder as she sorted through a stack of papers.

There was a pause on the other end, long enough for Samantha to notice the faint tremble in her cousin's breathing.

"It's Uncle James," her cousin said finally, her voice thick with worry. "He's...he hasn't come home."

Samantha froze, the papers slipping from her hands. "What do you mean he hasn't come home?"

"He left for the shop early this morning, but he's not answering his phone," her cousin explained, the words spilling out in a rush. "Mom's called him a dozen times, and we even drove by the shop. His truck is still there, but the place was locked up. It's not like him, Sam."

Samantha's chest tightened as she stood, grabbing her coat from the back of her chair. "Have you called the police?"

"Not yet," her cousin admitted. "Mom thinks we're overreacting, but—"

"Call them," Samantha said firmly, her voice trembling. "I'm heading to the shop now."

The drive to the woodworking shop felt longer than it should have, each turn of the wheel marked by a growing sense of dread. Samantha's thoughts raced, memories of her uncle flooding her mind. He had always been the steady presence in her life, the person she turned to when things felt uncertain.

The idea of him being hurt—or worse—was almost unbearable.

When she arrived, her stomach twisted at the sight of James's truck still parked in its usual spot. The shop was eerily quiet, the windows dark and uninviting.

Samantha climbed out of her car, her breath visible in the cold air as she approached the door. She knocked loudly, the sound echoing in the silence.

"Uncle James?" she called, her voice trembling.

No answer.

Her hand moved to the doorknob, but it wouldn't budge. It was locked, just as her cousin had said.

UNSEEN CHAINS

She stepped back, her gaze flicking to the surrounding woods. The shadows between the trees seemed to shift, as though something—or someone—was watching her.

Miles away, Ethan sat at the cabin, his hands trembling as he flipped through the bloodstained notebook.

His mind raced with fragmented thoughts, each one louder and more chaotic than the last.

He's gone. She'll see now. She'll understand.

Ethan's gaze drifted to the shadow box, its contents glowing faintly in the lantern light. The photograph of James and Samantha was back in its place, the blood smeared across its surface drying in jagged streaks.

"She'll thank me," Ethan whispered, his voice trembling. "She'll finally see that I've been here all along."

The wind howled outside, rattling the windows as Ethan stood, his resolve hardening. He grabbed the notebook and slipped it into his bag.

It wasn't over yet.

Back at the woodworking shop, Samantha paced near the entrance as the faint sound of sirens approached in the distance. Her cousin had finally called the police, and now all they could do was wait.

Her gaze drifted to the ground near the door, where something dark and sticky caught her eye. She crouched down, her heart pounding as she reached out to touch it.

It was blood.

Samantha's stomach lurched as she stumbled back, her breathing ragged. The growing dread in her chest exploded into full-blown panic.

The sound of the sirens grew louder, the flashing red and blue lights cutting through the trees as the police arrived. Samantha ran to meet them, her words tumbling out in a frantic rush.

"He's in there," she said, pointing to the shop. "Something's wrong. There's blood—"

The officers exchanged a glance before moving toward the door, their hands on their weapons.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha stood frozen, her arms wrapped around herself as she watched them break the lock and disappear inside.

Moments later, one of the officers emerged, his expression grim.

“Miss Hayes,” he said gently, his tone laced with sympathy. “We need you to stay back. This is now a crime scene.”

Samantha’s world tilted, her legs threatening to give out beneath her. She clung to the side of her car, her chest heaving as she tried to process what the officer had said.

A crime scene.

Her uncle was gone.

And in the back of her mind, a thought she didn’t want to acknowledge began to creep forward—a dark, insistent whisper that sent chills down her spine.

This felt too familiar.

This felt like Ethan.

The air inside the woodworking shop was heavy with the metallic scent of blood and sawdust. Detective Laura Mills stepped carefully over the stained floorboards, her sharp eyes scanning the room.

She had seen her share of violent crime scenes in her decade-long career, but something about this one felt different. The brutality wasn’t random; it was deliberate, almost ritualistic.

James Hayes’s body lay sprawled on the ground, his head caved in, the blood pooling around him in jagged streaks. Tools were scattered nearby, but the hammer resting near the body made it clear what the weapon had been.

Mills crouched down, her gloved hand hovering over the bloodied hammer. She noted the way it had been placed—almost carefully, as though the killer had wanted it to be found.

“This wasn’t spur of the moment,” Mills muttered, mostly to herself. “Whoever did this planned it.”

The officer beside her, a young rookie named Andrews, shifted uncomfortably. “Should we start canvassing the area for witnesses?” he asked.

Mills nodded without looking up. “Do that. And get a timeline from the family. I want to know exactly when Hayes was last seen and who he was supposed to meet today.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Yes, ma’am,” Andrews said before stepping outside.

Mills stood, her gaze sweeping the room again. She moved to the workbench, where a faint impression in the dust caught her attention. Something had been sitting here recently—a photograph, perhaps, or a piece of paper—but it was gone now.

Her lips pressed into a thin line as she pulled out her notebook and jotted down the detail.

Outside, Samantha stood near her car, her arms wrapped around herself as the cold seeped through her coat. The flashing lights of the police cars cast harsh shadows across her pale face.

Detective Mills approached her carefully, her expression professional but sympathetic. “Miss Hayes?”

Samantha looked up, her eyes red and glassy. “Yes?”

“I’m Detective Mills,” she said, holding up her badge briefly before slipping it back into her pocket. “I know this is difficult, but I need to ask you a few questions.”

Samantha nodded shakily.

“When was the last time you saw your uncle?” Mills asked gently.

“Last weekend,” Samantha said, her voice trembling. “He came over for dinner. We talked about his work, and he seemed...he seemed fine.”

“Did he mention meeting anyone today? Or any unusual activity recently?”

Samantha shook her head. “No. He was...he was always so careful. He didn’t have enemies. I don’t understand why anyone would—” Her voice broke, and she covered her mouth with her hand.

Mills waited a moment before continuing. “Miss Hayes, has anything strange been happening in your life recently? Anything that might feel unrelated but could help us?”

Samantha hesitated, the weight of an unspoken thought pressing against her. **Ethan.**

The name echoed in her mind, the memories of his obsessive behaviour and violent tendencies rushing back like a flood.

“There was someone,” she said finally, her voice barely above a whisper. “A long time ago. He...he was obsessed with me.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Mills's expression sharpened. "What was his name?"

"Ethan Carter," Samantha said. "We were in school together. He attacked my boyfriend at the time and...and he was arrested. But he was released."

Mills scribbled the name into her notebook. "Do you think he could be involved in this?"

"I don't know," Samantha admitted, her voice trembling. "I haven't seen or heard from him in years. But this...it feels like something he would do."

Mills nodded, her mind already piecing together the threads. "Thank you, Miss Hayes. We'll look into it."

Later that evening, Detective Mills sat in her office, poring over old case files. Ethan Carter's name appeared in several reports—stalking, harassment, assault. His arrest for attacking Liam West had been a major incident, but it was the lack of follow-up that caught Mills's attention.

Sent abroad for schooling, no further incidents reported.

Mills leaned back in her chair, her brow furrowing. If Ethan Carter had spent years out of the country, it explained why he had fallen off the radar. But something about his return, coinciding with James Hayes's murder, felt too deliberate to be a coincidence.

She picked up her phone and dialed Andrews.

"Get me everything you can on Ethan Carter," she said when he answered. "I want his current address, employment records, the works."

"Yes, ma'am," Andrews replied.

Mills hung up and stared at the photograph of James's bloodied workbench that was displayed on her computer screen.

Something about the scene nagged at her—the precision, the lack of chaos. It wasn't just a murder. It was a message.

In the woods, Ethan stood outside the cabin, the cold air biting at his skin as he stared up at the darkened sky. His mind raced, replaying the moments from the shop—the weight of the hammer, the sound of it connecting, the stillness that followed.

James was gone, and now the path to Samantha was clear.

But Ethan knew the police wouldn't stop looking.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He turned back to the cabin, his gaze settling on the shadow box hanging on the wall. The photograph of Samantha smiled back at him, and Ethan felt a twisted sense of calm wash over him.

“This is just the beginning,” he whispered, his voice steady.

The cabin creaked in the wind as Ethan stepped inside, closing the door behind him.

Samantha paced the small living room of her apartment, her arms wrapped tightly around herself. The silence of the morning felt oppressive, the kind that made her hyper-aware of every creak of the floorboards and whisper of the wind outside.

She had tried distracting herself—folding laundry, scrolling through her phone—but her thoughts kept returning to her uncle. The image of the blood-streaked ground near the woodworking shop door was burned into her mind.

A knock at the door startled her, and she rushed to open it, her relief palpable as she saw Liam standing there.

“Hey,” he said softly, stepping inside and pulling her into a hug. “It’s okay. I’m here.”

Samantha buried her face in his chest, her fingers clutching at his jacket. For a moment, she allowed herself to feel safe, letting his warmth push back the cold fear that had taken root in her.

“Did the police call you?” Liam asked gently, guiding her to the couch.

She shook her head, sitting beside him. “No, not yet. But I told Detective Mills about Ethan.”

Liam’s jaw tightened. “Good. They need to look into him.”

Samantha leaned back, her hands twisting in her lap. “What if it’s not him?” she asked quietly. “What if I’m just... dragging up the past for no reason?”

Liam frowned. “Sam, you’re not overreacting. What Ethan did back then wasn’t normal. And even if it’s not him, the police need to know everything to figure this out.”

She nodded but remained silent, her fingers absently tracing the edge of the coffee mug. The weight of Liam’s words felt heavy, but the guilt and doubt lingered just as strongly.

“What if he’s worse now?” Samantha whispered. “What if... I’ve made it worse by mentioning him?”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Liam reached for her hands, squeezing them gently. “You didn’t do anything wrong. This isn’t on you. If it’s Ethan, he’s the one responsible. Not you.”

Samantha looked up at him, her expression a mix of gratitude and fear. “Thank you,” she said softly.

Liam shifted closer, his hands brushing her hair back gently. “You’re strong, Sam. You’ve been through so much already, and you’re still here. You don’t have to face this alone. I’ll be with you every step of the way.”

A faint smile touched Samantha’s lips, though the unease in her chest remained. She rested her head on Liam’s shoulder, letting the steady rhythm of his breathing calm her frayed nerves.

But even as she closed her eyes, seeking a moment of peace, the shadows in her mind refused to disappear.

At the Carter Mansion

Detective Mills stepped out of her car, her gaze sweeping over the sprawling estate. The house was massive, with gleaming windows and a perfectly manicured lawn. It radiated wealth and privilege, a stark contrast to the dark history she was investigating.

The door was opened by a middle-aged woman in a crisp blouse and pearls. Her expression was polite but guarded.

“Can I help you?” the woman asked.

“Detective Laura Mills,” Mills said, holding up her badge. “I’m here to ask a few questions about Ethan Carter.”

The woman’s smile faltered, and her hands tightened on the edge of the door. “Ethan? What does this have to do with him?”

“We’re investigating a crime, and his name came up,” Mills said carefully. “Is he here?”

The woman hesitated, glancing over her shoulder before stepping outside and closing the door behind her. “Ethan keeps to himself these days,” she said. “He’s very private. But I can tell you he’s been here, focused on his work and studies. He rarely goes out.”

Mills tilted her head slightly, studying the woman’s carefully composed demeanour. “So he doesn’t leave at night? Or visit anyone outside the property?”

UNSEEN CHAINS

The woman frowned. “Not that I know of. Ethan is... reserved. He’s always been that way. But I don’t believe he’s done anything wrong.”

Mills nodded slowly, her instincts kicking in. “I understand. Would you mind if I spoke with him directly?”

The woman hesitated again before forcing a smile. “Of course. Let me check if he’s in his room.”

She disappeared inside, leaving Mills standing on the grand front steps. Mills scanned the property, her eyes lingering on the line of trees that bordered the estate. Something about the dense woods felt off, as if they were hiding something.

When the woman returned, her expression was tight. “I’m afraid he’s not in right now,” she said. “He’s probably out for one of his walks. He likes to clear his head.”

Mills’s jaw tightened, but she nodded politely. “Thank you for your time. If he returns, please have him contact me immediately.”

The woman smiled stiffly and closed the door, leaving Mills standing alone on the steps.

At the Cabin

Ethan sat at the rickety table, his notebook spread out before him. The shadow box on the wall seemed to glow faintly in the lantern light, its contents casting jagged shadows across the room.

The bloodstained photograph of James and Samantha lay beside the notebook, the dried streaks of red marring the image.

Ethan traced a finger over Samantha’s face, his expression blank but his mind racing. “She’ll see,” he whispered. “She’ll understand when it’s done.”

He pulled out a pen and began scrawling in the notebook, his words fragmented and erratic. **“Remove the obstacles. Remove the lies. Only the truth remains.”**

Ethan’s pen paused, and his gaze shifted to the map of Samantha’s neighbourhood pinned to the wall. The locations were marked carefully—her apartment, Liam’s usual parking spot, and the side alley with no cameras.

He smiled faintly, his thoughts coalescing into something cold and sharp.

“It’s almost time.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

The wind howled outside, rattling the windows as Ethan closed the notebook and extinguished the lantern. Darkness enveloped the cabin once more, hiding the horrors within.

Detective Mills sat at her desk, her fingers tapping rhythmically against the polished wood. The conversation with Ethan's mother lingered in her mind, replaying in pieces that didn't sit right. The woman's forced smile, her carefully chosen words, the way she glanced toward the trees—all of it felt off.

Mills reached for the file she had requested earlier that morning. It contained Ethan Carter's records: his school history, his arrest as a teenager, and a scattering of documents detailing his life since returning from abroad.

Her pen hovered over her notebook as she wrote: **"Night movements?"**

There was something about Ethan's behaviour that didn't fit with his mother's description of him as reclusive but harmless. People didn't just vanish into the night for no reason.

Mills grabbed her phone and dialed Andrews.

"Detective," he answered quickly.

"I want a patrol car near the Carter mansion tonight," she said. "Make it low profile. If Ethan Carter leaves, I want to know where he's going."

"Yes, ma'am," Andrews replied.

Mills hung up and leaned back in her chair, staring at the crime scene photo of James Hayes on her computer screen. The blood patterns, the deliberate placement of the hammer, the locked door—it all pointed to someone methodical. Someone who knew James well enough to get close but hated him enough to kill him with precision.

Her instincts told her she was closing in on the truth.

At the Carter mansion, Ethan sat in his room, staring at the shadow box on the wall. The photograph of Samantha seemed to glow faintly in the moonlight filtering through the window.

Ethan leaned forward, his elbows resting on his knees as he whispered to himself. "She's waiting. She doesn't even know it, but she's waiting for me."

The house was silent as Ethan grabbed his notebook and the small duffel bag he kept hidden beneath his bed. His movements were quiet, deliberate, honed by years of practice.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He opened his bedroom window and slipped outside, his feet landing soundlessly on the soft grass below. The sprawling estate stretched out before him, the woods on the edge of the property beckoning like an old friend.

The patrol car stationed just outside the Carter mansion sat in the shadows of the tall oak trees, its occupants lulled by the quiet night. The officers had been vigilant at first, but as the hours stretched on without any movement from the house, their focus waned.

One of the officers leaned back in his seat, suppressing a yawn. “Nothing’s happening,” he muttered, his voice heavy with fatigue.

His partner nodded in agreement, his eyes already drooping. “Maybe we’re wasting our time. If this guy’s as reclusive as they say, he’s probably asleep.”

Within minutes, the two men were slumped in their seats, the steady rhythm of their breathing blending with the rustling of the trees.

Ethan moved past the patrol car, his figure blending into the shadows as he disappeared into the woods.

The cabin loomed in the darkness, its crooked frame barely visible beneath the canopy of trees. Ethan pushed open the door, the familiar creak of the hinges welcoming him like an old friend.

Inside, the air was thick with the scent of damp wood and decay. Ethan lit the lantern on the table, its flickering light casting jagged shadows across the walls.

He set the duffel bag down and began arranging its contents: the map of Samantha’s neighbourhood, a length of rope, a roll of duct tape, and the knife he had carved into the cabin’s table the night before.

The shadow box on the wall seemed to watch him, its grotesque contents glowing in the dim light. The bloodied photograph of James and Samantha sat at the center, her smiling face a stark contrast to the chaos around it.

Ethan picked up the photograph, his fingers trembling slightly as he traced Samantha’s face. “You’ll understand,” he whispered. “You’ll see why this has to happen.”

He folded the photograph carefully and tucked it into his notebook before turning his attention to the map pinned to the wall.

His pen moved quickly, marking entry points, blind spots, and potential escape routes. Every detail was accounted for, every contingency planned.

UNSEEN CHAINS

When the map was complete, he stepped back to admire his work. His lips curled into a faint smile, and a sense of calm washed over him.

“She’ll thank me,” Ethan said softly.

The lantern flickered, its light casting distorted shapes across the cabin. Ethan extinguished it, plunging the room into darkness. He sat in silence, the weight of his plan settling over him like a heavy shroud.

At Samantha’s apartment, the living room lights dimmed as she and Liam prepared for bed. Liam had insisted on staying over, and Samantha was too grateful for the company to argue.

As she brushed her teeth in the bathroom, her mind wandered to the past. Ethan’s face flashed in her memory—not the boy she had known in high school, but the distorted version of him from her nightmares.

She gripped the edge of the sink, her knuckles white as a wave of unease swept over her.

Liam appeared in the doorway, his presence breaking the spell. “Hey,” he said gently. “You okay?”

Samantha forced a small smile. “Yeah. Just tired.”

He nodded, stepping closer to wrap an arm around her shoulders. “Come on. Let’s get some rest.”

As they settled into bed, Samantha stared at the ceiling, her mind refusing to quiet. In the back of her thoughts, a chilling certainty began to form—Ethan hadn’t forgotten her.

And he was closer than she wanted to believe.

The morning air was crisp as Samantha walked through the park, her hands stuffed into the pockets of her coat. She had barely slept the night before, her mind weighed down by grief and the looming investigation into her uncle’s murder.

Liam had insisted she take a walk to clear her head, promising to join her later once he finished a work call. Samantha hadn’t argued; the quiet solitude of the park was a welcome reprieve from the chaos swirling around her.

She paused near a bench, the sunlight filtering through the trees, casting dappled patterns on the ground. For a moment, she closed her eyes, letting the warmth of the sun soothe her frayed nerves.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Samantha?”

The voice froze her in place. It was low and familiar, tinged with a softness that sent a shiver down her spine.

She turned slowly, her breath catching as her gaze landed on a tall figure standing a few feet away. His dark hair was neatly combed, and his expression was tentative, almost vulnerable.

“Ethan,” she whispered, her voice barely audible.

He nodded, his hands tucked into the pockets of his black coat. “It’s been a long time.”

Samantha’s heart raced as a flood of emotions washed over her—fear, confusion, anger. She took a step back, her posture stiffening. “What are you doing here?”

Ethan raised his hands slightly, a gesture of reassurance. “I heard about your uncle. I’m... I’m so sorry, Samantha. I can’t imagine what you’re going through.”

The genuine sadness in his tone gave her pause, her eyes narrowing as she studied him. “How did you hear about it?”

“It was in the news,” Ethan said quickly, his voice steady. “I wanted to reach out, but I wasn’t sure if I should. I didn’t want to... make things harder for you.”

Samantha crossed her arms, her skepticism evident. “Why now? After all these years?”

Ethan took a careful step closer, his expression softening. “Because I’ve changed, Samantha. I’m not the same person I was back then.”

She scoffed, the memory of his past actions flashing in her mind. “You tried to hurt Liam. You stalked me. How can you expect me to believe that you’ve changed?”

Ethan’s shoulders sagged slightly, his gaze dropping to the ground. “I don’t expect you to believe me. Not right away. But I spent years trying to fix myself. Therapy, work, school—I’ve done everything I can to be better.” He looked up, his eyes glistening with unshed tears. “I know I can’t undo what I did, but I’m truly sorry, Samantha. I’ve regretted it every single day.”

For a moment, her resolve wavered. There was something raw and genuine in his voice, a vulnerability that felt almost disarming.

“Why are you really here?” she asked, her tone softer but still guarded.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“To offer my condolences,” Ethan said simply. “And to tell you that if there’s anything I can do to help, I will. I know I don’t deserve your trust, but I want to try.”

Samantha stared at him, her emotions warring between distrust and the faintest glimmer of hope. Before she could respond, a familiar voice cut through the tension.

“Sam?”

She turned to see Liam approaching, his expression darkening as his eyes landed on Ethan. “What the hell are you doing here?”

Ethan’s posture stiffened, but he kept his tone calm. “I was just offering my condolences. I didn’t mean to upset her.”

Liam stepped protectively between them, his glare unwavering. “You don’t get to come back and act like everything’s fine. Stay away from her.”

Ethan held up his hands in a placating gesture. “I understand. I just wanted to say I’m sorry—for everything. I’ll go.”

He turned to leave, his steps measured and unhurried.

Across the street, Detective Mills sat in an unmarked car, her sharp eyes fixed on the scene unfolding in the park. She recognized Ethan immediately, his name and face burned into her memory from the files she had studied.

Her instincts screamed at her to act, but she stayed put, watching as he walked away.

“What are you up to?” Mills murmured under her breath.

That afternoon, Mills visited Samantha’s apartment, a notebook in hand as she sat across from her in the living room. Liam lingered nearby, his protective presence a comfort to Samantha.

“So, you saw Ethan Carter this morning,” Mills began, her tone even.

Samantha nodded, her fingers twisting the edge of her sweater. “He... he said he’s changed. That he’s sorry.”

“And you believe him?” Mills asked, her expression neutral.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“I don’t know,” Samantha admitted. “He seemed sincere, but after everything he did... it’s hard to trust him.”

Mills jotted something down. “He’s been on my radar, but I’ll be honest—there’s no concrete evidence linking him to your uncle’s murder. If he’s telling the truth, it might mean he’s not involved at all.”

Liam snorted, crossing his arms. “That guy’s dangerous. I don’t care how much therapy he claims he’s had—he’s not someone you can ignore.”

Mills glanced at him. “And you’re right to be cautious. But until we have proof, I can’t treat him as a suspect. For now, I’ll keep an eye on him.”

She closed her notebook and stood, her gaze lingering on Samantha. “If he contacts you again, let me know immediately. And be careful.”

Samantha nodded, her unease growing as Mills left.

Later that night, Ethan sat in his room at the mansion, a faint smile playing on his lips. The meeting with Samantha had gone exactly as he had planned.

“She’ll see,” he whispered, his voice barely audible. “She’ll see I’ve always been there for her.”

The photograph of Samantha in the shadow box gleamed in the moonlight, her smile as bright as ever.

Ethan’s gaze shifted to the map on his desk, his plans falling into place.

One obstacle had been removed. Now soon it will be the time for the next.

The apartment was quiet, save for the faint hum of the refrigerator as Samantha sat alone in her living room after Liam had gone to bed. Her mind replayed the encounter with Ethan, her emotions tangled in a web of fear and reluctant sympathy.

He had seemed genuine—more human than the boy she remembered, with his cold, predatory stares and erratic behaviour. But something about him still unnerved her, a tension that lingered long after he had walked away.

She pulled her blanket tighter around her shoulders, her gaze drifting to the window. Outside, the streetlights cast long shadows on the pavement, their flickering glow unsettling.

In the darkness, a single thought echoed in her mind: **What if he’s lying?**

UNSEEN CHAINS

At the Carter mansion, Ethan stood in front of the shadow box, his reflection faint in the glass. The photo of Samantha smiled back at him, her image pristine and untouched, despite the chaos brewing around her.

Today's meeting had gone better than he had anticipated. Samantha's defences were cracked, her emotions raw from her uncle's death. She had looked at him with suspicion, yes, but there had also been a flicker of something else—hesitation.

Ethan ran a finger along the edge of the shadow box, his smile widening.

"She doesn't know it yet," he whispered. "But she's closer than ever to understanding."

Detective Mills stared at the notes spread across her desk, the details of the case swirling in her mind. Ethan Carter remained the most obvious link, but the lack of evidence gnawed at her. His demeanour in the park had been calm, measured—nothing like the disturbed individual described in his files.

Her instincts told her he was hiding something.

But instincts weren't enough to build a case.

With a frustrated sigh, Mills leaned back in her chair, her fingers rubbing her temples. "You're playing a game," she muttered, staring at the photo of James Hayes's workshop on her monitor. "And I'm going to figure out what it is."

In the woods, the cabin sat in silence, its crooked frame barely visible beneath the thick canopy of trees. Inside, the shadows stretched long and jagged, flickering in the dim lantern light.

The map on the table lay open, its lines and markings meticulous. Ethan's notebook rested beside it, its pages filled with scrawled plans and fragmented thoughts.

Ethan had already mapped out his next steps. The pieces were in place.

Soon, Samantha would see the truth.

Beneath the Surface

Four months had passed since the brutal murder of James Hayes, and life in the quiet town was beginning to settle again. The investigation, while still open, had stalled without new leads, leaving the townsfolk with no choice but to move on.

For Samantha, the months had been a slow but steady journey back to normalcy. The initial shock and grief of losing her uncle had begun to soften, replaced by the demands of her work and her relationship with Liam. The constant ache in her chest was still there, but it no longer defined her days.

Ethan Carter had surprised her the most.

In the months since their first meeting at the park, Ethan had been nothing but polite, respectful, and supportive. He rarely initiated contact, instead waiting for her to reach out, and when they spoke, he kept the conversation light and carefully neutral.

He had even apologized to Liam in person, an awkward but earnest gesture that left her boyfriend begrudgingly admitting, “Maybe he really has changed.”

Detective Mills, too, had gradually shifted her focus away from Ethan. His alibi for the night of James’s murder had checked out, and his calm, cooperative demeanorduring their interviews had made it difficult to justify keeping him under scrutiny.

“He’s not the same person he was back then,” Mills had admitted reluctantly during her last visit to Samantha’s apartment. “I don’t think he’s our guy.”

Samantha had wanted to believe her. And over time, she started to.

It was a sunny afternoon, and Samantha was seated at an outdoor café, sipping a cappuccino while scrolling through her phone. The warmth of the sun on her skin and the hum of life around her felt comforting, a stark contrast to the heaviness of the past few months.

“Mind if I join you?”

She looked up to see Ethan standing nearby, his hands tucked into the pockets of his coat. His smile was tentative, as though he were afraid of overstepping.

Samantha hesitated for a moment before gesturing to the empty chair across from her. “Sure.”

Ethan sat down, his movements unhurried. “How have you been?” he asked, his tone casual but genuinely curious.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Better,” Samantha admitted. “Work’s been busy, and I think... I think I’m finally starting to feel normal again.”

“That’s good to hear,” Ethan said, nodding. He paused before adding, “I’ve been meaning to thank you, by the way.”

“Thank me?”

“For giving me a chance,” he said softly. “I know I didn’t deserve it, but it means a lot.”

Samantha studied him for a moment, searching for any cracks in his carefully composed demeanour. But there were none. He seemed sincere, his gaze steady and open.

“Well, I guess everyone deserves a second chance,” she said finally, her voice cautious but kind.

Ethan’s smile widened slightly. “That means a lot, Samantha. Really.”

Across the street, Liam stood near his car, his arms crossed as he watched the two of them.

He didn’t trust Ethan—not fully, not yet. There was something about the man that still set his nerves on edge, despite his apparent transformation.

“Keeping your distance, huh?”

Liam turned to see Detective Mills approaching, her hands tucked into the pockets of her leather jacket.

“Just making sure everything’s okay,” Liam replied, nodding toward Samantha and Ethan.

Mills followed his gaze, her expression thoughtful. “He’s kept his nose clean for the past few months. No suspicious behaviour, no outbursts. If I didn’t know better, I’d say he’s harmless.”

“But you don’t believe that,” Liam said, his tone wary.

Mills’s lips pressed into a thin line. “I don’t know what to believe. People can change, sure. But people can also fake change.”

Liam’s jaw tightened. “You think he’s faking?”

“I think,” Mills said carefully, “that it’s too soon to tell. But until he proves otherwise, we have to take him at face value.”

Liam didn’t reply, his gaze fixed on Samantha.

UNSEEN CHAINS

That evening, Ethan returned to the cabin, his calm facade slipping the moment he stepped inside.

The lantern flickered as he lit it, the shadows stretching across the room like jagged scars. The map on the table was still there, its lines and markings now accompanied by new notes and plans.

Ethan opened his notebook, flipping through the pages until he found the most recent entry.

“She trusts me now. She’s starting to see. Soon, it’ll be time.”

He set the notebook down and moved to the shadow box, his fingers brushing against the photograph of Samantha.

“She’ll understand,” he whispered, his voice trembling. “When it’s all over, she’ll finally understand.”

Ethan’s gaze shifted to the knife on the table, its blade gleaming faintly in the lantern light. He picked it up, turning it over in his hands as a dark smile curved his lips.

“Patience,” he murmured. “Just a little longer.”

The following weeks unfolded like a dream—or so it seemed to Samantha.

For the first time in years, she felt like she was reclaiming her life. The heaviness that had haunted her since her uncle’s death began to lift, replaced by the warmth of routine and small moments of happiness.

Ethan’s presence, though unexpected, had grown oddly comforting. He had become a quiet fixture in her life, appearing just often enough to check in without overwhelming her. His conversations were light and easy, never crossing boundaries or dredging up the past.

Even Liam had started to ease up around him, though his protectiveness remained ever-present.

One afternoon, Samantha stood in her kitchen, humming softly as she prepared a tray of sandwiches for the small group of friends she had invited over. The sound of the doorbell pulled her from her thoughts, and she wiped her hands on a towel before heading to answer it.

“Hey, Ethan,” she said with a small smile as she opened the door.

Ethan stood on the threshold, holding a neatly wrapped box. “I hope I’m not too early,” he said, his tone polite.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Not at all,” Samantha replied, stepping aside to let him in.

The apartment was warm and inviting, filled with the faint scent of lavender and freshly baked cookies. Ethan glanced around, his expression calm but quietly observant.

“I brought this for you,” he said, handing her the box.

Samantha raised an eyebrow as she accepted it. “What is it?”

“Just a small gift,” Ethan replied. “Something I thought you might like.”

Inside was a beautifully bound leather journal, its cover embossed with delicate floral patterns.

Samantha’s lips parted in surprise. “Ethan, this is beautiful. Thank you.”

He smiled, his gaze soft. “I remembered you used to love writing. I thought maybe it would help, you know... with everything.”

For a moment, Samantha was speechless. The thoughtfulness of the gesture caught her off guard, stirring a mix of gratitude and unease.

Across the room, Liam watched the interaction silently, his arms crossed.

When Ethan stepped into the kitchen to grab a glass of water, Liam followed, his expression unreadable.

“Nice gift,” Liam said flatly.

Ethan turned, his face carefully neutral. “I just thought it might help her. That’s all.”

Liam leaned against the counter, his gaze sharp. “I don’t know what your angle is, but let me be clear: if you hurt her again, in any way, you’ll regret it.”

Ethan’s lips twitched into a faint smile, his tone calm. “I understand your concern, Liam. But I’m not here to hurt Samantha. I’ve made mistakes, and I’m doing my best to make up for them.”

Liam didn’t reply, his jaw tightening as he stepped back.

That evening, after everyone had left, Samantha sat on the couch with Liam, the journal resting on the coffee table in front of them.

“Ethan’s been... different,” she said hesitantly.

Liam frowned, his arm draped around her shoulders. “You trust him?”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha shrugged. “I don’t know. He seems genuine. But part of me still wonders if it’s all an act.”

Liam’s expression darkened. “He’s smart. He knows how to play the long game.”

She sighed, leaning into him. “I just wish things could go back to how they were before. Before all of this.”

Liam kissed the top of her head, his voice soft. “We’ll get there, Sam. One step at a time.”

At the cabin, Ethan sat at the table, the leather journal’s twin resting in front of him. Its cover was identical to the one he had gifted Samantha, but its contents were anything but ordinary.

Each page was filled with detailed notes about Samantha’s life—her routines, her habits, her conversations. Drawings of her face adorned the margins, alongside scattered fragments of poetry written in his precise, deliberate hand.

He flipped to a blank page and began to write:

“Today, she smiled at me. She’s letting me in. Soon, there will be no distance between us. No obstacles. No lies.”

Ethan set the pen down and closed the journal, his fingers lingering on the cover. His mind buzzed with anticipation, his plans inching closer to fruition.

The map on the wall caught his eye, its markings growing more intricate with each passing day. He traced a finger along the lines, his lips curling into a faint smile.

“It’s almost time,” he whispered.

The lantern flickered, casting jagged shadows across the room. Ethan extinguished it, the darkness swallowing him whole as he leaned back in his chair, his thoughts consumed by the inevitability of what was to come.

Samantha found herself writing in the journal Ethan had gifted her more often than she expected. Initially, she had hesitated, unsure if accepting something so personal from him was a mistake. But as the weeks passed, she found comfort in the act of writing—pouring her thoughts onto the blank pages felt like regaining a part of herself that grief had stolen.

She wrote about her day, her plans, and sometimes her lingering feelings of loss. Occasionally, she found herself writing about Ethan.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“He’s changed so much,” one entry read. “I can’t tell if I’m letting my guard down too soon, but he seems... kinder. Like he’s trying to make amends. Part of me wonders if I’ll ever fully trust him, but another part hopes I can.”

Samantha closed the journal one evening, her gaze drifting to the window. The moonlight filtered through the curtains, casting soft shadows on the walls.

At the Carter mansion, Ethan sat at his desk, his demeanour composed, his room pristine. From the outside, he appeared like the picture of a man redeemed—a far cry from the troubled boy he had once been.

But Ethan’s mind was far from calm. His thoughts were back at the cabin, where his real plans were unfolding.

Every night, after his parents were asleep, he slipped out into the woods, his movements practiced and silent. The cabin was his sanctuary, his control center. It was where he planned every detail of Samantha’s future, their future, away from prying eyes.

One afternoon, Liam invited Samantha to dinner at a small Italian restaurant downtown. The air between them was warm and easy, the kind of evening that reminded Samantha of how safe she felt with him.

They shared a bottle of wine, the gentle hum of conversation filling the cozy space.

“I think you should move in with me,” Liam said suddenly, his voice steady but nervous.

Samantha blinked, caught off guard. “Move in?”

Liam nodded, his hand reaching for hers. “I’ve been thinking about it for a while. I just... I want to know you’re safe. Especially with everything that’s happened.”

Samantha’s chest tightened. “Liam, I don’t know if I’m ready for that.”

“Why not?” he asked gently. “You spend most of your time at my place anyway. It makes sense.”

She hesitated, her mind flickering to the journal, to the moments she had spent writing her private thoughts. Moving in with Liam would mean giving up that solitude, that space she had carved out for herself.

“It’s not that I don’t want to,” she said finally. “I just need more time.”

Liam nodded, his disappointment barely masked. “Okay. I’ll wait as long as you need.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Outside, Ethan stood in the shadows, his breath fogging the cold air as he watched through the restaurant's window. His gaze fixed on the way Liam reached for Samantha's hand, the way her face softened as she smiled at him.

The image burned into his mind like a brand.

"She doesn't need you," Ethan muttered under his breath. "She's mine."

Later that evening, Samantha returned to her apartment alone, her thoughts heavy. She poured herself a glass of wine and sat on the couch, the journal resting on the coffee table in front of her.

The city outside her window was quiet, the streetlights casting faint halos onto the pavement below. She stared at the blank page of the journal for a long time before finally picking up her pen.

"Dinner with Liam tonight," she wrote. "He asked me to move in with him. I told him I wasn't ready, but I don't know if that's true. I'm scared of moving forward, of making another change when I've just started to feel normal again."

She paused, tapping the pen against the edge of the journal.

"Ethan seems different. I hate to admit it, but he's been kind, thoughtful even. I still don't trust him completely, but... maybe people really can change."

She closed the journal and leaned back against the couch, her eyes heavy with exhaustion. For the first time in months, her sleep came easily, her mind quiet.

At the cabin, Ethan stared at the map on the wall, his pen moving swiftly as he made new notes. The plan was evolving, becoming sharper and more precise.

The notebook beside him was filled with pages of Samantha—her routines, her preferences, her fears. Every detail of her life was documented, a puzzle that Ethan believed only he could solve.

He flipped to a fresh page and began to write:

"She's beginning to let go of him. Soon, she'll be mine entirely. No one else matters. Not Liam, not the past. Just us."

Ethan leaned back, a satisfied smile spreading across his face.

The shadows in the cabin seemed to press closer as the lantern flickered, the light casting jagged patterns on the walls.

"Patience," he whispered to himself. "She'll see soon enough."

UNSEEN CHAINS

The morning sunlight poured through Samantha's kitchen window as she prepared her coffee, the rich aroma filling the small space. She reached for her journal on the counter, flipping through the pages as she waited for the water to boil.

Her entries had grown longer in recent weeks, the act of writing becoming a daily ritual that gave her a sense of clarity. As she skimmed through her recent thoughts, her phone buzzed on the counter, interrupting her.

It was Ethan.

“Good morning, Samantha. I hope you’re doing well. Would you like to join me for coffee this afternoon? My treat.”

She hesitated for a moment, glancing at the journal before typing her reply.

“Sure, that sounds nice. Let me know where.”

The café Ethan chose was small and tucked away, its quiet ambiance a stark contrast to the bustling streets outside. Samantha arrived early, her hands wrapped around a warm mug of tea as she waited.

When Ethan walked in, he greeted her with a soft smile, his demeanour calm and collected.

“Thanks for meeting me,” he said as he sat across from her.

Samantha returned the smile. “Of course. It’s nice to take a break.”

Ethan nodded, his gaze steady. “How have you been?”

She shrugged lightly. “Good, I think. Things are finally starting to feel normal again.”

“I’m glad,” Ethan said, his tone genuine. “You deserve that.”

Their conversation drifted to lighter topics—the weather, her work, a few funny anecdotes about their school days. Ethan’s careful restraint was evident, his words chosen with precision to avoid anything that might make her uncomfortable.

At one point, he reached into his coat pocket and pulled out a small book. “I thought you might like this,” he said, sliding it across the table.

Samantha picked it up, her fingers tracing the embossed cover. It was a book of poetry, its pages filled with delicate, handwritten verses.

“I remember you used to love poetry,” Ethan explained. “I found this at a little shop downtown and thought of you.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha's smile widened. "Thank you, Ethan. This is... really thoughtful."

Ethan's expression softened. "I just want to make up for the person I was. I know I can't erase the past, but I hope I can be better now."

For a moment, Samantha felt a flicker of genuine connection. It was fleeting, but it was there.

That evening, Samantha told Liam about her meeting with Ethan.

They were in her apartment, Liam stretched out on the couch while Samantha tidied up the kitchen. His reaction was cautious but measured, a far cry from the outright hostility he had shown in the past.

"So, he's giving you gifts now?" Liam asked, his tone neutral.

"It was just a book," Samantha said. "Something he thought I'd like."

"And you're okay with that?"

She sighed, setting down the dish she was holding. "I don't know. I think... I think he's trying. He hasn't done anything wrong, and honestly, it feels good to let go of all that anger."

Liam sat up, his expression serious. "I get it, Sam. I really do. But just promise me you'll be careful."

Samantha nodded. "I will. I promise."

At the cabin, Ethan carefully unwrapped another photograph of Samantha, adding it to the wall. The image was recent, taken just the day before as she walked through the park.

He stepped back, admiring his growing collection. Each photograph, each note, each drawing—it was all part of a larger tapestry, a story that only he could see.

His gaze drifted to the book of poetry he had gifted Samantha earlier that day. Another copy sat on the table in front of him, its pages identical except for one small difference.

Inside her copy, he had written a note on the final page. A simple message, tucked away where she wouldn't find it until the time was right.

"You're never alone. I'm always here."

Ethan smiled faintly, his fingers brushing against the cover of the duplicate book.

"She'll understand soon," he murmured, his voice soft but resolute.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The lantern flickered, its light casting jagged shadows across the walls as Ethan sat back in his chair.

Patience had always been his greatest strength.

Days turned into weeks, and Ethan's presence in Samantha's life became increasingly steady. He appeared at just the right moments, offering support without ever overstepping. When she mentioned a tough day at work, he would surprise her with a kind message or a thoughtful gesture, like a small bouquet of flowers left at her doorstep with a simple note: **"Keep smiling. - E."**

Samantha found herself relaxing around him more and more. His once-intense energy had been replaced by a calm, almost soothing demeanour, and his ability to listen without judgment made him feel safe—something she never thought she'd associate with Ethan Carter.

Even Liam, though still wary, seemed to accept Ethan's reformed persona.

"He's been nothing but polite," Liam admitted one evening as he and Samantha walked through the park. "I still don't trust him, but maybe he's trying to make up for everything."

Samantha nodded, though she kept her thoughts to herself. Deep down, she wasn't sure if she truly believed in Ethan's transformation—or if she just wanted to.

Meanwhile, at the cabin, Ethan's preparations grew increasingly meticulous.

The map on the wall was now covered in overlapping lines and detailed notes. Each entry chronicled Samantha's movements, her habits, and her interactions with those closest to her.

He studied the map intently, his fingers tracing the route from her apartment to Liam's house. Every path was marked, every potential blind spot noted.

"She's almost ready," Ethan muttered, his voice low and steady.

He moved to the shadow box on the wall, his gaze lingering on the photographs inside. One, in particular, held his attention—Samantha smiling at the café, the sunlight catching the curve of her face.

"You'll see soon," he whispered. "You'll see that I've always been the one for you."

One evening, Samantha invited Ethan over for coffee. It was a casual gesture, one she hadn't thought much about at the time, but as she waited for him to arrive, a faint sense of unease crept over her.

UNSEEN CHAINS

She shook it off quickly, reminding herself that Ethan had done nothing to warrant her suspicion.

When he arrived, he was as calm and composed as ever, carrying a small box tied with a silver ribbon.

“What’s this?” Samantha asked as she opened the door.

“Just a little something,” Ethan replied with a warm smile.

Inside was a delicate charm bracelet, each charm shaped like something meaningful from their shared past—a book, a small camera, and a daisy.

“I thought it might remind you of the good moments,” Ethan said softly. “The ones worth holding on to.”

Samantha’s throat tightened as she ran her fingers over the charms. “Ethan... this is beautiful. Thank you.”

He shrugged, his smile widening. “I’m just glad you like it.”

They settled into the living room, the warm glow of the lamp casting soft shadows across the walls. Their conversation flowed easily, and for the first time, Samantha felt like she was talking to someone completely different from the Ethan she had once feared.

But as Samantha’s trust in Ethan grew, Liam’s unease deepened.

“I don’t like how close you’re getting to him,” Liam said one night as they sat together in her apartment.

“He hasn’t done anything wrong,” Samantha argued gently.

“That doesn’t mean he won’t,” Liam replied, his tone firm. “You know what he’s capable of, Sam. You’ve seen it.”

Samantha sighed, her fingers toying with the charm bracelet. “People can change, Liam. Maybe he’s not the same person he used to be.”

Liam shook his head, frustration flickering in his eyes. “Just promise me you’ll be careful.”

“I will,” she said, though the tension between them remained.

Back at the cabin, Ethan sat in the dim light, his gaze fixed on the bracelet’s twin that lay on the table before him.

The charms were identical, down to the smallest detail, but this one had a single addition—a tiny heart, hidden on the inside of the clasp.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan picked it up, turning it over in his hands as a smile spread across his face.

“She’s almost there,” he whispered.

He set the bracelet down and reached for his notebook, flipping to a fresh page.

“She wears it now. My gift. A part of me always with her. Soon, she’ll understand what it means. Soon, she’ll be mine.”

The lantern flickered, casting jagged shadows across the walls as Ethan leaned back in his chair, his mind buzzing with anticipation.

The day had started innocently enough. Liam had kissed Samantha goodbye as she left for work and then headed to his own apartment to get ready for an evening meeting. The routine was predictable, just as Ethan had counted on.

Earlier that morning, while Liam had been out for a run, Ethan had entered the apartment unnoticed. His gloves protected him from leaving prints as he worked with quiet efficiency.

The trap was simple but precise: a chair placed against the door at just the right angle, its back leg balancing precariously on a pile of heavy books. Atop the chair sat a toolbox—heavy enough to cause serious injury, but innocuous enough to be overlooked. A single string was tied between the doorknob and the chair leg, taut and nearly invisible.

When Liam returned and opened the door, the setup would come crashing down directly onto him.

Ethan had planned for every detail, from the noise of the impact to the timing of his own alibi.

By late afternoon, Ethan and Samantha were sitting on a park bench, enjoying the crisp autumn air. The sun dipped low on the horizon, casting long shadows across the grass as they chatted about books and memories of their school days.

Ethan’s demeanour was warm and easy, his laughter light and infectious. Samantha felt herself relaxing in his presence, her guard lowering bit by bit.

“It’s funny,” she said, smiling as she sipped her coffee. “I never thought we’d be sitting here like this.”

“Life is strange like that,” Ethan replied, his tone thoughtful. “Sometimes, it gives us a second chance when we least expect it.”

Samantha nodded, her gaze drifting to the distant horizon.

UNSEEN CHAINS

At Liam's apartment, the front door creaked open. Liam stepped inside, his phone pressed to his ear as he greeted his boss.

"Yeah, I'll have those files ready by tonight," he said, his voice distracted as he pushed the door fully open.

The trap triggered instantly.

The chair tipped, sending the toolbox hurtling toward him. It struck him squarely in the shoulder and side of his head, the force knocking him backward. He fell to the floor, his phone clattering beside him as pain radiated through his body.

Dazed, Liam groaned and reached for his phone, his vision swimming.

"Hello? Liam? Are you okay?" his boss's voice echoed faintly.

"I—something happened," Liam mumbled, struggling to sit up. His fingers brushed against the toolbox, and realization dawned. Someone had set this up.

His heart pounded as he scanned the room, but the apartment was silent.

Later that evening, Samantha's phone buzzed as she and Ethan were leaving the park.

"Liam?" she answered, her voice bright.

"Samantha," Liam said, his tone tight with pain. "I... I think someone tried to hurt me."

"What?" Samantha stopped in her tracks, her voice rising. "What are you talking about? Are you okay?"

"I'm fine," Liam said, though his voice was strained. "There was some kind of trap set up at my apartment. A toolbox fell on me when I opened the door. It hit me pretty hard, but I'm okay."

Samantha's free hand flew to her mouth, her eyes wide with shock. "Oh my God, Liam. What—who would do something like that?"

"I don't know," Liam replied. "But I'm calling the police."

"Do you want me to come over?" she asked, her voice trembling.

"No," Liam said quickly. "Stay where you are. I'll handle it."

Samantha nodded, though her hands shook as she ended the call.

Ethan placed a steadying hand on her shoulder. "What happened?" he asked, his tone calm but laced with concern.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Someone tried to hurt Liam,” Samantha said, her voice breaking. “He thinks it was a trap.”

Ethan’s brows furrowed in apparent disbelief. “A trap? That’s... insane. Why would anyone do that?”

“I don’t know,” Samantha whispered, her mind racing.

Ethan offered her a soft smile, his voice gentle. “Do you want me to stay with you tonight? Just in case?”

Samantha hesitated before nodding. “Yes, please. I don’t want to be alone.”

That night, as Samantha lay in bed, her thoughts a tangled mess of worry and fear, Ethan sat quietly in her living room. His calm demeanour never faltered, even as he replayed the events in his mind.

The plan had gone perfectly. Liam’s injuries weren’t severe enough to raise suspicion, but the incident was enough to rattle him and make Samantha lean further into Ethan’s carefully constructed web.

Ethan leaned back on the couch, his lips curling into a faint smile.

“Patience,” he murmured. “Everything is falling into place.”

At his apartment, Liam sat on the couch with an ice pack pressed to his shoulder as the police officer jotted down notes.

“You’re sure you didn’t notice anything out of place before the incident?” the officer asked.

Liam shook his head. “No, everything seemed normal. But this wasn’t an accident. Someone did this on purpose.”

The officer nodded. “We’ll file a report and follow up. In the meantime, keep your doors locked and be cautious.”

As the officer left, Liam’s gaze drifted to his phone. His instincts told him that this wasn’t random.

And for the first time, his thoughts turned to Ethan.

The following day, Liam sat at his desk, his shoulder aching from the bruising impact of the toolbox. He replayed the incident in his mind, over and over, searching for something he might have missed.

His apartment building wasn’t the kind of place where strangers came and went unnoticed. The neighbours were friendly, and the security cameras at the

UNSEEN CHAINS

entrances had always made him feel safe. But now, that sense of security was gone.

He leaned back in his chair, his mind drifting to Ethan.

The man had been everywhere lately—always polite, always calm, always perfectly timed. Liam couldn't shake the feeling that Ethan's newfound charm was too calculated to be genuine.

But there was no proof. Nothing to tie him to the incident.

Liam exhaled sharply and reached for his phone.

“Hey, Detective Mills?”

At Samantha's apartment, Ethan was helping her rearrange the bookshelves in her living room. The faint scent of coffee lingered in the air, and the soft hum of the radio filled the quiet spaces between their conversation.

“Thanks for staying last night,” Samantha said, glancing at Ethan with a small smile. “I know I probably overreacted, but... it meant a lot.”

“You weren't overreacting,” Ethan replied, his tone steady. “What happened to Liam was terrifying. Anyone would have felt the same.”

Samantha nodded, though her expression remained troubled. “I just don't understand why someone would target him. He's never done anything to anyone.”

“Maybe it was random,” Ethan suggested, his voice casual. “Sometimes bad things happen without a reason.”

Samantha frowned but didn't reply, her gaze drifting to the charm bracelet on her wrist.

Ethan watched her out of the corner of his eye, his calm exterior masking the satisfaction he felt. The plan was working perfectly.

Later that evening, Liam met with Detective Mills at the precinct.

“What's on your mind, Liam?” Mills asked, leaning back in her chair as she studied him.

“It's about Ethan Carter,” Liam said bluntly.

Mills's expression didn't change, but her posture straightened slightly. “Go on.”

Liam hesitated, organizing his thoughts. “I know you cleared him as a suspect in James's murder, but... I think he's dangerous. He's been spending a lot of time around Samantha, and now, this thing with my apartment—it feels connected.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Mills folded her arms, her gaze sharp. “You think Ethan set the trap in your apartment?”

“I don’t have proof,” Liam admitted. “But it’s the kind of thing he would do—calculated, subtle, designed to send a message without getting caught.”

Mills sighed, her fingers drumming against the desk. “Ethan hasn’t done anything to put himself back on my radar. And trust me, I’ve been watching him. But I’ll admit... I don’t trust him either.”

Liam leaned forward. “So, what can we do?”

“We wait,” Mills said firmly. “People like Ethan can’t keep their masks on forever. If he’s up to something, we’ll catch him.”

Liam nodded, though the tight knot of unease in his chest didn’t loosen.

At the cabin, Ethan meticulously added new notes to his map. The details of Liam’s life were written in small, precise script—his routines, his habits, and his moments of vulnerability.

Ethan leaned back in his chair, studying the map with satisfaction.

“Liam’s shaken,” he murmured to himself. “Good. Now he’ll start making mistakes.”

He turned to the notebook on the table, flipping to a fresh page.

“Samantha is almost mine. She’s starting to see me for who I really am—not the monster, but the man who’s always loved her. Liam is the only obstacle left. Soon, he’ll be gone.”

Ethan closed the notebook, his lips curling into a faint smile as he extinguished the lantern.

The darkness in the cabin was absolute, but Ethan felt nothing but clarity.

At Samantha’s apartment, she sat on the couch with Liam, their conversation strained.

“I talked to Mills today,” Liam admitted, his voice low.

Samantha glanced at him, her brow furrowed. “Why?”

“Because I think Ethan’s dangerous,” Liam said bluntly.

Samantha sighed, her shoulders slumping. “Liam, we’ve been over this. He hasn’t done anything wrong.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Not yet,” Liam countered. “But that doesn’t mean he won’t. You’re letting your guard down, and that’s exactly what he wants.”

Samantha shook her head, frustration flickering in her eyes. “Why can’t you just give him a chance? People can change, Liam. Not everyone is out to hurt me.”

Liam stared at her, his expression torn between anger and concern. “I just don’t want to see you get hurt again.”

“I won’t,” Samantha said firmly. “I can take care of myself.”

Liam didn’t reply, but the tension between them was palpable.

That night, as Samantha slept, her dreams restless, Ethan stood in the shadows outside her apartment. His breath fogged the cold air as he stared up at the faint glow of her bedroom window.

“She’ll see,” he whispered, his voice steady. “She’ll see that I’m the only one who can protect her.”

The wind rustled the trees around him, but Ethan remained still, his gaze unwavering.

Patience had always been his greatest strength.

The Carter mansion gleamed like a beacon against the night sky, its grand facade illuminated by soft, golden lights. Tonight, the estate played host to an exclusive gathering—a celebration of Ethan Carter officially stepping into his father’s shoes as the new CEO of Carter Industries.

The event was everything one would expect from the Carter family: lavish decorations, fine wines, and a guest list that included the town’s most influential figures. The buzz of laughter and conversation filled the air as sharply dressed guests wandered through the expansive hallways and gardens.

For Samantha, the invitation had come as a surprise. The embossed card had arrived two days earlier, accompanied by a personal note from Ethan:

“Samantha, your support has meant so much to me. I’d be honoured if you could attend this special moment in my life. – Ethan.”

Despite her initial hesitation, she decided to go. Liam had, predictably, been less than thrilled.

“This is a calculated move,” he had said, pacing in her living room. “He’s doing this to draw you closer.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

“It’s a party, Liam,” Samantha replied, frustration creeping into her tone. “Not everything he does is some sinister plot.”

Liam shook his head. “You’re walking straight into his trap, Sam.”

But Samantha had stood firm.

Ethan greeted Samantha warmly at the entrance to the mansion, his tailored suit impeccable and his smile effortlessly charming.

“Samantha,” he said, his voice soft yet confident. “I’m so glad you could make it.”

“Congratulations, Ethan,” she replied, returning his smile. “This is an amazing achievement.”

“Thank you,” he said, leading her toward the main hall. “It’s a big night for me, but having you here makes it even better.”

Samantha felt a flicker of unease at his words, but his tone was so genuine, his demeanour so composed, that she brushed it aside.

The hall was filled with guests, each of them sipping champagne and exchanging pleasantries. The warm glow of chandeliers bathed the room in golden light, and soft jazz music played in the background. Ethan introduced Samantha to a few of his business associates, always positioning himself as the gracious host.

Liam arrived an hour later, his jaw set and his shoulders tense. He didn’t care about the champagne or the small talk—his eyes scanned the room until they landed on Samantha. She was standing near Ethan, laughing softly at something he had said.

Liam’s stomach churned.

He approached them quickly, his gaze fixed on Ethan.

“Samantha,” he said, his voice tight. “Can I talk to you? Alone.”

Samantha turned, her brow furrowing. “Liam? What’s going on?”

“Please,” Liam insisted, glancing around at the crowd.

“Is everything okay?” Ethan asked, his tone calm but laced with subtle curiosity.

“No,” Liam snapped, his voice sharp. “Not that it’s any of your business.”

“Liam!” Samantha hissed, her embarrassment evident as the guests around them began to murmur.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Don’t you see what he’s doing?” Liam said, his voice rising. “This whole party, this whole act—it’s just another way for him to manipulate you.”

Samantha stared at him, her expression a mixture of shock and anger. “Liam, stop. You’re making a scene.”

“No, he’s right,” Ethan interjected smoothly, raising his hands in a placating gesture. “I wouldn’t want to come between the two of you. I only invited Samantha because I thought she’d enjoy the evening.”

Liam turned on him, his frustration boiling over. “Cut the act, Ethan. I see through you.”

Ethan’s expression didn’t falter, but the faintest trace of satisfaction flickered in his eyes.

“Liam, enough!” Samantha said, her voice trembling with anger. “What is wrong with you?”

“What’s wrong with me?” Liam repeated incredulously. “I’m trying to protect you, Samantha. He’s dangerous!”

Samantha’s jaw tightened, her voice lowering. “You’re the one acting out of control right now. You’re ruining this night for no reason.”

“This night?” Liam said, his voice dripping with disbelief. “This isn’t just a night. This is him pulling you deeper into his web, and you’re letting him!”

Samantha’s cheeks flushed with embarrassment as the guests stared, their whispers growing louder.

“I think you should leave,” she said finally, her tone cold.

Liam stared at her, stunned. “Sam, don’t do this. Don’t let him win.”

“I’m not doing anything,” Samantha said sharply. “You’re the one who’s out of line. Please, just go.”

Liam’s chest tightened, his frustration and disbelief almost choking him. He cast one last glare at Ethan before storming out, the crowd parting to let him pass.

Ethan turned to Samantha, his expression concerned. “I’m so sorry, Samantha. I didn’t mean for this to happen.”

Samantha shook her head, her arms wrapping around herself. “It’s not your fault. I just... I don’t know what’s gotten into him.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan hesitated before saying, “He’s clearly worried about you. But maybe he’s letting his emotions cloud his judgment.”

Samantha sighed, her anger giving way to exhaustion. “I don’t know what to think anymore.”

Ethan placed a gentle hand on her shoulder, his voice soft. “You don’t have to decide anything right now. Just know that I’m here for you, no matter what.”

For the first time that evening, Samantha felt a flicker of relief.

Later that night, as the guests departed and the mansion grew quiet, Ethan sat in his study, his glass of whiskey untouched on the desk.

The evening had gone exactly as planned.

He leaned back in his chair, his lips curling into a faint smile as he replayed the moment Liam had stormed out.

“Patience,” he murmured to himself. “One piece at a time.”

The photograph of Samantha on the desk caught the glow of the desk lamp, her smiling face a reminder of how close he was to finally achieving everything he wanted.

The days following the party were strained for Samantha. Liam had called multiple times, apologizing for his outburst and trying to explain his suspicions about Ethan. Despite her lingering anger, a part of her wanted to believe him.

“Sam, I’m not saying this because I’m jealous,” Liam had said during their last conversation. “I’m saying it because I know him. He hasn’t changed.”

But when Samantha thought of Ethan, she saw someone patient, kind, and supportive—someone who had been there for her during one of the most difficult periods of her life.

“Liam,” she had replied with a sigh, “I need time to figure this out. Please respect that.”

Liam had agreed, albeit reluctantly, leaving Samantha to wrestle with her thoughts alone.

One evening, as the rain tapped softly against her apartment windows, there was a knock at the door.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha opened it to find Ethan standing there, holding a bottle of wine in one hand and a small paper bag in the other. He smiled softly, his presence immediately soothing.

“I thought you might need a break,” he said, holding up the wine.

Samantha hesitated for a moment before stepping aside to let him in. “Thanks, Ethan. I could use the company.”

They settled in the living room, the dim glow of a table lamp casting a warm light over the room. Ethan poured them each a glass of wine, his movements unhurried and deliberate.

“To finding peace,” he said, raising his glass.

Samantha smiled faintly and clinked her glass against his. “To moving forward.”

The wine loosened the tension in the air as they talked about lighter topics—books, movies, and their favourite childhood memories. Ethan was careful to steer the conversation away from anything that might bring up Liam or the events of the past few days.

As the evening wore on, the bottle of wine grew emptier, and Samantha felt herself relax in a way she hadn’t in weeks.

“You know,” she said, her words slightly slurred, “you’ve changed so much, Ethan. I barely recognize the guy I knew in high school.”

Ethan smiled, his gaze steady. “I had to change, Samantha. For you.”

She blinked, caught off guard. “For me?”

Ethan leaned forward slightly, his voice low and sincere. “You were always the one person who made me believe I could be better. Everything I’ve done... it’s been to prove that I’m worthy of you.”

Samantha stared at him, her heart pounding in her chest. The room felt suddenly smaller, the air charged with an intensity she hadn’t expected.

“Ethan,” she began, her voice unsteady. “I don’t know if—”

He reached out, gently tucking a strand of hair behind her ear. “You don’t have to say anything,” he murmured. “Just let me show you how much you mean to me.”

Before she could respond, Ethan leaned in, his lips brushing against hers.

UNSEEN CHAINS

For a moment, Samantha froze, her mind spinning. But as the warmth of the wine and the weight of her emotions overtook her, she found herself leaning into the kiss.

Ethan's hands rested lightly on her waist, his touch soft yet deliberate. The kiss deepened, and for a brief moment, the chaos of the world outside seemed to disappear.

When they finally pulled apart, Samantha stared at him, her cheeks flushed and her breathing uneven.

"I—" she started, but the words failed her.

Ethan smiled softly, his hand lingering on hers. "You don't have to say anything," he whispered.

Samantha looked away, her mind a whirlwind of conflicting emotions. She couldn't deny the connection she had felt in that moment, but a part of her still held back, uncertain of what it all meant.

"Maybe I should get some rest," she said finally, her voice quiet.

Ethan nodded, his expression unreadable. "Of course. I'll see myself out."

He stood, gathering his coat as Samantha walked him to the door.

"Goodnight, Samantha," he said, his voice warm.

"Goodnight," she replied, closing the door behind him.

As Ethan stepped out into the rain, his lips curved into a slow, triumphant smile.

The evening had gone exactly as he had planned.

"Patience," he murmured to himself, the word a familiar mantra. "One piece at a time."

The rain soaked through his coat as he walked toward his car, but he didn't care. Samantha was closer than ever to being his, and nothing—especially Liam—would stand in his way.

Ethan returned to his cabin, where he pinned Samantha and their kissing photo to the wall. He opened his journal and wrote, "**One last step and she'll be mine.**"

He was just one step away from his final move to make Samantha his.

Unseen Chains

The pale morning light seeped into Samantha's apartment, casting long, soft shadows on the walls. She sat at her small dining table, nursing a lukewarm cup of coffee and staring blankly at the buzzing phone beside her. Liam's name flashed across the screen for the third time that morning, but she couldn't bring herself to answer.

The argument they'd had the previous night hung heavy in her mind. Liam's accusations about Ethan had grown more intense, his warnings more desperate. But Samantha couldn't reconcile the image of the kind, patient Ethan she knew now with the sinister picture Liam was painting.

"Ethan's dangerous," Liam had said, his voice tight with frustration. "He's manipulating you, and you can't even see it."

But Ethan had been nothing but supportive. How could Liam not see that?

Samantha sighed heavily, silencing her phone and taking a sip of her coffee. She wanted to trust Liam—she always had—but his fixation on Ethan was starting to feel like paranoia.

At his apartment, Liam stared at his bandaged side in the bathroom mirror. The wound Ethan had inflicted during the attack still burned, a sharp reminder of how close he had come to losing everything.

Liam knew he didn't have much time. Ethan was escalating, and Samantha was in more danger than ever.

Grabbing a folder filled with photos, notes, and timelines, Liam slipped it into his bag and slung it over his shoulder. He needed Detective Mills to act, and he needed her to act now.

The Carter mansion was still that morning, the kind of stillness that felt deliberate, almost staged. Ethan moved through the house with a measured calm, every step purposeful, every movement precise. The faint scent of polished wood and fresh linen filled the air as he stepped into the dining room.

The table was set with a simple breakfast: toast, eggs, and black coffee. Ethan sat at the head, his gaze distant as he methodically worked through his meal.

His thoughts were elsewhere—on Samantha, and on the fragile trust he had built between them. Liam had tried to undo his progress, but Samantha's reluctance to believe Liam had given Ethan all the confirmation he needed.

UNSEEN CHAINS

She was beginning to see him the way he had always seen her: as someone who belonged.

Finishing his breakfast, Ethan stood and adjusted the cuffs of his shirt. His phone buzzed on the counter, a text from Samantha appearing on the screen.

“I’ve been thinking about what you said. Maybe we can talk later.”

A faint smile curved his lips as he read the message. She was pulling further away from Liam, just as he had planned.

Ethan slipped his phone into his pocket and left the house, his calm demeanour masking the storm of anticipation building inside him. Tonight, everything would fall into place.

Liam locked the door to his apartment, his bag slung over his good shoulder. The pain from his wound had dulled slightly but remained a constant reminder of Ethan’s violent intentions.

He walked briskly toward the stairwell, the folder of evidence pressing heavily against his side. He didn’t have time to waste.

But as he turned the corner, his steps faltered.

Ethan was there, leaning casually against the railing at the top of the stairs. His suit was impeccable, his posture relaxed, but his eyes betrayed a sharp, dangerous focus.

“Liam,” Ethan greeted, his tone calm and cordial.

“What the hell are you doing here?” Liam demanded, his voice low and tense.

“I wanted to talk,” Ethan replied, pushing off the railing and taking a slow step forward. “You’ve been a nuisance, Liam. I think it’s time we settle this.”

Liam stepped back, his grip tightening on the strap of his bag. “Stay away from me,” he said, his voice shaking with anger and fear.

Ethan’s faint smile faded, his expression growing cold. “I’ve given you every chance to back off, but you just don’t know when to stop.”

Before Liam could react, Ethan lunged.

Ethan lunged forward, his movements quick and precise, like a predator striking its prey. Liam barely had time to react before Ethan’s shoulder slammed into his chest, driving him backward against the cold wall of the stairwell.

UNSEEN CHAINS

The impact knocked the air from Liam's lungs, his bag slipping from his shoulder and hitting the ground with a heavy thud.

Ethan's hand gripped the front of Liam's jacket, pinning him in place. His face was unnervingly calm, his voice low and steady. "You've been in my way for too long, Liam. Samantha doesn't need you. She never did."

Liam struggled against Ethan's grip, his hands clawing at the fabric of his jacket. "You're insane," he spat, his voice hoarse with panic.

Ethan tilted his head slightly, his lips curling into a faint, almost pitying smile. "No, Liam. I'm focused. Something you'll never understand."

Before Liam could respond, Ethan's other hand came up, the glint of a knife catching the dim light of the hallway. The blade slashed downward, slicing across Liam's side—a deliberate, calculated cut.

Liam cried out, the pain searing through him as he tried to push Ethan away. Blood soaked through his shirt, the warmth of it spreading quickly.

"You should have walked away," Ethan said, his tone devoid of emotion. He stepped back slightly, letting Liam slump against the wall.

Liam's vision blurred, his legs trembling as he fought to stay upright. He pressed his hand to the wound, trying to stem the bleeding, but his strength was fading fast.

Ethan crouched down in front of him, his expression eerily composed. "I'm not going to kill you, Liam. That would be too easy. I want you to see what happens when you try to take what's mine."

Liam glared at him, his breaths shallow and ragged. "She'll never be yours," he managed to say, his voice weak but defiant.

Ethan's smile widened, his eyes narrowing. "We'll see about that."

He stood, wiping the blade clean on Liam's jacket before slipping it back into his pocket. "I'd say take care of yourself, but... well, that's unlikely."

Ethan turned and walked away, his footsteps echoing down the hall as Liam slid to the floor, his body wracked with pain.

Liam didn't know how long he lay there, the edges of his vision darkening as blood pooled beneath him. Every movement sent fresh waves of agony through his side, but he refused to give in.

UNSEEN CHAINS

With trembling hands, he reached for his phone, pulling it from his pocket. He fumbled with the screen, his blood-slicked fingers struggling to press the right buttons.

Finally, he managed to call Detective Mills.

“Mills,” he rasped when she answered.

“Liam?” her voice was sharp with concern. “What’s wrong?”

“It’s Ethan,” Liam said, his words slurred and uneven. “He attacked me. He’s... he’s going after Samantha.”

“Where are you?” Mills demanded.

Liam gave her his location before the phone slipped from his hand, clattering to the ground. His strength was nearly gone, his body growing colder by the second.

Detective Mills gripped her phone tightly, her pulse racing as Liam’s strained voice echoed in her ear.

“Liam,” she said firmly, her tone laced with urgency. “Stay awake. I’m on my way.”

But there was no response. The line went silent, leaving Mills staring at her phone for a brief moment before springing into action.

She grabbed her coat and keys, barking orders to the officers nearby. “I need a car and medical backup at West’s address now. Move!”

Her gut told her this wasn’t just an attack. It was a warning. And if Liam’s cryptic message was true, Samantha could already be in danger.

Liam lay slumped against the wall of the stairwell, his breaths shallow and uneven. Every ounce of his strength had been drained, his blood pooling around him in a dark, sticky mess.

The pain was blinding, but his thoughts remained focused on Samantha.

She has to know, he thought, his mind slipping in and out of consciousness. **She has to get away from him.**

His phone buzzed faintly on the floor beside him, a text notification lighting up the cracked screen. He turned his head slowly, his vision blurring as he tried to focus on the words.

It was a message from Mills.

“Hold on, Liam. I’m coming.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

A faint, bitter smile tugged at the corner of his lips. He could only hope it wasn't already too late.

At Samantha's apartment, the sound of knocking jolted her from her thoughts. She set her mug down and stood, her heart skipping as she approached the door.

When she peeked through the peephole, she saw Ethan standing there, his expression calm but unreadable.

Samantha hesitated before opening the door slightly. "Ethan? What are you doing here?"

"I was worried about you," Ethan said softly, his tone filled with concern. "You didn't answer my messages, and after everything with Liam, I thought you might need someone to talk to."

Samantha opened the door fully, stepping aside to let him in. "I'm fine," she said, though her voice wavered slightly.

Ethan stepped inside, his gaze sweeping the room briefly before settling on her. "I just wanted to make sure you were okay," he said, his smile faint but reassuring.

She nodded, wrapping her arms around herself. "It's just been a lot lately. Liam keeps—"

"I know," Ethan interrupted gently. "He's been... struggling. But I'm here for you, Samantha. Always."

His words were soothing, his presence steady. For a moment, Samantha felt herself relax, the tension in her shoulders easing.

"Thank you," she said, offering him a small smile.

Ethan nodded, his own smile widening slightly. "Of course. That's what friends do."

Detective Mills arrived at Liam's apartment building within minutes, her car screeching to a halt in front of the entrance. Two officers followed close behind, their radios crackling as they confirmed backup was en route.

She ran up the stairs, her heart pounding as she reached the blood-streaked stairwell.

"Liam!" Mills called, spotting him slumped against the wall. She dropped to her knees beside him, her hands hovering over his injuries as she assessed the damage.

"Liam, can you hear me?"

UNSEEN CHAINS

His eyelids fluttered open, his breaths shallow. “Mills...”

“I’m here,” she said firmly, her voice steady despite the panic rising in her chest. “You’re going to be okay. Ambulance is on the way.”

Liam’s hand twitched weakly, his blood-slicked fingers brushing against her coat. “Samantha,” he rasped. “He’s with her. You have to stop him.”

Mills clenched her jaw, her mind racing. She motioned for the officers to move quickly. “Get a trace on Ethan Carter. Now.”

Turning back to Liam, she gripped his hand gently. “Stay with me, Liam. We’re going to get her.”

At Samantha’s apartment, Ethan sat across from her on the couch, his posture relaxed but his mind racing.

She looked vulnerable, her defenses lowered just enough for him to slip deeper into her life. He could see it in the way her hands trembled slightly as she reached for her mug, in the way her voice softened when she thanked him.

“You’ve been through so much,” Ethan said, his tone soothing. “You deserve peace, Samantha. You deserve someone who can take care of you.”

Her gaze flicked to his, her eyes searching his face. “Sometimes I feel like everything’s falling apart,” she admitted, her voice barely above a whisper.

Ethan leaned forward slightly, his expression earnest. “It doesn’t have to. I’m here. I’ll always be here.”

For a moment, Samantha felt a flicker of warmth, a connection she hadn’t expected. But then her phone buzzed on the table, breaking the moment.

Ethan’s eyes flicked to the screen, where Liam’s name lit up.

“Do you want to answer that?” Ethan asked, his tone calm but with a hint of something darker.

Samantha hesitated, reaching for the phone.

The air in the apartment felt heavy as Samantha sat on the couch, her phone resting in her lap. Ethan had just left, his calm but intense demeanor still lingering in her mind. She couldn’t shake the uneasy feeling that something wasn’t right.

Her phone buzzed again, and this time it was a call. She glanced at the screen, her heart skipping a beat when she saw the name: **Detective Mills.**

Samantha hesitated before answering, her voice tentative. “Hello?”

UNSEEN CHAINS

“Samantha, it’s Detective Mills,” came the firm, familiar voice. “Are you somewhere safe right now?”

“What? Yes, I’m at home,” Samantha replied, confused by the question.

Mills’s tone sharpened. “Good. Is Ethan Carter there with you?”

Samantha’s pulse quickened. “No, he just left. Why?”

“I need you to listen carefully,” Mills said. “Liam was attacked earlier. He’s hurt, but he told us everything before we found him.”

Samantha’s hand trembled, her voice rising in alarm. “What do you mean he was attacked? Who did this?”

“Samantha…” Mills paused, as though choosing her words carefully. “It was Ethan. He’s dangerous. Liam gave us enough to reopen our investigation into him. You need to stay away from him.”

The words felt like a punch to her chest. “Ethan? No, that can’t be true. He wouldn’t—he’s not like that.”

Before Mills could respond, another voice came through the line. “Sam, it’s Liam.”

Her breath hitched. “Liam?”

“Samantha,” Liam’s voice was weak but insistent, the strain of his injuries evident. “Ethan is dangerous. He’s the one who attacked me. He’s obsessed with you, and he’ll do whatever it takes to keep you. You need to get out of there.”

Samantha shook her head, her mind reeling. “I… I don’t understand.”

“Everything he’s done—the stalking, the manipulation, the lies—it’s all about controlling you,” Liam said, his voice trembling with desperation. “He doesn’t care about anyone else. Please, just trust me this once.”

Samantha stared at the phone, her heart pounding. “Liam, are you sure it was him? This doesn’t make any sense—”

“It was him,” Liam interrupted. “I swear to you, Samantha. You have to believe me.”

Mills spoke again, her tone urgent. “Samantha, we’re on our way to you now. Stay on the line until we get there—”

Suddenly, a shadow moved behind her.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha turned, but she was too late. Ethan was there, his expression dark and terrifying.

He grabbed the phone from her hand, his grip like iron. “Thank you for the update, Detective,” Ethan said into the phone, his voice calm but dripping with venom.

“Ethan!” Mills’s sharp voice crackled through the speaker. “Don’t do anything stupid—”

With a flick of his hand, Ethan ended the call and tossed the phone across the room. It hit the wall with a crack and fell to the floor.

Samantha backed away, her breath coming in short, panicked gasps. “Ethan... what are you doing?”

“You’ve been listening to the wrong people, Samantha,” he said, his tone soft but menacing. “I’m the only one who truly understands you. The only one who can protect you.”

“Stay away from me,” she said, her voice trembling.

Ethan took a step closer, his eyes fixed on hers. “I don’t want to hurt you, Samantha. I never wanted that. But you’ve left me no choice.”

Before she could scream, Ethan lunged. His hand clamped over her mouth as he pressed something cold and sharp against her neck—a damp cloth soaked with an acrid, chemical smell.

Samantha struggled, her limbs flailing as she tried to fight him off. But the fumes overwhelmed her senses, her vision blurring as darkness closed in around her.

Ethan caught her limp body as she fell, cradling her gently. His expression softened, a twisted semblance of tenderness crossing his face.

“You’ll thank me one day,” he murmured, brushing a strand of hair from her face. “You’ll see that this is the only way.”

He carried her out of the apartment, the city lights casting eerie shadows on the walls as he disappeared into the night.

The night air was cool and heavy as Ethan carried Samantha’s unconscious body out of the apartment building. His steps were deliberate, his grip firm but gentle. The streets were quiet, the occasional flicker of a streetlight casting long shadows across the pavement.

UNSEEN CHAINS

Here at Samantha's apartment, Detective Mills's car screeched to a halt in front of the building. She stepped out, her sharp gaze scanning the area as officers filed in behind her.

Inside, the faint smell of chloroform lingered, mingling with the acrid scent of a smashed phone battery. Mills crouched near the shattered device on the floor, picking it up carefully.

"Chloroform," one of the officers said, holding up a soaked cloth found near the couch.

Mills's jaw tightened as she straightened, her voice sharp. "He took her. She's not here, but he was."

Behind her, Liam stumbled into the apartment, his face pale and drawn.

"Where is she?" he demanded, his voice raw and strained.

Mills turned, her tone urgent but firm. "She's gone, and we're going to find her. Do you have any idea where he might have taken her?"

Liam racked his brain, panic flickering in his eyes. "He's smart. He wouldn't take her somewhere obvious."

"Then think," Mills urged. "Somewhere private, out of sight. Did he ever talk about a place he'd go to be alone?"

Liam shook his head, his frustration evident. "No. Ethan was secretive about everything. But... he liked isolation. If he had somewhere like that, he wouldn't tell anyone."

Mills narrowed her eyes, her mind working through the possibilities. "Then we start with what we can track. Get a trace on Carter's car," she ordered the officers. "Focus on isolated areas—wooded trails, abandoned properties, and anywhere off the grid."

An officer nodded. "We'll start with his family's registered assets and known hangouts."

Mills glanced at Liam. "We'll find her. But if he's gone somewhere that only he knows..." She didn't finish the sentence, her jaw tightening.

"We don't have much time," Liam said, his voice thick with desperation.

"Exactly," Mills replied. She motioned to her team. "Expand the search radius. Let's move."

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan placed her carefully in the passenger seat of his car, adjusting her head so it rested against the seat. For a moment, he simply stared at her, a mixture of triumph and tenderness in his gaze.

“This is for us,” he whispered, closing the door softly before getting into the driver’s seat.

The drive to the cabin was silent except for the steady hum of the engine. Ethan’s mind raced, envisioning the life he had meticulously planned. A life where Samantha would finally see him for who he truly was, where she would understand the depths of his love and devotion.

The cabin was quiet, its crooked frame bathed in the dim glow of the lantern Ethan had lit upon arrival. He carried Samantha inside, her body limp in his arms.

The door creaked as he pushed it open, revealing a space that was both sparse and deeply unsettling. Photographs of Samantha were pinned to the walls, interspersed with crude sketches of her face. A small table was cluttered with items he had collected over the years: strands of her hair, dried flowers he’d taken from places she’d been, and a faded scarf he had stolen long ago.

Ethan laid Samantha gently on a worn mattress in the corner of the room, brushing her hair away from her face.

“This is our sanctuary,” he whispered, his voice soft but trembling with emotion. “No one can hurt us here.”

He stepped back, his gaze sweeping the room. Everything was in place. This was the moment he had envisioned for so long.

Behind him, Samantha stirred slightly, a soft groan escaping her lips.

Ethan turned immediately, his expression softening. “Samantha?” he said, crouching beside her. “It’s okay. You’re safe now.”

Her eyelids fluttered, but she didn’t wake fully. Ethan reached out, his hand grazing her cheek.

“You’ll see,” he murmured. “You’ll see that this is the way it was always meant to be.”

Back at the precinct, a crackle came through Mills’s radio.

“Detective Mills, we’ve got a lead,” the dispatcher said. “Carter’s car was spotted near the woods off Route 17. Units are en route now.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Mills grabbed the radio, her voice sharp. “We’re on our way. Hold the perimeter and wait for backup.”

She turned to Liam, who was sitting on the edge of the couch, his breathing laboured.

“Liam, this is it,” she said. “We’re going to find her.”

Liam stood, his face pale but resolute. “I’m coming with you.”

Mills hesitated for a moment before nodding. “Let’s move.”

The faint light of the lantern flickered, casting long shadows across the cabin’s warped walls. Samantha’s head throbbed as her senses slowly returned. The smell of damp wood and the faint, metallic tang of old rust filled her nose, stirring a sense of dread deep within her.

She opened her eyes to a dimly lit room. It took a moment for the blurry shapes around her to come into focus: photographs of her pinned to the walls, crude sketches, and locks of her own hair twisted into strange ornaments.

Her breath hitched, panic flooding her veins.

“You’re awake,” Ethan’s voice came from behind her, soft and calm.

Samantha turned sharply, her heart pounding as she saw him standing by the table. His hands were busy arranging items, his movements steady and purposeful.

“Where am I?” she demanded, her voice shaky.

Ethan turned to her, his expression serene. “Our home,” he said simply. “A place where no one can hurt us. Where we can finally be together.”

Samantha struggled to sit up, her limbs still heavy from the lingering effects of the chloroform. “Ethan... this isn’t right. You have to let me go.”

Ethan stepped closer, kneeling beside her. His eyes were wide, almost childlike, as he shook his head. “No, Samantha. Don’t you see? Out there, the world is full of pain and lies. But here, we can be happy. Just us.”

Her chest tightened, fear clawing at her throat. “This isn’t happiness, Ethan. This is—this is sick.”

His face twisted briefly with hurt, but he quickly composed himself. “You don’t mean that,” he said softly. “You’re just scared. But you’ll see. In time, you’ll understand.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Samantha's gaze darted around the room, searching for an escape. The door was behind him, slightly ajar, but it might as well have been miles away.

She swallowed hard, trying to steady her voice. "Ethan, if you really care about me, you'll let me go."

His expression hardened, the calmness giving way to something colder. "I do care about you. That's why I can't let you leave. You belong here, Samantha. With me."

Outside the woods, Detective Mills's car screeched to a halt near the edge of the dirt road. The tires kicked up gravel as she and Liam stepped out, followed by a convoy of officers.

"This way," Mills said, motioning toward the faint tire tracks leading into the forest.

Liam stumbled slightly, clutching his side as he pushed forward. "We have to hurry," he said, his voice strained.

Mills nodded, her flashlight cutting through the thick underbrush as they followed the trail.

Inside the cabin, Samantha made her move.

While Ethan was distracted, she grabbed the edge of the mattress and hauled herself to her feet. Her head swam, but adrenaline drove her forward.

"Sam—wait!" Ethan's voice rose in alarm as she bolted toward the door.

She didn't look back, her bare feet slamming against the uneven floor as she reached for the handle.

But before she could pull the door open, Ethan's hand caught her wrist.

"No!" he shouted, spinning her around with more force than he intended.

Samantha lost her balance, her body crashing into the corner of the table. The edge caught her side, and she gasped as pain ripped through her. She stumbled, her legs giving way beneath her.

"Samantha!" Ethan cried, dropping to his knees beside her. His hands hovered over her, unsure of what to do. Blood began to pool beneath her, staining the wooden floor.

Her breaths were shallow, her eyes wide with fear and pain.

UNSEEN CHAINS

“I didn’t mean to—” Ethan’s voice cracked, his hands trembling as he tried to stem the bleeding. “I didn’t mean to hurt you.”

Samantha’s lips moved, but no sound came out. Her eyes fluttered shut, and her body went limp.

“No,” Ethan whispered, his voice breaking. “No, no, no.”

His mind spiraled, a chaotic storm of grief and denial. He clutched her lifeless body, rocking back and forth as tears streamed down his face.

Then, something shifted.

A twisted calm settled over him as his gaze drifted to the shrine on the wall. Slowly, he laid her down and stood, his expression eerily serene.

“You’ll always be with me,” he murmured, retrieving a knife from the table. “I’ll make sure of it.”

What followed was a grotesque act born of obsession. Ethan worked with precision, his mind fixated on preserving Samantha in the only way he could imagine. He removed her skin carefully, treating it like a sacred relic.

When he finished, he draped the skin over the shrine, his hands trembling as he stepped back to admire his work.

“She’s here,” he whispered, his voice reverent. “She’ll never leave me now.”

Outside, Mills and Liam stumbled upon Ethan’s car parked haphazardly near the edge of the woods.

“He’s here,” Mills said, her tone grim. She motioned for the officers to fan out.

Liam’s heart pounded as they approached the cabin. The faint glow of a lantern seeped through the cracks in the walls, and the sound of Ethan’s voice reached them—soft, almost like a lullaby.

Mills signaled for silence as they surrounded the cabin. She stepped forward, her gun drawn, and kicked the door open.

“Ethan Carter! Step away!”

Inside, Ethan stood motionless, his back to them. The shrine loomed before him, Samantha’s skin stretched across it like a macabre tapestry.

Liam froze, his eyes widening in horror. “No,” he whispered.

Ethan turned slowly, his expression peaceful. “You’re too late,” he said softly. “She’s with me now.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Mills advanced, her gun trained on him. “Ethan, put your hands up. Now.”

Ethan didn’t resist as the officers grabbed him, his calm demeanour unnerving everyone in the room.

“She’s happy now,” he murmured as they dragged him away. “We’re finally together.”

Liam collapsed to his knees, his body shaking as he stared at the shrine.

Ethan didn’t resist as the officers dragged him out of the cabin. His gaze remained distant, unfocused, as though his mind was somewhere far beyond the chaotic scene around him.

Mills followed closely behind, her jaw clenched as she scanned the grotesque shrine that dominated the room. The flickering lantern light made the scene all the more horrific: Samantha’s skin stretched taut, her likeness frozen in the macabre display.

Liam stood frozen near the doorway, his body trembling as he stared at the shrine. His mind struggled to process what he was seeing, a wave of nausea rising in his chest.

“Liam,” Mills said firmly, stepping in front of him and placing a steadying hand on his shoulder. “You don’t need to see this. Go outside.”

But Liam shook his head, his voice barely a whisper. “I—she—”

Mills squeezed his shoulder, her tone softening. “There’s nothing you can do for her now. Let us handle this.”

Reluctantly, Liam turned and stumbled out of the cabin, his breaths coming in shallow gasps as the cool night air hit his face. He sank to his knees just outside the door, his hands gripping the dirt as sobs wracked his body.

Ethan sat silently in the back of the police car, his expression serene as the blue and red lights reflected off the windows.

“She’s safe now,” he murmured to himself, his voice barely audible. “We’re together.”

Mills watched him from a few feet away, her arms crossed tightly over her chest. She couldn’t fathom the level of delusion required for a man to commit such an act and still appear calm.

“Detective?” an officer called, breaking her thoughts. “We’ve cleared the cabin. Forensics is on their way.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

Mills nodded, her gaze fixed on Ethan. “Make sure he’s transported securely,” she said. “I don’t want him out of our sight.”

The officer nodded and moved to the car.

Liam sat on the steps of the cabin, his face buried in his hands as he tried to piece together everything that had happened. Samantha was gone. The woman he loved, the person he had fought so hard to protect, was gone.

Mills approached quietly, sitting beside him. For a moment, neither of them spoke. The sound of crickets and the distant chatter of officers filled the silence.

“She trusted him,” Liam said finally, his voice hollow. “Even after everything, she trusted him.”

Mills nodded, her tone steady. “People like Ethan are manipulators. They find ways to twist the truth, to make themselves seem like the victim.”

Liam looked up at her, his eyes red and filled with grief. “How do you stop someone like that? How do you stop someone so... broken?”

Mills exhaled, her gaze distant. “Sometimes you don’t. Sometimes all you can do is limit the damage.”

Liam’s hands clenched into fists as he stared out at the dark woods. “It wasn’t enough. It’ll never be enough.”

Ethan sat in his cell, the cold walls of the police station closing in around him. The fluorescent light above flickered faintly, casting a sterile glow on his face.

But he didn’t notice.

In his mind, he was somewhere else—back at the cabin, sitting beside Samantha. She was smiling at him, her laughter echoing softly in his ears.

“We’re together now,” Ethan whispered, his lips curling into a faint smile. “Just like I promised.”

His hands twitched slightly, the sensation of her skin still lingering on his fingertips.

From the other side of the bars, an officer watched him carefully, unease etched across his face.

“What’s he doing?” the officer muttered to a colleague.

“Talking to himself,” the other replied. “Keeps saying her name.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

The first officer shook his head, his expression grim. “That guy’s not just a killer. He’s a whole new kind of sick.”

Back in the woods, the cabin was sealed off, the scene preserved for investigators. But its shadow lingered in the minds of everyone who had stepped inside.

For Liam, it was a scar that would never fade. And for Ethan, it was the shrine to the obsession that had consumed him entirely.

The trial of Ethan Carter was the talk of the nation. Media outlets painted him as a monster, his face plastered across every screen. Terms like “obsessive psychopathy” and “disturbing delusions” echoed in every headline.

But inside the courtroom, Ethan remained calm, his demeanour unnervingly composed.

Liam sat in the gallery, his hands gripping the edge of the bench as he listened to the prosecution recount the grisly details of Samantha’s death. Each word was a dagger to his heart, the weight of his failure crushing him anew.

“The defendant,” the prosecutor said, his voice ringing through the silent room, “deliberately abducted Samantha Hayes, confining her in a location so remote that her chances of rescue were almost nonexistent. His obsession culminated in a grotesque and inhumane act that defies comprehension.”

Ethan’s lawyer attempted to argue that he was mentally unfit to stand trial, presenting medical evaluations that described his delusions and obsessive behaviors. But the prosecutor countered with Ethan’s meticulous planning, his ability to evade suspicion for so long, and the chilling evidence of his shrine.

Liam felt a surge of anger as Ethan’s lawyer described him as a “victim of his own mind.” He clenched his fists, his teeth grinding as he struggled to keep his composure.

“He’s no victim,” Liam muttered under his breath. “Samantha was the victim.”

Mills, sitting beside him, placed a hand on his shoulder. “He’ll get what he deserves,” she said quietly.

When the jury returned with their verdict, the tension in the courtroom was palpable.

“Ethan Carter,” the judge said, his voice steady, “you have been found guilty of the murder of Samantha Hayes, the murder of James Walker, and the attempted murder of Liam West. You are hereby sentenced to life imprisonment without the possibility of parole.”

UNSEEN CHAINS

There was a collective sigh of relief from the gallery, but Liam felt no comfort. Samantha was still gone. Justice, while served, felt hollow.

Ethan remained silent as the sentence was read, his expression unreadable. As he was led away in handcuffs, he turned his head slightly, his eyes briefly meeting Liam's.

"She's waiting for me," Ethan said softly, his voice calm. "She'll always be with me."

Liam stared back at him, a chill running down his spine.

Months passed, but the wounds left by Ethan's actions lingered like ghosts.

Liam visited Samantha's grave often, leaving fresh flowers and sitting in silence. He replayed their last conversations in his mind, wondering if there was anything he could have done differently.

"She trusted him," he said aloud one day, his voice breaking. "And I let her."

Mills joined him occasionally, offering quiet support. "You couldn't have known," she said once, her tone firm but kind. "People like Ethan... they hide in plain sight. They manipulate. This wasn't your fault."

But Liam couldn't shake the weight of guilt. He carried it with him, a constant reminder of what had been lost.

In his cell, Ethan sat on the edge of his cot, his hands folded neatly in his lap. The walls were bare, the small window letting in only a sliver of light.

But in his mind, the cabin was alive. He could hear the crackle of the lantern, smell the damp wood, feel the presence of Samantha all around him.

He smiled faintly, his gaze unfocused.

"She's waiting for me," he whispered to himself, his voice steady. "We're together, even now."

For Ethan, the prison walls were meaningless. In his twisted reality, Samantha was still with him, her laughter echoing in his ears, her skin preserved as a token of their eternal bond.

Outside, life moved on, but the scars left by Ethan's madness remained. Liam carried Samantha's memory with him, a painful reminder of the love that had been taken too soon.

And Ethan, lost in his delusions, remained forever chained to the twisted version of love he had created—an unseen chain binding him to his darkness.

UNSEEN CHAINS

He sat on his cot, the faint smile never leaving his lips. His fingers traced patterns on the cold concrete walls, as if drawing invisible outlines of her face.

The fluorescent light in Ethan's cell flickered faintly, casting pale shadows across the cold, gray walls. Ethan sat on his cot, his posture upright, his hands folded neatly in his lap. His gaze was fixed on the far corner of the room, his lips curling into a faint smile.

To the guards who passed by, Ethan was a quiet, docile inmate. But within the confines of his mind, he was no prisoner.

Samantha stood in the corner of the cell, radiant as ever. Her hair fell in soft waves over her shoulders, her dress flowing like silk. Her smile was warm and genuine, her eyes filled with affection. She crossed the room slowly, her every step graceful, until she stood right in front of him.

"You came back," Ethan whispered, his voice trembling with emotion.

Samantha knelt in front of him, her hands resting lightly on his knees. "Of course, Ethan," she said softly. "How could I not? Everything you've done... it's brought us together."

Ethan's breath hitched, his chest tightening with joy. "I knew you'd understand. I knew you'd see why I had to do it."

She smiled, her fingers brushing lightly against his cheek. "You did it all for us. You showed me what real love is—how far someone can go to protect what they care about most."

Ethan leaned into her touch, his eyes glistening. "They didn't understand. They tried to take you from me, to keep us apart. But I didn't let them."

Samantha nodded, her gaze steady and full of admiration. "And now, they can't. It's just you and me, Ethan. No one else matters anymore."

"They said I was wrong," Ethan said, his voice rising slightly as his hands gripped hers. "They said I was sick. But I knew—knew—this was the only way to keep you safe."

Samantha's smile widened, her tone soothing. "You weren't wrong, Ethan. You were brave. You did what no one else would have done."

The words filled Ethan's heart with a warmth he hadn't felt in years. He pulled her hands to his chest, holding them tightly. "I knew you'd see it. I knew you'd understand."

"I do," she whispered, leaning closer. "And I'll stay with you. Always."

UNSEEN CHAINS

From the hallway, the guards exchanged uneasy glances as they listened to Ethan's voice echoing softly from within the cell.

"Who's he talking to?" one asked, peering through the small window.

"Her," the other replied grimly. "Always her."

Inside, Ethan's conversation with Samantha continued, his tone full of affection and reverence.

"I'll never let you go," Ethan said, his voice trembling with emotion. "We'll always be together."

"Forever," Samantha replied, her smile unwavering.

Over time, Ethan's delusions deepened. The cell no longer felt like a prison to him—it became a sanctuary. The gray walls transformed into the warm wooden panels of the cabin, the harsh light overhead softened into the glow of a lantern.

Samantha was always with him, her presence constant and comforting. They laughed together, talked about the future, and dreamed of the life they would build once they were free of the outside world.

"They'll never understand us," Ethan said one night, his hand resting over hers.

"They don't need to," Samantha replied. "This is our world, Ethan. It's perfect."

The guards began to avoid his cell, unsettled by the sound of his conversations.

"I don't know how he does it," one guard muttered. "It's like he really thinks she's in there with him."

"Let him," another said with a shrug. "He's not hurting anyone now. Just a crazy man rotting in his own head."

But Ethan didn't feel like he was rotting. To him, every moment with Samantha was real. He could feel her touch, hear her laughter, and see her smile as clearly as the day he first met her.

One evening, as the sun set outside the prison, Ethan sat on the floor of his cell, his back against the wall. Samantha sat beside him, her head resting on his shoulder.

"I've never been happier," Ethan murmured.

Samantha smiled, her eyes closing as she leaned into him. "That's because we're finally where we're meant to be. Together."

UNSEEN CHAINS

Ethan's eyes closed, his breathing slow and steady. For the first time, he felt at peace.

"We'll never be apart," he said softly.

"Never," Samantha whispered.

Years later, the cabin stood abandoned, the forest slowly reclaiming it. The walls sagged under the weight of decay, vines snaking through the broken windows. But inside, the memories lingered like shadows, refusing to fade.

Liam returned to the site for the first time since Samantha's death. The building loomed before him, a monument to everything he had lost.

He stepped inside, the floor creaking beneath his weight. The air was thick with mildew and the faint scent of charred wood. Though the shrine had been taken as evidence long ago, the weight of Ethan's obsession still hung in the space.

From his backpack, Liam pulled a small wooden box. Inside were Samantha's belongings—her favorite scarf, the faded photo of them together, and a small journal she had kept during her college years.

Liam placed the box in the center of the room, carefully arranging the photograph on top. The edges of the photo curled slightly in the damp air, but Samantha's smile remained intact.

"This is where it ends," Liam said softly, his voice steady despite the tears streaming down his face. "You deserve peace, Sam."

He struck a match and tossed it onto the box. The flames caught quickly, licking up the edges of the photograph and spreading across the floor. Liam stepped back, watching as the fire consumed the remnants of Ethan's twisted world.

The heat drove him outside, where he stood in silence, the cabin burning behind him. The flames climbed higher, illuminating the dark forest as the building collapsed in on itself.

For the first time in years, Liam felt a weight lift from his chest.

As the fire died down, a faint breeze stirred the ashes, carrying them into the night.

Samantha was free.

UNSEEN CHAINS

